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Leadership change unfolds in Karnataka

Siddaramaiah rejects Rajya Sabha offer, says he prefers remaining in the State to fight communal forces

DEEPAK KUMAR JHA
■ Bengaluru/New Delhi

Ending months of speculation about a leadership change following an intense power tussle with his deputy, DK Shivakumar for the coveted post, Congress leader Siddaramaiah on Thursday resigned as Chief Minister of Karnataka. Announcing his resignation at a packed press conference, the 77-year-old leader asserted that he was demitting office with a clean conscience and thanked his party brass for providing him an opportunity to serve the people for two terms.

Since Karnataka Governor Thaawarchand Gehlot was not in the State Capital, Siddaramaiah handed over his resignation letter to the Governor's special secretary.

"I have tendered my resignation from the Chief Minister's post. I am confident the Governor would accept my resignation as per Constitutional provisions," he said.

Siddaramaiah said he had stated repeatedly that he would resign whenever the high command instructed him.

Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah being greeted by Deputy CM DK Shivakumar at the CM's official residence in Bengaluru on Thursday PTI

Shivakumar reached Delhi on Thursday night to meet the Congress high command, hours after Siddaramaiah announced his resignation. Later Siddaramaiah too left for the national Capital to meet the Congress leadership.

Flanked by his successor Shivakumar during the press conference, Siddaramaiah made it clear that he will continue in remain active politics. Noting that the Congress leadership offered him a Rajya Sabha ticket, he said he declined it as he preferred active politics in Karnataka "to fight against communal forces till my last breath".

"The high command directed me two days ago to step down, and accordingly, I have submitted my resignation today. I got the opportunity to serve the people of Karnataka twice, for which I thank Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge," Siddaramaiah added.

Asked whether the high command exerted pressure on him, he said, "What pressure? I voluntarily resigned immediately after they asked me to." He underscored that he was demitting office with clean conscience.

Siddaramaiah hit out at the BJP, especially Prime Minister Narendra Modi for allegedly "spreading misinformation" about the five guarantees of his Government and that its implementation would make Karnataka bankrupt.

Siddaramaiah noted that his Government made 550 promises, of which 300 have been fulfilled so far including the five pre-poll guarantees. The BJP alleged that such guarantees could not be implemented. It claimed that the State would go bankrupt and that the treasury would become empty.

Party sources said discussions regarding the selection of the new Congress Legislature Party leader, the composition of the new ministry and other organisational matters, including the Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee president's post currently held by Shivakumar, were likely to take place during the Delhi visit.

Earlier in the day, during a breakfast meeting hosted at his residence for Cabinet colleagues, Siddaramaiah informed ministers of his decision also to step down and indicated that Shivakumar would succeed him, in line with directions from the Congress high command, according to several ministers who attended the meeting.

Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan chairing a meeting to assess the preparedness for NEET-UG re-examination PTI

Defence forces may guard NEET-UG retest operations

DEEPAK KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

The National Testing Agency (NTA) is taking no chances in the conduct of NEET entrance rescheduled on June 21and is mulling over the use of defence as well as the paramilitary forces for transportation of question papers and also providing security. Sources said a final call in this regard will be taken after a discussion with Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who is personally monitoring the preparations for the June 21 retest.

"Use of defence and paramilitary forces will act as a deterrent factor for any unscrupulous elements and they will not even think of any kind of sabotage. Government is serious as this concern future and career of lakhs of students. We need to repose the trust amongst all the stakeholders," said a top education ministry official.

The NTA is following a protocol in preparation for the question papers similar to the Union Budget. All people involved in the preparation till printing of the question papers have to be confined to the confidential unit with no access to smartphones until the conduct of the entrance test.

In this regard, a meeting at Defence Minister Rajnath Singh's residence was held, which was attended by Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, Communications Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia, National Testing Agency (NTA) DG Abhishek Singh, defence and education ministry officials and representatives from the Department of Posts were present. Earlier in the day, Pradhan chaired a high-level meeting along with former Indian Space Research Organisation Chairman Dr K Radhakrishnan. Dr Radhakrishnan is the Chairman of the High Powered Steering Committee constituted to monitor implementation of recommendations on NTA.

Besides the paramilitary force units like CRPF, CISF, ITBP could be used in providing security apparatus at the examination centres as well as all NEET documents related logistics. Extensive dialogue between the State and UT administration is open for better coordination between the State and Paramilitary units.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

The ByStander

BJP rejigs State units ahead of crucial polls

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

BJP on Thursday announced a fresh round of organisational appointments across several States. Union minister Harsh Malhotra was appointed as the new party chief of Delhi BJP unit and senior leader Kewal Singh Dhillon as the president of its Punjab unit. Malhotra replaces Virendra Sachdeva as Delhi unit chief, while Dhillon succeeds Sunil Jakhar in Punjab.

In another significant change, Abhishek Debroy was appointed the new BJP president for Tripura, replacing Rajib Bhattacharjee who remained party chief since 2022, while Archana Gupta was named the party's Haryana unit chief, replacing Mohan Lal Badoli as the State president.

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta offers sweets to new president of BJP's Delhi unit, Harsh Malhotra PTI

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Pradhan promises action on OSM lapses

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Thursday addressed the controversy surrounding On Screen Marking (OSM) for class 12 examination results, saying he takes responsibility, and assuring students and parents that "no one will be spared" if irregularities are found in the evaluation process.

"I take responsibility. It will be fixed," Pradhan said after chairing a high-level review meeting at the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) headquarters. Pradhan directed officials to take necessary measures to ensure that issues faced by students are resolved in a timely and transparent manner.

PTI

The meeting was attended by School Education Secretary Sanjay Kumar, CBSE Chairperson Rahul Singh, directors of IIT Madras and IIT Kanpur, and senior officials from the Ministry of Education, and others, a ministry statement read.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

NTA REVISES CUET DATES

New Delhi: The National Testing Agency (NTA) has released revised examination dates and admit cards for the Common University Entrance Test (CUET) 2026 for admissions to undergraduate courses that were rescheduled from May 28 owing to Eid-ul-Azha. According to the NTA, the examinations will now be conducted on May 31, June 6 and June 7. The NTA said that admit cards for candidates appearing for the test on May 31 have been released and they can be downloaded from the official website. *(PNS)*

Ex-CCI chief dies in fire

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An 80-year-old retired IAS officer died while his son sustained injuries after a fire broke out at a house in south Delhi's Hauz Khas area on Wednesday night.

The deceased was identified as Dhanender Kumar, 1968 batch a retired Indian Administrative Service officer. He was the first chairperson of Competition Commission of India. He succumbed during treatment at the AIIMS Trauma Centre for asphyxiation, Deputy Commissioner of Police (South) Anant Mittal said on Thursday.

While Kumar could not survive, his son is undergoing treatment and is stated to be out of danger, an officer said.

Dhanender Kumar
WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

Preliminary enquiry suggested that the fire may have been triggered by a blast in the indoor unit of an air-conditioner installed in the house, police said. At the time of the incident, five people, including family members and domestic help, were present inside the house, they said.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Iran, US edge closer to temporary ceasefire deal

AAMER MADHANI/ JON GAMBRELL/SAM METZ/ KONSTANTIN TOROPIN ■ Dubai

US and Iranian negotiators have reached a tentative agreement to extend the ceasefire by 60 days and launch talks on Iran's nuclear program, according to a US official familiar with the matter. The official, who was not authorised to comment publicly and spoke on condition of anonymity, said President Donald Trump still needs to sign off on the emerging memorandum of understanding.

The tentative agreement worked out by the two sides comes at a moment when the fragile ceasefire between the US and Iran appeared to be wavering.

US President Donald Trump attending a Cabinet meeting at the White House AP

Earlier in the day, the US military slammed Iran for violating the ceasefire after Kuwait reported coming under attack in the latest flare-up that threatened ongoing negotiations to end the war.

US Central Command said that Kuwait had intercepted missiles launched by Iran late Wednesday night, calling the Iranian attack on one of America's top allies in the Persian Gulf an "egregious ceasefire violation."

Kuwait had earlier announced an attack on its territory, and Iran said had retaliated after strikes earlier in the week by firing on a US base in an Gulf State it did not name.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Two elderly women found dead in central Delhi home

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Two elderly women, aged around 80 years each, were found dead inside their locked home in New Rajinder Nagar in central Delhi on Thursday morning. The bodies was discovered after a maid noticed a foul smell emanating from the premises and alerted police. No signs of forced entry, ransacking, or disturbance were found inside the house, and no external injury marks were found on either body.

The women were identified as Chandra Kanta and Saroj Bala. The two had been living together for a long time. Saroj Bala was unmarried. Chandra Kanta was her sister-in-law.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

CBI ARRESTS GIRIBALA SINGH IN TWISHA CASE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal/New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Thursday arrested former district judge Giribala Singh, the mother-in-law of Twisha Sharma, a day after the Madhya Pradesh High Court quashed her anticipatory bail. A CBI team questioned Singh at her residence in Bhopal.

Giribala Singh being arrested by CBI in Bhopal on Thursday PTI

The CBI involved two teams: one comprised of technical and forensic experts, and a team of women sleuths.

Twisha's lawyer husband, Samarth Singh, is already in CBI custody (remanded till May 29). The agency will now interrogate and cross-examine the mother-son duo as part of its probe into the alleged dowry harassment and death. The arrest came after nearly seven hours of questioning at Singh's residence in Katara Hills.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Thunderstorms sweep Delhi after days of scorching heat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

After days of sweltering heatwave conditions, Delhi and its adjoining areas breathed a sigh of relief on Thursday evening as heavy rain, thunderstorms and gusty winds swept parts of the national Capital.

The sudden change in weather cames hours after the India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued an orange alert, predicting strong winds, moderate to heavy rains and thunderstorms. The change in weather impacted flights to and from the national Capital, with the Delhi Airport, SpiceJet and IndiGo issuing advisories for passengers.

Karnataka Chief Minister K Siddaramaiah's Delhi-bound flight was diverted to Jaipur due to bad weather. "The special flight carrying Chief Minister Siddaramaiah has landed in Jaipur instead of Delhi due to adverse weather conditions. Karnataka in-charge and Congress general secretary Randeep Singh Surjewala, Ministers K J George, Bairathi Suresh, legal advisor Ponnanna, Siddaramaiah's MLC son Yatindra, Congress secretary Abhishek Dutt were in the flight," the CMO of Karnataka said in a statement.

The Delhi Airport authority in a post on X issued a warning that flights may be impacted due to the weather. "Passengers are requested to contact the airline concerned for updated flight information. Passengers can consider alternative modes of transport, including the Delhi Metro, to get to the Airport to avoid potential delays," it said.

Representative image FILE PHOTO

According to IMD data, maximum temperatures across the city on Thursday fell by around 3 to 5 degrees Celsius compared to the previous day. The weather office said the current spell of rain and thunderstorm activity is expected to continue till May 31.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Government pushes menstrual health reforms in schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday directed Government schools across the capital to improve menstrual hygiene facilities and create a more supportive environment for girl students during a high-level virtual meeting with school principals and education officials on World Menstrual Hygiene Day.

The Chief Minister instructed schools to ensure clean toilets, functioning sanitary pad vending machines, proper medical rooms, and better hygiene facilities for girls. She also stressed the need to make schools emotionally supportive spaces where students can speak openly about menstrual health without hesitation.

Addressing principals and officials through video conferencing from the Jan Seva Sadan, the Chief Minister said menstruation is a natural biological process, and girls should not feel fear, shame, or discomfort while attending school during their periods. She said school authorities have a responsibility that goes beyond administration and includes ensuring emotional support and dignity for students.

The meeting was attended by Education Minister Ashish Sood, Director of Education Vedita Reddy, and senior department officials. During the discussion, the Chief Minister reviewed menstrual hygiene infrastructure in Government schools and expressed concern over complaints related to dirty toilets and damaged facilities in some institutions.

She directed principals to immediately repair broken doors, improve sanitation, and use available school funds or coordinate with departments concerned to resolve pending issues. She said students cannot be expected to study properly if basic hygiene conditions are neglected.

The Delhi Government also announced several new measures under its "Menstrual Health Matters" campaign.

A special advisory will be issued for regular maintenance and timely refilling of sanitary pad vending machines installed in schools, government offices, public toilets, and Arogya Mandirs across the city. Officials said the sanitary pad distribution system will now be centrally monitored to ensure the availability of biodegradable and quality-tested products for girls and women.

The Government will also expand awareness campaigns through ASHA and Anganwadi workers so that information related to menstrual hygiene reaches households across Delhi. In schools, menstrual health education for students from Classes 6 to 9 will be strengthened as part of the curriculum.

During the meeting, the Chief Minister also spoke about broader women's health issues, including anaemia, PCOS, menopause, cervical cancer, and HPV vaccination. She said regular awareness sessions would be organised at Arogya Mandirs, where doctors and trained healthcare workers would directly interact with women and adolescent girls.

The Chief Minister asked school principals to ensure that parents are informed about the importance of HPV vaccination and that consent procedures are properly followed. She said awareness about cervical cancer prevention is necessary because the disease affects a large number of women and can largely be prevented through timely vaccination and education.

The Chief Minister also announced that free bicycles would be distributed to girl students after schools reopen. She said parents should also be encouraged to consider HPV vaccination for their daughters during the process.

"A healthy and confident daughter forms the foundation of a strong society," the Chief Minister said during the meeting. She added that Delhi can become a truly developed city only when girls are able to move ahead without fear, stigma, or discomfort.

Education Minister Ashish Sood said menstrual hygiene is not only a health issue but also linked to dignity, confidence, and awareness.

He said schools must become safe and sensitive spaces where students receive proper support and information. Sood said the Delhi Government is committed to ensuring that girls receive clean facilities, access to hygiene products, and timely healthcare support.

Government to roll out hydrogen buses in green transport push

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Delhi Government is preparing to introduce hydrogen fuel cell buses in the national Capital as part of its clean mobility programme, with an initial fleet of two buses to be deployed on a pilot basis in partnership with Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) and NTPC.

The move marks Delhi's entry into hydrogen-powered public transport and is aimed at strengthening the city's transition towards low-emission and environmentally sustainable mobility systems.

Officials said the buses will operate using hydrogen fuel cell technology, which is known globally for producing zero tailpipe emissions and reducing pollution levels in urban transport networks.

The pilot project will be carried out under a coordinated framework involving DTC, NTPC and other agencies. The Delhi Government said operational arrangements and deployment plans are currently being finalised before the buses begin service in the city.

Delhi Transport Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh said the Government was steadily

moving towards cleaner and future-oriented public transport systems. "Hydrogen fuel technology is an important step towards building environmentally responsible transport infrastructure in Delhi," he said. The minister added that the government was working with organisations such as NTPC to introduce advanced zero-emission technologies that could help improve public transport while contributing to cleaner air in the capital.

According to officials, the buses are expected to run under the Gross Cost Contract model, under which DTC will handle operational deployment and bear expenditure at approved GCC rates. Support for costs beyond the GCC framework is being explored through NTPC's Corporate Social Responsibility support mechanism and other arrangements being discussed between the agencies involved.

The government said a formal Memorandum of Understanding between the stakeholders is also being prepared to facilitate the launch of operations. Discussions are underway regarding operational procedures, technical support, and route planning for the pilot phase.

Hydrogen fuel cell buses are considered one of the emerging alternatives to conventional fossil fuel vehicles. Unlike diesel-powered buses, hydrogen buses generate electricity through a chemical reaction between hydrogen and oxygen, producing only water vapour as a byproduct.

The technology is increasingly being adopted in several countries as governments look for cleaner urban transport solutions.

The Delhi Government said the initiative complements its ongoing efforts to modernise the public transport system and reduce vehicular pollution in the city. The capital has already been expanding its electric bus fleet and promoting clean energy-based mobility solutions in recent years.

Govt mandates IoT-based real-time monitoring system in buildings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Delhi Government has mandated the installation of an Internet of Things (IoT)-based automated continuous monitoring system (ACMS) in specified buildings to digitally monitor fire prevention and life safety systems in real time by sending alerts through SMS, according to a recent gazette notification.

The new provision, introduced under the Delhi Fire Service (Amendment) Rules, aims to ensure that both active and passive fire safety measures in buildings remain functional, well-maintained and capable of responding during emergencies.

Under the rules, the ACMS will monitor the operational status of critical firefighting infrastructure, including hydrant pumps, sprinkler systems, fire water tanks, detection systems, manual call points, public address systems, pressurisation fans and basement ventilation systems.

The monitoring system will function through IoT gateways connected to cloud-based servers that will generate real-time alerts and reports for owners, occupiers and empanelled fire safety auditors through mobile applications, emails and SMS alerts.

The implementation of the system will take place in two phases. In the first phase, which comes into effect immediately after the notification of the rules, alerts and system health reports will be accessible to building owners, occupiers and fire safety auditors.

In the second phase, critical alarms such as pump power failures, low hydrant and sprinkler pressure, and fire alarm faults will also be directly transmitted to the Delhi Fire Service (DFS).

The rules specify that the monitoring system must digitally track key firefighting components such as main hydrant pumps, diesel and electric standby pumps, jockey pumps, booster pumps, underground and overhead fire water tanks, sprinkler risers and fire alarm control panels.

The system will also monitor operational status of manual call points, public address systems, staircase pressurisation fans, lift lobby pressurisation systems and basement exhaust fans.

According to the notification, the IoT system must use machine-to-machine communication based on MQTTS protocol and support cloud connectivity through 4G, 5G, Ethernet, Wi-Fi or any other reliable wired or wireless medium.

Complete remediation of Bhalswa landfill by September: Manohar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal on Thursday directed authorities to ensure complete remediation of the Bhalswa landfill site in the national Capital by September.

During his second on-site inspection of the site, the minister said fresh waste generated on a daily basis should be processed immediately to prevent further accumulation and stressed that no new legacy waste should be created.

He reviewed biomining operations, fire prevention measures and the roadmap for clearing the remaining waste at the site, the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) said in a statement.

The Bhalswa landfill has been adopted by the minister under the Dumpsite Remediation and Action Plan (DRAP), a nationwide initiative launched under the Swachh Bharat Mission-Urban 2.0 for scientific remediation of major legacy waste sites across the country.

During his visit, officials briefed the minister on the progress of biomining and

land reclamation activities at the Bhalswa Dumpsite. The site had approximately 73 lakh metric tonnes of legacy waste in June 2022, and since July 2022, biomining operations have been continuously undertaken in mission mode, approximately 15 thousand metric tonnes processed per day.

As of 26 May 2026, resulting in a significant reduction of the balance waste quantity, including both legacy and fresh waste, to approximately 23.17 lakh metric tonnes is remaining waste to be processed.

Owing to the sustained biomining and remediation efforts, nearly 43 acres of land have been reclaimed out of the total dumpsite area of about 70 acres.

The minister also directed officials to ensure that the reclaimed land is utilised judiciously for public and community welfare after completion of the remediation process.

ITL FINLEASE & SECURITIES LIMITED

CIN: L65910DL1991PLC045090,
Registered Office:- B-08, GD-ITL Tower, Top Floor, Netaji Subhash Place, Pitampura, Delhi-110034, Ph No- 011-41572981
E-Mail: csitlfinlease@gmail.com, Website: www.itlfinlease.in,

Audited Financial Results for the quarter and year ended on March 31st ,2026

Based on the recommendation of the audit committee, the Board of Directors of ITL Finlease and Securities Limited ("the Company") at its meeting held on Wednesday May 27th , 2026, has approved the Standalone Audited Financial Results for the Quarter and year ended March 31st ,2026 . The said financial results along with the Annexures thereon are available on the website of the Stock Exchange www.msei.in and Company's website www.itlfinlease.in. **The same can also be accessed by scanning a Quick Response Code given below:**

Scan the QR Code to access the Financial Results on the Website of the Company

For ITL FINLEASE & SECURITIES LIMITED
Sd/-
B.L.GUPTA
(DIRECTOR)
DIN : 00143031

Place : Delhi
Date : 27-05-2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is notified for the information of General Public that my clients **(1) Prmod Kumar Angrish S/o Hari Krishan Angirsh and (2) Smt. Anju Angrish W/o Mr. Prmod Kumar Angrish both are R/o B-111, Near Sai Baba Mandir, Indra Park, Najafgarh, Delhi-110043,** have severed all their relations and connections with their son **Mr. Shubham Angrish** because of his miss-behavior and Not Obedient & have debarred the from their all movable and immovable properties with immediate effect. Anybody deals with them will be doing so at his/her/their own risk, costs and expenses. My Client will not be liable and responsible for their acts. Deeds and things under any circumstances.

Kiran Bala Nayak (Advocate)
Ch. No.312, Saket Court, New Delhi-10017

PUBLIC NOTICE

To be known to all that **I, Amit Gupta S/o Late Sh. M. P. Gupta R/o DDA SFS Flat No.14-A, Motia Khan, New Delhi-110055, I am the Allottee of Flat No. B-704, 7TH Floor, Shiam CGHS Ltd, Plot No.5-D, Sector-11, Dwarka, New Delhi applied for conversion of the aforesaid property from leasehold to freehold in DDA. The Original Share Certificate, Allotment Letter and Possession Letter of the above said flat have been lost/misplaced.** An FIR to this effect has been lodged in LR NO. 330 516/2026 Dt.27/05/2026 Any person claiming any right, interest having any objection may write/contact with above named person at above address/phone 8800794031 within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice and can personally inform or write to Dy. Director (GH) or Director (GH) C Block, 2nd Floor, Vikas Sadan, INA, New Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE

To be known to all, **RAJWANTI W/o ISHWAR SINGH MALIK DDA LIG FLAT NO. R/O A-1/155, SECTOR-16 ROHINI,DELHI-110089.** has applied for certified copy & conversion from leasehold to freehold in DDA.The original document i.e. Allotment Letter, Possession Letter,Site Possession Slip, NOC, for Obtaining Water and Electric Connection of the above said flat has been lost.An F.I.R./NCR/LR No.330607/2026 dt.27/05/2026 to this effect has been lodged in P.S. Crime Branch Delhi. Any person (s) claiming any right,interest,having any objection or found in possession of original documents, may write/contact with above name d person at above Address/Phone **9810122762** within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. The person claiming any right, interest, objection with respect to this property, can personally inform or write to **Deputy Director (Housing)LIG, Delhi Development Authority, Vikas Sadan,New Delhi -110023.**

E-AUCTION NOTICE

FIRE AFFECTED APPROX. 8,000 KG OF HEAVY STEEL, APPROX. 5,000 KG OF LIGHT STEEL AND MACHINERIES ETC.

Interested Buyers are invited to participate in the e-Auction for the disposal of "Fire Affected Approx. 8,000 Kg of Heavy Steel, approx. 5,000 Kg of Light Steel and Machineries etc." on "Per UOM" Basis. The subject salvage will be sold on "As is Where is", Whatever there is" and "No Complaint" Basis and belongs to **M/s. Jai Impex / Mr. Jai Sahni / M/s. Windeson Trademart Pvt Ltd.** The subject materials can be inspected at Plot no. 182, G.T Road, Sahibabad, Ghaziabad – 201005 Between **29-05-26 to 08-06-26** between **10 AM to 5 PM** on working days only. **Kindly contact Mr. Shiv Prasad at 8130736670 or Mr. Navneet Agarwal at 9811686022** for inspection.

E-AUCTION WILL BE HELD ON 09.06.26

Kindly contact **Mr. Amit Mishra at 9266315793** to obtain the form containing terms & conditions of e-Auction or download from website **https://www.sealthedeal.co.in/.**

Auctioneers: Seal The Deal having registered office at 5th Floor, Off No. 2, Kings Mall, Rohini Sec. 10, Delhi-110085.

LAST DATE OF SUBMISSION OF FORM & EMD DEMAND DRAFT IS 08.06.26

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Dr. Jagdish Kumar Ladha S/o Mr. Hargovind Das Ladha R/o CGQ072 , DLF Capital Greens, Shivaji Marg, New Delhi-110015 informs that I have lost the property documents in the name of Dr. Jagdish Kumar Ladha and Smt. Usha Ladha (Allotment letter dated 19-3-2010, Posession letter dated 19-9-2017 and Payment Receipts are as follows :

CG2/CRB/00010/1009, CG2/CRB/00758/1109, CG2/CRB/00668/1209, CG2/CRB/00636/0110, CG2/CRB/01036/0110, CG2/CRB/01211/0310, CG2/CRB/00349/0910, CG2/CRB/00350/0910, CG2/CRB/00073/1010, CG2/CRB/00088/1110, CG2/CRB/00065/0111, CG2/CRB/00020/0411, CG2/CRB/00116/0413, CG2/CRB/00117/0413, CG2/CRB/00481/1113,

FINDER PLEASE CONTACT
9310390990

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of **MD SAHEB** to inform to the public at large that **MD SAHEB** is purchasing the **PROPERTY BEARING NO. 91, KHASRA NO. 57/9/1, UPPER GROUND FLOOR (L-TYPE/FRONT SIDE PORTION), WITHOUT ROOF RIGHTS, GALI NO. 4, BLOCK A, SITUATED IN THE, REVENUE ESTATE AT VILLAGE-HASTSAAL, COLONY KNOWN AS VIJAY NAGAR, MOHAN GARDEN, UTTAM NAGAR, NEW DELHI-110059, NATIONAL CAPITAL TERRITORY OF DELHI, NEW DELHI, 110059, DELHI, WEST, INDIA NEW DELHI NEW DELHI YES REVENUE ESTATE AT VILL. HASTSAAL DELHI ABADI COLONY KNOWN AS VIJAY NAGAR, MOHAN GARDEN NATIONAL CAPITAL TERRITORY OF DELHI INDIA** from **Mr. Virendra Kumar Meena** who became owner through **GENERAL POWER OF ATTORNEY, AGREEMENT TO SELL & WILL DATED 18/12/2013, DULY ATTESTED WITH THE NOTARY PUBLIC DELHI DATED 18/12/2013** which was executed by **Mr. Ved Parkash SAME TO BE FINANCED & MORTGAGED BY VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD.** So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within **07 days** from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. **Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre,New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327**

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is to inform to all concern that Mr. Pawan Kumar, S/o. Om Prakash Dua, R/o. 735, Sector-31, Faridabad Haryana was the original allottee of Residential LIG Flat bearing No. B-1/235, Aravali Apts, Sector-34, Noida (UP) and he had sold the said LIG Flat on the basis of General Power of Attorney in the name of mine namely Mr. Sudhir Singh, S/o. Sh Satyavir Singh, R/o. B-1/235, Aravali Apts, Sector-34, Noida (UP) which is duly Registered on 03/05/1995, and the Agreement to Sell was not registered.Now the above mentioned LIG Flat bearing No. B-1/235, Aravali Apts, Sector-34, Noida is going to transfer in favour of Mrs. Kanchan Singh, W/o. Mr. Sudhir Singh R/o. B-1/235, Aravali Apts, Sector-34, Noida, so, if anyone has any objection in this regard, then they shall file their objection alongwith sufficient proof in the office of Residential Department of Noida Authority within 30 days from the date of this Public Notice.

Sudhir Singh S/o Shri Satyavir Singh
R/o B- 1/235 Aravali Apartment Sector 34
Noida Gautam Budh Nagar (UP)

PUBLIC NOTICE

LATYAN INFRASTRUCTURE

CERTIFIED TRUE COPY OF THE RESOLUTION PASSED BY THE BOARD OF DIRECTORS OF LATYAN INFRASTRUCTURE PRIVATE LIMITED AT THEIR MEETING HELD ON WEDNESDAY,20TH MAY, 2026 AT PLOT NO. A-41, THE CORRENTHUM TOWER B, SECTOR 62, NOIDA - 201301

"RESOLVED THAT in supersession of all board resolutions passed previously by Latyan Infrastructure Private Limited,including but not limited to board resolutions passed on 31.01.2024, 15.10.2024 and 22.12.2025, or any others also if any the authority given to Mr. Teg Bahadur Rais son of Mr. Lalta Prasad Rai Vide above referred resolutions and otherwise, whether express or implied, stands withdrawn with immediate effect. RESOLVED FURTHER THAT all directors of the Company be and are hereby severally authorized to convey the said withdrawal of authority of Mr. Teg Bahadur Rai to all persons concerned as well as to the statutory authorities, Noida Authority and the public at large by way of publishing notices in newspapers, if need be, in the areas/locations of operations of Latyan Infrastructure Private Limited and/or such other means, as they think fit to protect the best interests of the Company.

VISHAL VERDHAN KARTIKEYA AGARWAL
DIRECTOR DIRECTOR
DIN: 01186364 DIN: 07493012

PUBLIC NOTICE

We, Anant Gupta son of Lt. Krishna Avatar Gupta resident of H. No. C-7, Sector-14, Gautam Budh Nagar, UP-201301, Kunal Gupta & Karan Gupta sons of Lt. Kapil Gupta resident of H. No. 66 67, Mandi Road,New Delhi-47, would like to inform the general public that we are owner of flat No. 323, Ground Floor, Cat-III, Pocket A, Sarita Vihar, New Delhi, that we've lost/misplaced the original documents 1. Allotment Cum Demand Letter, 2. Demand Letter Against 5th and Final Payment, 3. Possession Letter, 4. NOC for Water & Electricity Connection and 5. Site Possession Slip of our above mentioned flat bearing Flat No. 323, Ground Floor, Cat-III, Pocket A, Sarita Vihar, New Delhi. If anyone finds it, kindly contact us at 9971346421. The use of these documents by any person or company for any purpose whatsoever, will be illegal.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public that Sh. Devesh Sharma, Ms. Alka Sharma, and Sh. Rajesh Sharma are the absolute, joint, and co-owners of the 100% undivided share in the Freehold Property bearing No. C-217, Surya Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh 201011, admeasuring 297.29 Square Meters. The Ghaziabad Development Authority originally allotted and leased the said plot to Late Sri Umesh Chandra Sharma vide Lease Deed dated 30.04.1974, registered as Document No. 5740-5741 in Book No. 1, Volume No. 1756 starting from Page 223. The property was subsequently converted into a Freehold property in his favor vide Freehold Deed executed on 04.02.2004, registered as Document No. 2065 in Book No. 1, Volume No. 3787 at Pages 79 to 90, in the office of Sub-Registrar IV, Ghaziabad. Upon the intestate deaths of Shri Umesh Chandra Sharma (d. 10.12.2014) and his wife Smt. Sushma Sharma (d. 25.04.2020), the entire property devolved upon their three surviving children-Sh. Devesh Sharma, Ms. Alka Sharma, and Sh. Rajesh Sharma as confirmed by Legal Heir Certificates dated 07.10.2015 and 15.03.2023. The sellers expressly declare that no other heir or third party has any claim whatsoever. Consequently, the mutation of the Said Property has been formally approved, and the names of Rajesh Sharma, Devesh Sharma, and Alka Sharma have been updated in the official records of the Ghaziabad Development Authority on 26.05.2026 (Ref: Mutation Application No. MU202412061535 2063 dated 06.12.2024). The current owners, acting through their duly constituted General Power of Attorney holder, Mr. Kirat Pal, have executed an Agreement to Sell the said property to the intending purchasers, Smt. Poonam Mishra and Sh. Raghav Kumar Tiwari. The intending purchasers propose to acquire the said property and have applied to avail financial assistance by creating an equitable mortgage on the property in favour of Bank of Baroda Limited. However, during the title investigation and due diligence process, it was brought to our notice that crucial original link documents pertaining to the title chain of the said property have been lost or misplaced in transit. The specifically lost documents are: (1) Original Freehold Deed dated 04.02.2004, duly registered in the office of the Sub-Registrar IV, Ghaziabad, U.P., vide Document No. 2065, in Book No. 1, Volume No. 3787, on Pages 79 to 90; and (2) Original Allotment Letter & Original Possession Letter. A formal Information Report regarding the loss of these original documents has been lodged by the Attorney Holder, Mr. Kirat Pal, with the Delhi Police (e-Police Station, Anand Vihar) vide L.R. No. 326215/2026 dated 25.05.2026.

Any person(s), firm, company, bank, financial institution, or statutory authority having any claim, right, title, interest, or objection whatsoever in respect of the said property, or claiming possession/lien over the above-mentioned original lost documents by way of sale, exchange, mortgage, charge, gift, trust, inheritance, lease, or otherwise, is hereby called upon to notify the undersigned in writing, supported by valid documentary evidence, within 15 (fifteen) days from the date of publication of this notice. Take note that if no valid claim or objection is received within the stipulated period, the said documents shall be deemed irretrievably lost, any subsequent claims shall be considered unconditionally waived, null, and void, and our client, Bank of Baroda Limited, shall proceed to finance the intending purchasers and mortgage the property free from all encumbrances.

Akash Ojha (Advocate)
Chamber No. 830, Patiala House Courts,
New Delhi-110001 Mob.: +91-8383020294
Email: hvlegalconsultants@gmail.com

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Santosh, Mother of JC-472652H Sub Prathvi Singh, R/o- Vill- Shorana Ki Dhani, PO- Dev Road, Teh- Chirawa, Dist- Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan-333035 declare that in my Son's service record my name is wrongly recorded as Santosh Kanwar whereas my correct name is Santosh, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(1206)C

I, Laxman, Father of No.15585062K Nk Tanpure Tushar Laxman, R/o- At PO-Dhangawadi, Tal- Bhor, Dist-Pune, Maharashtra- 412205, have changed my name from Laxman to Laxman Govind Tanpure, vide affidavit dated 28/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1207)C

I, No.15585062K Nk Tanpure Tushar Laxman, R/o- At PO-Dhangawadi, Tal- Bhor, Dist-Pune, Maharashtra- 412205, have changed my son's name from Tanpure Yash Tushar to Yash Tushar Tanpure, vide affidavit dated 28/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1208)C

I, Tanpure Anjana, Mother of No.15585062K Nk Tanpure Tushar Laxman, R/o- At PO-Dhangawadi, Tal- Bhor, Dist-Pune, Maharashtra- 412205, have changed my name from Tanpure Anjana to Anajna Laxman Tanpure, vide affidavit dated 28/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1209)C

I, Ram Narain S/o- Jhinku Ram, R/o- House No. - 93, Gali No. 13, Saraswati Colony, Sehatpur, Amarnagar, Faridabad, Haryana- 121003, declare that in my service records (Senior Plumber/ Employee Id E9800067), my name has been erroneously recorded as Ram Narayan, whereas my correct name is Ram Narain, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(1210)C

I am Tanzeem Ahmad R-283, Gali no-2 joga bai extension Jamia nagar Okhla-110025, Declare that both the names Tanzeem Ahmad and Mohd Tanzeem Ahmad are same name of one person and I will be known as Tanzeem Ahmad for all purposes in future

PD(1211)C

I, MEHAK KAUR TULI W/o Dashmeet Singh R/o C-30 East of Kailash,New Delhi-110065 have changed my name from MEHAK KAUR TULI to MEHAK KAUR. Henceforth, I would be known by the name of MEHAK KAUR for all future purposes.

PD(1212)C

AXIS BANK **Retail Lending and Payment Group (Local Office/Branch):** Axis Bank Ltd, 1st Floor, G- 4/5, B, Sector-4, Gomti Nagar Extension, Lucknow, U.P-226010 **Axis Bank Ltd.,** 3rd Floor, Gigaplex, NPC – 1, TTC Industrial Area, Mugalsan Road, Airoli, Navi Mumbai – 400708 **Registered Office:** "Trishul", 3rd Floor Opp. Samartheshwar Temple Law Garden, Ellisbridge Ahmedabad – 380006.

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rule, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property is mortgaged/charged to the secured creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of Secured Creditor will be sold on **"As is where is" , "As is what is", "Whatever there -is"** and **"No Recourse Basis"** on **30.06.2026** for recovery of **Rs. 31,86,283.88/- (Rupees Thirty-One Lakh Eighty-Six Thousand Two Hundred Eighty-Three and eighty-Eight Paisa Only)** dues as on **21.05.2022** with future interest and costs due to the secured creditor from **Mr. Pramod Kumar, (Applicant) & Mrs. Mamta Yadav (Co-Applicant)**. Please refer the appended auction schedule for necessary details:

KNOWN ENCUMBRANCES (IF ANY)	NA
RESERVE PRICE (IN RS.)	Rs.16,40,400/- (Rupees Sixteen Lakh Forty Thousand Four Hundred Only)
EARNEST MONEY DEPOSIT (IN RS.)	Rs 1,64,040/- (Rupees One Lakh Sixty-Four Thousand Forty Only) through DD/PO in favor of 'Axis bank ltd.' payable.
BID INCREMENTAL AMOUNT	Rs. 10,000/- (Rupees Ten Thousand only)
LAST DATE, TIME AND VENUE FOR SUBMISSION OF BIDS / TENDER WITH EMD	Till **29.06.2026** latest by 05:00 P.M. Axis Bank Ltd, 1st Floor, G-4/5, B, Sector-4, Gomti Nagar Extension, Lucknow, U.P-226010 addressed to **Mr. Abhishek Sharma**
DATE, TIME, AND VENUE FOR PUBLIC E-AUCTION	On **30.06.2026,** between 11.00 A.M and 12.00 Noon. with unlimited extensions of 5 minutes each at web portal

https://www.bankeauctions.com e-auction tender documents containing e-auction bid form, declaration etc., are available in the website of the Service Provider as mentioned above.

SCHEDULE – DESCRIPTION OF PROPERTY

All such pieces or parcels of a diverted land/property having covered area 69.70 sq. mt., situated at: House part of Kh. No. Mauza Bharthana Dehat Area Nagar Palika Ke Bahar Pargana Bharthana, District – Etawah (UP) – 206242, Property is in the name of Mamta Yadav. **Boundaries as per Deed:** East: 10' Wide Gali, West: Plot of Sh. Pratap Singh, North: 10' Wide Road, South: Plot of Sh. Edal Singh. **Boundaries as per Site:** East: 10' Wide Road, West: Property of Dakhhedar Singh / Smt. Mamta Yadav, North: 15' Wide Road, South: House of Sh. Mannu Pradhan

For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in the secured creditor's website i.e. https://www.axisbank.com/auction-retail and the Bank's approved service provider M/S C1 India Private Limited at their web portal https://www.bankeauctions.com

The auction will be conducted online through the Bank's approved service provider M/s.C1 India Private Limited at their web portal https://www.bankeauctions.com. For any other assistance, the intending bidders may contact **Mr. Abhishek Sharma, Mobile. No. +91- 918077639704, Email. Abhishek65.Sharma@axis.bank.in** Authorized officer of the Bank during office hours from 10 a.m. to 4:00 p.m.

Yours faithfully,
Dated: 29.05.2026, Place: Lucknow **Authorized Officer, For Axis Bank Ltd.**

RLF LIMITED

Regd.Office : 14 Kms, Pataudi Road, Village Jhund Sarai Veeran, Gurugram, Haryana, 122016
CIN NO.: L74999HR1979PLC032747, **Phone :** 011-49075251,**Email :** compliance@rlfltd.com

EXTRACT OF STANDALONE AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ANDYEAREND ED ON 31ST MARCH,2026

(Rupees in Lakhs)

Sr. No.	Particulars	Quarter ended			Year ended	
		31/03/2026	31/12/2025	31/03/2025	31/03/2026	31/03/2025
		Audited	Un Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited
1	Income from Operations	8.36	24.77	33.35	49.31	108.01
2	Net Profit for the period (before tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(24.14)	3.25	(10.72)	(31.60)	(0.32)
3	Net Profit before tax for the period (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	(24.14)	3.25	(15.48)	(31.60)	(5.08)
4	Net Profit for the period after tax and Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items	(24.14)	3.25	(33.22)	(31.60)	(22.82)
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (comprising profit for the period (after tax) and other Comprehensive Income (after Tax)	(24.14)	3.25	(33.22)	(31.60)	(22.82)
6	Equity Shares Capital (Face value Rs.10/- Per equity share)	964.35	980.18	980.17	964.35	980.17
7	Earnings Per Share (for continuing and discontinued Operations) Basic and diluted	(0.25) (0.24)	0.03 0.03	(0.35) (0.33)	(0.33) (0.32)	(0.24) (0.23)

Notes:

1. This extract of the detailed format of Financial Resultsfiledwith the Stock Exchanges under the Regulation 33 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations,2015. The full format of the financial results are available on the stock exchanges website : www.bseindia.com The same is also available on the company's Website:www.rlfltd.com
2. The above results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors of the company at their Meeting held on 27th May, 2026.
3. The Company has no subsidiary/associate/Joint Venture Company(ies).
4. The Operations of the company are considered as a single business product. Segment reporting is not applicable.

For RLF LIMITED
Sd/-
ADITYA KHANNA
MANAGING DIRECTOR
DIN: 01860038

Place: New Delhi
Date : 28-05-2026

Delhi records 157 unidentified, homeless deaths in May: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi recorded 157 unidentified and homeless deaths in the first 26 days of May 2026, averaging more than five deaths per day. Apart from that, a field audit found that every single person surveyed outside major government hospitals was suffering from heat-related illness and nearly 97 per cent received no medical assistance, according to a report by the Centre for Holistic Development (CHD) that has been sent to Union Health Minister Jagat Prakash Nadda, the National Human Rights Commission, and Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta.

The letter, dated May 28 and signed by CHD Executive Director Sunil Kumar Aledia, describes the situation as a severe humanitarian and administrative crisis and calls for immediate intervention.

It accuses authorities of failing to implement the Delhi High Court's directions in WP(C) No. 380/2026, which had mandated emergency heatwave relief mechanisms for homeless individuals and patient attendants during extreme summer conditions.

The death data is drawn from Delhi Police's ZIPNET system, which logs unidentified bodies across the National Capital Territory. Out of the 157 deaths, the North District recorded the highest number at 31, followed by the Central District with 26. Railway and transit corridors accounted for 21 deaths across stations, including New Delhi Railway Station, Anand Vihar, and Sarai Rohilla. A single police station, I.P. Estate in Central Delhi, recorded 10 deaths, the highest for any station in the dataset. The report notes that actual deaths are likely significantly higher due to under-reporting and non-registration.

The CHD conducted a field audit between May 17 and May 26 across the perimeters of four major hospitals: LNJP, AIIMS, Safdarjung, and RML.

The findings from 35 surveyed individuals were stark.

All 35 were suffering from heat-related illness symptoms while living outside the hospital premises. Despite court-mandated protocols requiring priority medical triage for vulnerable heatwave victims, only one person out of 34 received any on-site medical assistance.

A total of 85.7 per cent of respondents were unaware of official heatwave alerts, and 82.9 per cent had received no guidance about nearby shelters or relief services.

Only 20 per cent of those surveyed were able to access a DUSIB shelter. Among those who did, 57.1 per cent found no drinking water, 57.1 per cent found no beds or mats, and every single woman surveyed reported the complete absence of a separate safe space. A further 88.6 per cent stated that no government outreach teams or DUSIB officials had visited them during the peak heatwave period.

The audit also documented hostile conduct by hospital security personnel and staff who allegedly prevented vulnerable attendants from seeking shade inside hospital premises. Field surveyors noted that attendants were asked to pay for staying near hospital shelters and that guards directed them to vacate occupied areas at night.

The CHD has demanded immediate repair of drinking water facilities outside all major government hospitals, establishment of shaded cooling zones near hospital premises, deployment of mobile medical units, women-only secure spaces in all shelters, and a formal inquiry into the reported hostile behaviour by frontline staff.

The DUSIB, which operates approximately 197 shelter homes across Delhi, had issued an inter-departmental memorandum in May requesting the Health Department to ensure priority treatment for homeless persons presenting with heat-related illness. The field audit found this directive had not reached the ground.

The letter has also been copied to the Delhi Commissioner of Police, the Chief Secretary, and the State Level Shelter Monitoring Committee.

Centre, Delhi to jointly undertake six major road projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

In a push to decongest thoroughfares between Delhi and other NCR cities, the Delhi government and the Centre will jointly undertake six major road projects.

The projects are connectivity to the Delhi-Dehradun Expressway via the Urban Extension Road (UER)-2, the Noida-Faridabad Corridor from the Delhi-Dehradun Expressway, Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway to be built at a cost of ₹1,500 Crore, UER-II Service Road to Ensure Smoother Connectivity, Tunnel Project to Ease Traffic Congestion, AIIMS-Mahipalpur-Gurugram Elevated Corridor Project and Kalindi Kunj Interchange to Improve Traffic Flow

Announcing this, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday said the new expressways, tunnels, elevated corridors and connectivity links are being planned to modernise and streamline transportation across Delhi-NCR. She said all these projects have been designed keeping future traffic requirements in mind.

The move comes a week after Union Minister of Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari and the Delhi chief minister held a review in this regard, during which discussions were held on a decongestion plan for major NCR roads.

One of the approved plans includes the 'Urban Extension Road-II (UER-II) Delhi-Dehradun Expressway Link Project'.

Under the project, a nearly 17-km-long six-lane corridor will connect the Delhi-Dehradun Expressway with UER-II near Tronica City in Ghaziabad, at an estimated cost of ₹3,500 crore.

"The project is expected to reduce traffic pressure on routes such as IGI Airport, Barapullah corridor, Mukarba Chowk, Singhu Border and the Ashram-Badarpur stretch. The project is currently in the alignment finalisation stage, with construction targeted to begin by December 2026," the CMO said in a statement.

The chief minister said the Centre and Delhi government will jointly undertake a series of large-scale road projects, with all of them designed in view of future traffic requirements.

Another proposed project is the 'Delhi-Dehradun Expressway Noida-Faridabad Connectivity Corridor'. Spanning around 65 km and featuring six lanes, its cost is estimated at ₹7,500 crore.

"The corridor will connect the Delhi-Dehradun Expressway, Delhi-Meerut Expressway, DND, Faridabad and the Yamuna Expressway," the CMO said.

It is expected to improve connectivity for Loni, Baghpat, Ghaziabad, Noida and Faridabad while reducing congestion at Kalindi Kunj, Sarai Kale Khan and the Outer Ring Road. Work is expected to commence by December 2026.

The chief minister also highlighted a project linking the Delhi-Amritsar-Katra corridor with UER-II.

"Under the proposal, traffic from the Delhi-Katra Expressway will gain direct access to Delhi, Gurugram and IGI Airport through UER-II and the Dwarka Expressway. The 17-km, six-lane corridor, estimated to cost ₹1,500 crore, is targeted to begin by March 2027," she said. To decongest Kalindi Kunj areas, authorities plan to construct an "interchange" near the Okhla barrage to improve traffic flow on the Delhi-Noida-Faridabad corridor.

"The project, estimated at ₹300 crore, includes the construction of a 500-metre-long, six-lane interchange and flyovers. The project aims to decongest Kalindi Kunj and provide signal-free connectivity between Noida, Jasola, Sarita Vihar and Faridabad," the statement added.

The chief minister said the land acquisition process for the project has already begun, and construction is expected to start by October 2026.

Another project, the 'AIIMS-Mahipalpur-Gurugram Elevated Corridor' -- a 20-km-long six-lane road -- is estimated at Rs 5,000 crore, with construction slated to begin by April 2027.

"The project will significantly ease traffic between Delhi and Gurugram. The elevated corridor will provide signal-free connectivity linking AIIMS, INA, Hauz Khas, and Vasant Kunj with the neighbouring state of Haryana," the Chief Minister said.

The project is also expected to improve connectivity to Aerocity, Rangpuri, Chhatarpur and Ghitorni areas of South Delhi.

Another key project involves construction of service roads along the existing UER-II corridor. According to the CMO, the initiative will improve local connectivity and support planned urban expansion in outer Delhi.

Change of guard like relay race: Delhi BJP chief Harsh Malhotra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The new president of the BJP's Delhi unit, Harsh Malhotra, on Thursday said change of guard is like a relay race and asserted to work towards strengthening the party's organisation with the cooperation of workers and the guidance of the senior leaders.

Accompanied by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, outgoing Delhi BJP president Virendra Sachdeva, party MPs Ramvir Singh Bidhuri, Manoj Tiwari, Bansuri Swaraj, Kamaljeet Sehrawat, Delhi government ministers and other senior party leaders, Malhotra took charge as the state president at the party office here. BJP national president Nitin Nabin appointed Malhotra, who belongs to the Punjabi community, to lead the party's Delhi unit. He officially assumed his duties at the Delhi BJP office at 2.30 pm.

Addressing his maiden press conference as Delhi BJP chief, Malhotra said he intended to work alongside lakhs of party workers, senior leaders and functionaries to ensure the party reached new heights. "Change of leadership is like a relay race, and I have been given this responsibility. I am fortunate to receive the well wishes and blessings of my predecessors, including (ex-Union minister) Harsh Vardhan," he said.

"I believe that responsibilities in the BJP are like a 400-metre relay race. Today, Virendra Sachdeva has handed over to me the baton of responsibility, and I resolve that with the support of thousands of party workers in Delhi and under the guidance of the leadership, I will make every possible effort to strengthen the BJP in Delhi and accelerate the work of the Delhi government," Malhota said after taking the charge.

CM CONGRATULATES HARSH MALHOTRA

New Delhi: Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday congratulated Union Minister of State and East Delhi MP Harsh Malhotra after he was appointed the new president of the Delhi unit of the Bharatiya Janata Party. The Chief Minister visited the Delhi BJP office and met Malhotra to extend her wishes on his new organisational responsibility.

The Chief Minister said Harsh Malhotra's long association with the party organisation and his close connection with workers would help strengthen the Delhi BJP in the coming years.

Fact-based debates strengthen constitutional institutions: Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Thursday emphasised the importance of fact-based debates on Thursday, stating that they not only strengthen constitutional institutions but also enhance their dignity and maintain public trust.

Birla made these remarks during the release of 89 volumes documenting the proceedings of the Central Legislative Assembly from 1924 to 1930 at the Delhi Assembly. He noted that this rare collection will serve as a valuable guide for the younger generation.

Accompanied by Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs and Minority Affairs Kiren Rijiju, Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta and Delhi Parliamentary Affairs Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, Birla also unveiled the inaugural issue of the assembly's magazine, 'Vidhan Chetna'.

In his address, Birla highlighted the significance of the Delhi Assembly building, where the Central Legislative Assembly operated during British rule.

"It was from this very house that the fight for representative rights gained momentum and where several national leaders raised their voices against oppressive colonial laws through historic debates and discussions," Birla said.

Birla pointed out that engaging in fact-based debates, both agreeing and disagreeing, has allowed Indian democracy to serve as a guiding force on global platforms.

Regarding the compilation and publication of the 89 volumes, he stated that they will enhance public awareness of legislative functions during British rule, inspiring all those who believe in democracy and public representatives across the country.

Rijiju commended the Delhi Assembly and its speaker for their efforts to preserve historical documents, asserting that this initiative will help reinforce democracy.

He warned against public representatives using Parliament and assemblies merely as platforms to enhance their own images, explaining that such actions can harm constitutional institutions. Rijiju expressed pride in India's emergence as a powerful country on the world stage and pointed out that there are elements, including some within the country, attempting to undermine this progress.

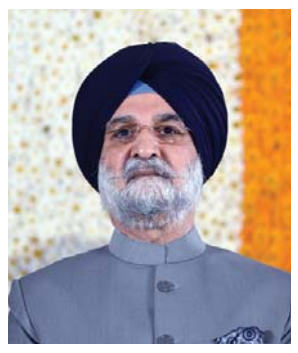
He stressed that the preservation of parliamentary records is crucial; if not prioritised, it could weaken the foundations of democracy.

Emphasising that affording respectability to the Constitutional bodies is everyone's responsibility, Rijiju noted that some people chose to attack them when rejected by the people.

"If legislative institutions weaken, democracy weakens. Every elected representative has a collective responsibility to protect the dignity of Parliament and Assemblies," Rijiju stated in his address.

LG reviews heatwave relief operations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu reviewed the capital's heatwave relief operations. LG directed authorities to make cooling zones operational in the remaining five districts by Thursday, as Mobile Heat Relief Units deployed since May 6 have so far served over 3,33,505 people across all 13 districts of Delhi. According to officials, the Delhi government plans to set up 100 hydration points in high-footfall areas to help people fight the scorching summer.

The review meeting was attended by the Divisional Commissioner and other senior officials. The LG underlined that special focus must be ensured in supporting vulnerable sections, particularly those who are compelled to step out during peak heat hours due to livelihood concerns. He also said animals and birds must be looked after alongside people.

The LG was informed that the Revenue Department has established dedicated Cooling Zones across eight districts at various locations to provide immediate relief to rickshaw pullers, labourers, daily wage workers, commuters, and others exposed to severe heat.

Each Cooling Zone has a seating capacity of 100 chairs, cold drinking water, five desert coolers, and five high-speed fans. ORS packets, caps, gamchas, and first aid kits are also available at each zone.

The zones operate on a 24-hour, seven-day basis with a team of 10 Civil Defence Volunteers deployed in shifts at each location. The LG directed that zones in the remaining five districts be made operational at the earliest by Thursday.

The scale of the relief effort so far is significant. Through the Mobile Heat Relief Units alone, approximately 1,35,269 litres of drinking water have been distributed to prevent dehydration. Additionally, 1,39,616 ORS packets, 55,176 gamchas, and 52,141 caps have been distributed across districts. These mobile units are deployed on the basis of crowd presence and high footfall, covering labour markets, shopping areas, and busy intersections, and will continue to operate until July.

The Delhi Development Authority has deployed 733 public parks as cooling zones, using natural water bodies across 98 parks for ambient heat mitigation. A hundred new water coolers have been installed or are being installed at various locations. The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has managed bird water pots, emergency canvas shade, and ORS distribution at market intersections.

MAJORITY OF DU STUDENTS APPEAR FOR EXAMS ON EID

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

A majority of Delhi University students appeared for examinations held on Thursday on the occasion of Eid al-Adha, with around 1.35 lakh undergraduates attending, according to university officials.

Delhi University Controller of Examinations Gurpreet Singh Tuteja said that while the final attendance data is pending, most students scheduled to appear for the examinations were present.

"There were some absentees in the Faculty of Law, maybe around 200-300 students. In postgraduate courses, not many absentees were observed. The total number of students who were supposed to sit for exams was around 1.50 lakh," he added.

Meanwhile, the university issued a notification on Wednesday stating that undergraduate and postgraduate students who are unable to appear for their May 28 examinations due to Eid al-Adha would be allowed to take a special examination at a later date.

Tuteja said students unable to take the examinations were asked to email their respective principals by Wednesday night to report their absence.

According to the notification signed by the Controller of Examinations, students unable to attend the examinations were asked to inform their respective principals or heads of departments.

The university said the special examinations for such students would be conducted after July 4, 2026.

Forgotten by Capital-dwellers, Hathi Basti clings to its elephant legacy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Zakir, a fifth-generation mahout, stands with his camel at Hathi Basti, in New Delh PTI

Time is rarely kind, but it has been particularly cruel on Hathi Basti. The now-desolate enclave still stands on the bank of the Yamuna near ITO, forgotten by capital-dwellers as they rush about their day.

The once-fashionable elephant-keeping tradition that endowed the locality its name fell into decline after 2019, when the Delhi High Court ordered the relocation of privately-owned elephants from the capital.

A 35-year-old Amir, a sixth-generation out-of-work mahout, now sits at his father's tea shack near the Yamuna bank at ITO, just like so many others who have taken up odd jobs for a livelihood.

Amir's father, who goes by the name of Chunna ji, is the last of the mahouts from that forgotten generation.

"Those were the days," the 85-year-old Chunna ji says as a distant memory flashes before his eyes, lighting up his pale, wrinkled face.

"There was a time when elephants roamed the streets of the capital, dressed in regalia, and the cars would slow down to admire their majesty," he reminisces.

Chunna ji stays at the shack on the Yamuna bank, which doubles up as his makeshift tea shop during the day.

After losing his elephants in 2019, when they were relocated to designated wildlife rehabilitation centres in Haryana and Gujarat following the court order, Chunna ji did whatever he could to make a living for himself and his family, the old man says recalling those desperate times.

Another resident of the locality, 32-year-old Zakir, resorted to rearing camels as a source of income.

A former mahout who lost his dear elephant Hiragaj, Zakir now rents out camels for marriage ceremonies and other events.

While its residents endure poor sanitation, irregular electricity supply, flooding when the Yamuna swells during monsoon, and the constant fear of eviction, Hathi Basti is left to grapple with a fleeting past and a shifting identity.

For the people of Hathi Basti, the relocation of their elephants was not merely the loss of livelihood, but the departure of a way of life that once defined the locality.

Even as residents take up new occupations, the forgotten enclave endures, a quiet reminder of Delhi's elephant-keepers and generations of mahouts who once made a living on these capital streets.

Departments directed to prevent electricity misuse

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Delhi Government has directed all the departments to prevent "misuse" of electricity and ensure its rational usage by cutting down unnecessary lighting, using natural light and maintaining air conditioning in energy-efficient manner, officials said on Thursday.

The government has already adopted various measures to cut down on use of fuel and other resources, including use of Metro trains and public transport by the chief minister, cabinet ministers, officers, work from home and less use of official vehicles in the wake of the impact of global uncertainties on the country's economy.

A recent order issued by the General Administration Department (GAD) of the government directed the departments to take measures for "prevention of misuse and rationalisation of electricity consumption" in the offices. In pursuance of the appeal made by Prime Minister Narendra Modi regarding saving fuels and energy, it has been decided to undertake measures for prevention of misuse and rationalisation of electricity consumption, it said.

IN FOCUS

Indian Coast Guard Director General Paramesh Sivamani presents a memento to Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Dinesh K Tripathi during a farewell ceremony ahead of the latter's retirement PTI

Amritsar: Shopkeeper burnt to death as massive fire guts bamboo market

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Amritsar

A shopkeeper was burnt to death in a massive fire in Rambagh's bamboo market here on Thursday, officials said.

The fire in the 'Bansan Wala Bazaar' destroyed at least 25 kiosks. It is suspected to have been caused by a short circuit in an electric transformer. Thick smoke filled the area, creating chaos in the market.

Locals criticised the administration, claiming that it took fire trucks too long to arrive at the scene and by the time they reached, many shops had already been gutted.

Smoke and flames billow after a fire broke out at a shop, in Bansa Wala Bazar, Amritsar PTI

Eyewitnesses said that the shopkeeper who was burnt alive was physically challenged and was unable to escape in time.

At least ten fire tenders were rushed to the site to control the fire.

Presence of highly flammable materials, such as bamboo, wooden ladders, and other goods, allowed the flames to spread rapidly through the market, police said.

The blaze was visible from a considerable distance away from where it originated.

AAP leader injured in exchange of fire

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Amritsar

An Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leader was injured during an exchange of gunfire with his ex-cop neighbour over a dispute related to parking in Amritsar, police said on Thursday. Another person present at the scene was also hit by a bullet, they said.

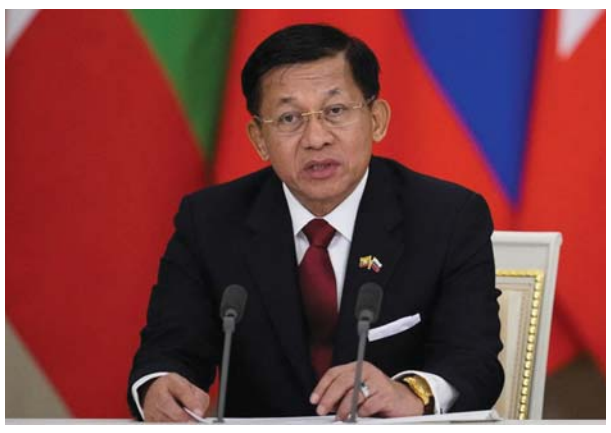
Jaipal Singh Bau, in-charge of Ward No 42 of the Amritsar Municipal Corporation, was admitted to a private hospital in critical condition after sustaining bullet injuries and had to undergo emergency surgery.

Earlier deemed critical, doctors informed that Bau is now out of danger.

Police stated that Bau had been involved in an ongoing dispute with his neighbour, former policeman Tajinderpal Singh, reportedly over car parking issues for the past several months.

According to police, an argument between the two turned violent on Thursday, leading to a physical scuffle and exchange of gunfire.

Myanmar president to undertake 5-day visit to India starting May 30



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

Myanmar President U Min Aung Hlaing will undertake a five-day visit to India beginning Saturday to explore ways to shore up bilateral ties in a range of areas including trade and defence.

It is the first high-level visit to India from Myanmar after the parliamentary elections were held in the neighbouring country from December to January.

The Myanmar president was scheduled to come to India to attend the International Big Cat Alliance Summit on June 1. His visit was rescheduled as the summit has been deferred.

He will be accompanied by a high-level delegation comprising several cabinet ministers, senior officials and business leaders, according to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA).

President U Min Aung Hlaing will hold discussions with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on June 1 to further strengthening the "historical and civilisational" ties between the two countries, the MEA said.

TN CM concludes official visit to Delhi, skips meeting Congress leaders

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Chennai/New Delhi

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay returned to Chennai on Thursday after concluding his maiden official visit to the national capital.

He skipped meeting the Congress leaders in Delhi. Congress MP Christopher Tilak said the meeting with Congress leader Rahul Gandhi did not take place as the chief minister has confined his visit to the official programme and not for political engagements. He claimed that Vijay's meeting with Rahul Gandhi has only been deferred and not cancelled, as speculated. "The chief minister is likely to come to Delhi around June 11 for the Niti Aayog meeting, and I think he would meet our leaders Rahul and Sonia Gandhi then," Tilak told reporters in the national Capital.

Vijay wound up his Delhi trip and returned to Chennai by a special flight.

The chief minister met Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday and discussed matters concerning the state, including the Mekedatu dam issue, fishermen arrests and the Tamil invocation song row.

In addition, he met Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and handed over a memorandum to prioritise funding for ports, national highways, railway projects and industrial corridors that are crucial for Tamil Nadu's development.

The CM raised the issue of the Tamil Thai Vazhthu (Tamil invocation), as a controversy had erupted over the sequence of playing it third-- after Vande Mataram and the national anthem in the swearing-in ceremony of his government, as well as the expansion of his cabinet.

12 arrested for attack on ED officials after search at Vijayan residence

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Thiruvananthapuram

Police on Thursday said it has arrested 12 people so far in connection with the violent attack on vehicles belonging to ED officials who had searched the rented residence of former Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan a day earlier.

Police also said more arrests may follow, as a few others, including local CPI(M) leader I P Binu, have been taken into custody.

Earlier in the day, State Police Chief Ravada A Chandrasekhar met Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala at his residence and vowed action against those involved in the violence.

Chandrasekhar said the investigation into the incident was on the right track and that more people involved in the violence had been identified.

He also said he had discussed the matter with the home minister, who directed that strong action be taken against the culprits. "Eight accused have been arrested, and we have identified more people," he said in the morning. By evening, four more persons were arrested in connection with the incident.

The state police chief also said adequate police personnel had been deployed at various locations near Vijayan's residence after receiving information about the Enforcement Directorate search.

Chandrasekhar said the police had not received prior intimation about the same. "They (the ED) did not inform us, but once the operation began, we took action and deployed security," he said.

Ex-sarpanch, 3 more killed, set on fire in car near Ajmer; first wife, son, daughter in custody

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Jaipur

A 45-year-old former village sarpanch and three members of his family were allegedly murdered and set on fire inside a car here on Thursday, police said on Thursday.

In Shrirampura village, around 60 km from Ajmer city, a Mahindra Scorpio was found burning on a highway nearly 500 metres from the victims' house, they said.

The deceased were identified as Ram Singh Choudhary, an ex-sarpanch, his mother, Poosi Devi, his second wife, Suryagyan Devi, and niece Mahima Chaudhary. The police said they had detained Ram Singh's first wife Sunita, daughter Sarita, and 17-year-old son in connection with the murders.

Ram Singh lived with both his two wives in the same house, and the cohabitation often led to quarrels.

On Thursday, three charred bodies were found inside the car, while a fourth body was found in a field nearby, the police said.

Superintendent of Police Harsh Vardhan Agarwala said initially it appeared to be a case of accidental fire, but initial probe indicated they were murders.

When police went to Ram Singh's house, his first wife said he had gone to a hospital with his mother, who had pain in her chest.

"Ram Singh had two wives, and there was a dispute in the family on this matter. Our investigation revealed that the first wife and her children had a scuffle with Ram Singh and his mother," the SP said.

FROM PAGE - 1

Defence forces may guard NEET-UG retest...

"There are several factors that need to be considered since the exam will be conducted in the monsoon. There might be flooded areas to which exam material is to be transported. In the case of Lakshadweep, the operation of ferries might be restricted during the monsoon. Similarly, there might be flooded areas in parts of Assam and Bihar. In such cases, air support might be necessary," the official added.

The preparation for the re-test is going on a war footing as the exam conducting body, NTA, has only one month to go as compared to the entire process, which usually takes six months.

The exam, which was held on May 3, 2026, for over 22 lakh candidates, was cancelled on May 12 after a paper leak. On May 15, the NTA announced that the retest would be conducted on June 21. The CBI is now probing the leak, and several arrests, including the mastermind, are in the net of investigations.

Pradhan promises action on OSM lapses

Pradhan who has been facing the heat from all quarters after the NEET cancellation due to paper leaks followed the CBSE digital marking controversy, said any lapses or negligence, whether within or outside the system, will not be tolerated and strict action will be taken in such cases.

The meeting came after the CBSE defended its digital evaluation system, saying the OSM process was backed by a "secure and robust IT platform". The board said that the platform has been "tested and certified through empanelled security audits" and is supported by a "robust digital infrastructure" with multiple quality checks and safeguards for secure scanning and processing of answer books.

The education minister reviewed the progress of post-result services with a focus on strengthening student support systems, improving the evaluation and monitoring framework, enhancing the CBSE digital platform, and making examination-related services more accessible and efficient for students.

According to the ministry, an expert technical team comprising professors from IIT Madras and specialists in digital systems has been tasked with reviewing portal stability, server capacity, login management and payment gateway integration to ensure seamless and uninterrupted services for students.

Addressing students, the CBSE posted on X that answer books are "safe" and have been processed through "multiple quality-control mechanisms". The statement comes amid controversy over the award of a contract related to digital evaluation of answer books for class 12 board exams 2026 to a firm and claims circulating on social media regarding the alleged compromise of its OSM system. The CBSE rejected allegations regarding the award of contract to Coempt Edutech, saying the claims were erroneous, misleading and not based on facts. It said the contract was awarded after following due procedure under the General Financial Rules.

BJP rejigs State units ahead of crucial polls

The appointment were announced by BJP national president Nitin Nabin as part of the party's ongoing organisational reshuffle.

By choosing leaders like Dhillon and Malhotra, the BJP appears to be balancing regional influence, caste equations and administrative experience as it prepares for upcoming State and national-level political battles.

The appointment of Malhotra and Dillon, who was originally one of the faces of the BJP in Punjab, is intended to send out a positive signal to Punjabi voters in the capital ahead of Punjab Assembly polls and MCD elections scheduled next year. Malhotra's elevation is seen as crucial for the BJP's preparations in the national capital, where the party is looking to strengthen its organisation and sharpen its political strategy.

Malhotra is a prominent BJP leader in Delhi who currently serves as a Member of Parliament in the Lok Sabha for the East Delhi constituency (elected in 2024).

He is also the Union Minister of State in the Ministry of Corporate Affairs and Minister of State in the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways.

While Sardar Kewal Singh Dhillon, a two-time former Congress MLA from Barnala, had joined the BJP in 2022 and was subsequently appointed vice-president of the state unit of the party. BJP appointing Dhillon, a Sikh, as its Punjab unit chief indicates the party's intent to strongly fight the state assembly polls due next year.

BJP leaders had been pushing for a Sikh face to lead the Punjab unit of the party. The BJP has already started preparations for the 2027 Punjab assembly polls hoping to dislodge the AAP Government from power in the State. Dhillon replaces Sunil Jakhar, who was appointed as the Punjab BJP president in July 2023. Jakhar had also joined the BJP in 2022, ending his long association with the Congress.

The new BJP chief of Tripura Abhishek Debroy has been a member of the Tripura Legislative Assembly, representing the Matabari constituency, since winning his seat in the 2023 assembly elections as a BJP candidate.

Archana Gupta, newly appointed Haryana BJP president, is a doctor by profession. She was serving the party as its state general secretary. Gupta takes over from Mohan Lal Badoli. Gupta, who hails from Panipat, is the second woman after Kamla Verma, a veteran BJP leader, to lead the Haryana BJP as its president. She has also previously worked as the BJP Mahila Morcha President for the Panipat district. The newly appointed Haryana BJP chief is considered a close confidant of former Punjab chief minister Capt Amarinder Singh, who had also joined the BJP in 2022 about a year after his bitter parting with the Congress.

Thunderstorms sweep Delhi after days...

According to the IMD, heatwave conditions Northwest India is expected to ease over the next three days due to incoming western disturbances and easterly winds, alongside warnings of thunderstorms, strong winds and hailstorms in several regions.

Mahesh Palawat, vice president meteorology and climate change, Skymet Weather, attributed the weather activity to a western disturbance over the hills, an induced cyclonic circulation over Rajasthan and adjoining areas, along with humid winds from the Bay of Bengal that have increased moisture levels over the city.

The IMD has issued an orange alert for Friday, forecasting thunderstorms with rain. The minimum temperature is expected to settle around 24 degrees Celsius, while the maximum temperature is likely to see a major drop and remain around 36 degrees Celsius. The weather office said the current spell of rain and thunderstorm activity is likely to continue till May 31.

Delhi had recorded 13.61 mm rainfall over five days in May before the current spell, according to the IMD. The latest pre-monsoon activity comes after the city reeled under severe heatwave conditions over the past few days.

Ex-IAS officer dies in fire

A crime team inspected the spot and an electrical inspection is underway to ascertain the exact cause of the fire. Statements of eyewitnesses have been recorded and no foul play is suspected at this stage, police added. Further investigation is in progress.

He has served on key positions with World Bank, Government of India and Government of Haryana. His last assignment was Chairperson of Committee on National Competition Policy formed by Ministry of Corporate Affairs. Prior to that, he was founding chairperson of CCI after he came back from Washington DC after serving as Executive Director at World Bank. He joined IAS in 1968, has served the Government at Centre and Haryana State in various senior positions.

Iran, US edge closer to temporary ceasefire deal

The US and Iran have traded strikes throughout the week, even as President Donald Trump has said he's confident his administration is making headway in negotiations with Iran to end the war.

On Monday, the US said it conducted what the Pentagon called "defensive" strikes on missile launch sites and minelaying boats in southern Iran. U.S. officials said late Wednesday in Washington that forces launched more strikes on Iran, shooting down four one-way attack drones that posed a threat around the strait and hitting an Iranian ground control station in Bandar Abbas that was about to launch a fifth drone. The officials were not authorised to comment publicly and spoke on the condition of anonymity. Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard via the state-run IRNA news agency acknowledged the attack around Bandar Abbas International Airport and said it launched its own retaliatory attack on the air base that launched the assault, without specifying whether the attack referenced had targeted Kuwait.

Kuwait's military announced its air defense systems intercepted incoming missiles and drones on Thursday, without providing further details on what had been targeted. Home to US Army Central's forward headquarters as well as air bases and a naval base, Kuwait repeatedly came under fire from Iran and Iranian-backed Shiite militias in Iraq before the April ceasefire.

The announcement comes as the Middle East is on the edge and talks to end the war remain in flux. Trump is looking for an agreement that will reopen the Strait of Hormuz - through which about a fifth of all traded oil and natural gas once passed. He is also seeking to get Iran to give up its stockpile of highly enriched uranium while the Islamic Republic wants economic sanctions to be lifted and frozen assets to be released to aid its shattered economy. The war has been unpopular in the US, and Iran's closure of the strait has sent oil prices skyrocketing, driving up fuel prices around the world. (*AP*)

CBI arrests Giribala Singh in Twisha case

According to officials, the CBI team reached her house around 10.30 am and continued interrogation throughout the day before formally arresting her at approximately 5.10 pm.

In a detailed 17-page order issued late Wednesday night, the HC observed that considering the seriousness of the allegations, available evidence and the ongoing stage of investigation, granting protection from arrest was not justified.

Twisha Sharma died under suspicious circumstances at her Katara Hills residence on the night of May 12, less than six months after her marriage to Samarth Singh on December 9, 2025. While her in-laws have maintained that she died by suicide, her parental family has alleged murder and accused her husband and in-laws of involvement.

On May 24, a fresh postmortem examination was conducted at AIIMS Bhopal by a team from AIIMS Delhi as part of the ongoing investigation. Following the procedure, Twisha was cremated at Bhadbhada crematorium, where her brother Major Harshit performed the last rites

Her family alleged that she was subjected to continuous mental and physical harassment for dowry by her husband and mother-in-law since the wedding. The Bhopal Police initially registered an FIR on May 15, 2025, under Sections 80(2) (dowry death), 85 (cruelty by husband or relatives), and 3(5) (common intention) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023, along with Sections 3 and 4 of the Dowry Prohibition Act, 1961, naming Samarth Singh and Giribala Singh as accused.

A Special Investigation Team (SIT) was formed under Bhopal Police Commissioner Sanjay Kumar. Samarth Singh was arrested by the SIT on May 22 from Jabalpur and initially remanded to police custody. Giribala Singh, a retired Bhopal district judge, was granted anticipatory bail by the 10th Additional Sessions Judge, Bhopal, on May 15, hours after the FIR was lodged.

On the recommendation of the Madhya Pradesh Government, the CBI took over the investigation on May 25, re-registering the state police FIR as its own case.

Two elderly women found dead in central...

According to the DCP Central's incident report, information was received at around 10:30 am. Upon reaching the premises, police found both women lying unconscious inside a room. One body was found lying on a bed. The other was found lying on the floor. Local enquiry with neighbours did not reveal any signs of foul play at this stage, though police say all angles are being examined thoroughly.

Both bodies have been sent to RML Hospital for post-mortem proceedings under Section 194 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita. Further legal action will follow after the post mortem examination.

Pradhan, Rahul spar over CBSE exam row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan and Rahul Gandhi on Thursday locked horns in social media over the CBSE exam row, with Pradhan accusing Gandhi of politicising the issue and being frustrated and the Congress leader hitting back, asserting that attacking him would not absolve the Union Minister of his "crimes".

Pradhan's attack came after Gandhi alleged irregularities in the CBSE exam system and demanded an independent judicial probe and constitution of a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to unearth the truth behind the "entire scam".

He also alleged that a firm with a murky past in Telangana was handed the contract by CBSE for digital evaluation of answer books.

Targeting Gandhi, Pradhan said the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha appeared "frustrated" due to continuous electoral defeats and accused him of opposing reforms and technological progress and accused him of politicising the issue.

"But as far as Rahul Gandhi is concerned, he seems to have reached a different state of mind. Due to continuous electoral defeats, he appears frustrated. He opposed SIR, he used to oppose EVMs, and he opposed Digital India. He does not seem to stand with India's scientific progress," he said. The minister emphasised that the CBSE's actions align with the Government of India's procurement policy and assured that if any irregularities are discovered, action will be taken against those responsible.

"As far as this issue is concerned, I take responsibility on behalf of the Government for any inconvenience, and I request everyone that this is not the time for politics. I have said this earlier as well. Politics can be done later," he said. Hitting back, Gandhi said, "Dharmendra Pradhan ji, you can attack me all you want, but it won't absolve you of your crimes. Nor will it stop me from demanding answers for 18.5 lakh children."

Posing a string of questions in a post on X, Gandhi asked why the CBSE OSM contract was handed to COEMPT — "a company already mired in controversy under its old name, Globarena?".

"On whose orders was it done? Why were no background checks done? What is the connection between COEMPT's management and the Modi Government?" Gandhi asked.

"Either you ran a background check and went ahead anyway — or you didn't run one at all. Either way, you are complicit," his post read.

Gandhi asserted that if the prime minister truly cared about the situation, he should have dismissed Pradhan long ago for jeopardising the futures of countless students.

In a post on X, Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said, "Arrogance and political *dramabaazi* is the best the Mantri Pradhan can come up with, even amidst the chaos he has created for lakhs of India's students and the absolute incompetence he has shown as minister."

He noted that Pradhan was now training his guns on the Leader of Opposition, as he was not content with slandering the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education.

"Even while his own ministry is a den of corruption and mismanagement. His thick skin and false bravado are a great fit for the Modi-Shah brand of politics: utterly shameless and disinterested in governance. Ramesh claimed that Prime Minister Modi's "patronage" was responsible for Pradhan's arrogance.

"The responsibility for the NEET-CBSE debacles is equally on the Pradhan Mantri, who has protected the Mantri even after the 2024 NTA debacle," Ramesh alleged.

Earlier, Pradhan asserted that the most important thing is that the mental stress of students and examinees should not increase.

"Certain issues have come to light regarding the CBSE Class 12 examination evaluation process, and a re-evaluation process will now begin," Pradhan said.

Nation Focus

AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MINISTER MARLES TO VISIT INDIA NEXT WEEK

Australia's Defence Minister Richard Marles will visit India next week to hold talks with his Indian counterpart Rajnath Singh on ways to expand bilateral strategic cooperation.

Marles, also Australia's Deputy Prime Minister, will join Singh at the second India-Australia Defence Ministers' Dialogue.

First held in Australia last October, this meeting reflects unprecedented progress in the bilateral defence partnership and a shared ambition to enhance cooperation, an Australian readout said.

"Australia and India are top-tier security partners. I look forward to meeting with Defence Minister Rajnath Singh to further strengthen our defence partnership following the strong progress we made during his visit to Australia last year," Marles said. (*PTI*)

Jaya Kumari (second left), sister of veteran Indian sports administrator Randhir Singh with others mourn during Randhir's last rites at Chandi Ghat in Haridwar on Thursday PTI

EMOTIONAL FAREWELL AS RANDHIR SINGH CREMATED IN HARIDWAR

Veteran sports administrator and India's first Asian Games shooting gold medallist Randhir Singh was cremated here on Thursday in the presence of family members, close associates and large number of mourners who gathered to bid farewell to one of the country's most influential sporting personality.

Singh died at his New Delhi residence on Wednesday after battling age-related ailments, bringing to an end a long and distinguished association with Indian and international sports administration. (*PTI*)

Sustainable, inclusive, rapid growth to shape policymaking in coming years: Ramesh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kozhikode (Kerala)

Senior Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Thursday said SIR-sustainable, inclusive and rapid development-would be the dominant theme of policymaking in the coming years, irrespective of which party is in power.

Delivering the MP Veerendrakumar Memorial Lecture here, Ramesh said the country would face three major challenges over the next 10 to 15 years, which he termed as SIR, with 'S' standing for sustainable development, 'I' for inclusive development and 'R' for rapid development.

He said all three were important, as the country needed economic growth that was environmentally sustainable, inclusive in ensuring benefits reached all sections of society rather than a select few, and rapid enough to create jobs for the seven to eight million Indians entering the labour market every year.

The senior Congress leader said that irrespective of which party was in power at the Centre or in the states, the priority in the coming years would be integrating the environment with development.

"Secondly, we have to create wealth, but ensure that inequalities do not widen. Thirdly, we have to expand the economy to create more and more jobs," he said.

The AICC general secretary in charge of communications also spoke about his close association with Veerendrakumar and recalled the latter's contributions.

Ramesh said he first met Veerendrakumar nearly 30 years ago after the latter was sworn in as Union Minister of State for Finance.

At the time, Ramesh was serving as an adviser to then Finance Minister P Chidambaram.

People of West Bengal endorsed SIR despite Opposition's campaign: Amit Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Ahmedabad

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday said that despite the Opposition's campaign, the people of West Bengal supported the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls along with the principle that only Indian citizens should have the right to vote.

Speaking at a gathering after inaugurating a hostel campus built by the Umiya Mataji Sansthan in Sola area of Ahmedabad, Shah said the Supreme Court too upheld the constitutional validity of the SIR exercise carried out by the Election Commission.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah during the inauguration ceremony of the newly constructed JS Patel Boys Hostel and Tapaswikumar Arvindbhai Patel Girls Hostel of Umiya Mata Sansthan in Ahmedabad PTI

"When the Election Commission initiated the SIR, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and his allied parties launched a nationwide campaign against it. They even went to the Supreme Court. But in the elections, the people of West Bengal demonstrated that they stand with the SIR," he said.

People also affirmed that infiltration into the country must not be allowed, the Union minister added.

The final verdict of the Supreme Court established that the SIR exercise was constitutionally correct, he said. The apex court on May 25 upheld the Election Commission's powers to conduct a Special Intensive Revision of voter rolls.

Shah further said the Narendra Modi government established a core principle that the right to decide the future of the country should belong only to Indian citizens and "not to infiltrators".

Forces trap foreign terrorists in Rajouri, hit hideouts with MGLs

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

A crack team of the elite Para Commandos of the Indian Army are leading multi-agency anti-terrorist operations, going on in the Dorimal-Gambhir Moghla forest belt of the Manjakote area of Rajouri district since May 23, with the sole objective of neutralising the well-entrenched group of foreign terrorists inside their safe hideout.

According to a preliminary assessment of the security forces, a heavily armed group of terrorists was trapped by the security forces during the cordon and search operations launched in the area on May 23.

After recalibrating their response so far, the security forces on Thursday once again switched gears and launched a fresh assault using a Multi grenade launcher (MGL) on the suspected hideouts of the terrorists to neutralise them.

The aggressive posturing was adopted by the ground troops after the Army commander of the Udhampur-based Northern Command headquarters, Lt-Gen Pratik Sharma, visited the ground zero of the operations and conducted a first-hand review of the ongoing anti-terrorist 'Operation Sheruwali'.

Senior officers of the Jammu and Kashmir Police and Central

Paramilitary Forces accompanied the Army Commander on ground zero. According to reports from ground zero, heavy firing was reported in the area during the day. Sounds of intermittent firing and blasts were heard from a long distance. Several media persons captured images of smoke and recorded the ongoing firing. However, it was not confirmed whether the firing was going on from both sides or the security forces were targeting the hideouts to neutralise the terrorists.

The ground troops are also relying on aerial reconnaissance missions launched by the Indian Army to track down the footprints of the terrorists inside deep jungles.

The foot soldiers have also deployed sniffer dogs in the area and used drone images to identify the suspected hideouts before launching the fire assault to smoke out the terrorists hiding inside these temporary structures.

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, Union Ministers JP Nadda, Kiren Rijiju, BJP President Nitin Nabin with other dignitaries after paying floral tributes to Swatantryaveer Vinayak Damodar Savarkar at his portrait in the Central Hall of Samvidhan Sadan, on his birth anniversary on Thursday PTI

Resolve water disputes through cooperation: PM Modi to States

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has asked States to resolve inter-state water disputes through cooperation, timely clearances and technology-based monitoring, and said the Ken-Betwa project should serve as a model.

Chairing the 51st PRAGATI meeting, where seven critical infrastructure projects across railways, power and road sectors covering nine states worth around ₹30,000 crore were reviewed on Wednesday evening, he underlined that delay in implementation of public projects leads not only to cost escalation but also deprives citizens of timely access to essential facilities.

"During yesterday's PRAGATI session, projects worth over ₹30,000 crore were reviewed. The works covered sectors like railways, power and road connectivity. Aspects relating to ports, Swachh Bharat Mission 2.0 and other social sector schemes were also discussed," Modi said in a post on X on Thursday.

Noted poet Bashir Badr passes away at 91

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Bhopal

Bashir Badr, one of most quoted Urdu poets of his generation with famous lines like "*Ujale apni yaadon ke hamare saath rehne do*", died in Bhopal on Thursday after a prolonged illness. He was 91.

The veteran poet, who was living with dementia for many years, breathed his last at his home in Bhopal, his son Syed Badr said.

"For me, for my mother, and for all his loved ones, it is a very painful day. His poetry is poetry of love and life. '*Ujaale unki yaddon ke* '.... This couplet is a representation of his life; it is his trademark. I would like all of you to celebrate this," Syed Badr said, adding that his father withdrew from public after his memory started failing him.

"He had dementia and had not been part of any mushaira (gathering of poets) for the past 10 years. That was his conscious decision because he was a showman... That is why he retired from mushairas when he realised that his memory was weakening, and he had not been active in writing or public life for quite some time. But the impact of his couplets and verses on the world has its own life," the son added.

During the Shimla Agreement between India and Pakistan in 1972, Badr wrote the famous couplet "*Dushmani jam kar karo lekin ye gunjaish rahe, jab kabhi hum dost ho jayein to sharminda na hon*".

The lines were recited by Congress leader Mallikarjun Kharge during a debate in the Lok Sabha in 2018, to which Prime Minister Narendra Modi responded with another couplet from the poet: "*Jee bahut chahta hai sach bolein, kya karein haunsla nahi hota*".

Badr's couplets are oft quoted by people in their everyday life, whether it is "*Kuch to majbooriyaan rahi hongi, yun hi koi bewafa nahi hota*" or "*Ujale apni yaadon ke hamare saath rehne do, na jaane kis gali me zindagi ki shaam ho jaye*", and "*Log toot jaate hain ek ghar banane mein, tum taras nahi khate bastiyan jalane mein*".

Noted lyricist Javed Akhtar expressed grief over Badr's demise.

Parliamentary panel summons education ministry, NTA, CBI officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

A parliamentary panel has summoned officials of the Union Education Ministry, the National Testing Agency (NTA) and the CBI to appear before it on Friday in connection with the assurances pertaining to the conduct of examinations by the testing agency.

According to a notice issued by the Rajya Sabha Secretariat on May 27, the Committee on Government Assurances will hear the views of Vineet Joshi, Secretary of the Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education, along with Abhishek Singh, Director General of NTA and Praveen Sood, Director of CBI.

The committee meeting is scheduled for 11 am on Friday.

The matter pertains to an assurance given in Rajya Sabha in reply to an unstarred question (USQ) dated November 27, 2024, regarding "Conduct of Examination by NTA", the notice said.

In its written reply to the question in November, 2024, the Education Ministry had stated that as informed by NTA, contracts for conducting

examinations are awarded to agencies "as per the extant rules, orders and guidelines issued by the Government of India".

The ministry had also informed the House that complaints against vendors are dealt with in accordance with the terms and conditions laid down in the work order or tender document and action ranges "from deduction of payment to debarment" upon ascertaining deficiency of service.

On the NEET-UG 2024 paper leak case, the ministry had said the CBI was conducting a "comprehensive investigation into the entire gamut of alleged irregularities including conspiracy, cheating, breach of trust etc." and had filed five charge sheets against 45 accused as on November 22, 2024.

The NEET-UG for admissions into medical courses took place on May 3 this year but was cancelled by the NTA on May 12 amid allegations of a paper leak. The CBI is currently investigating this matter, and a retest is scheduled for June 21.

The committee will also hear the views of Secretary of Union Health and Family Welfare Punya Salila Srivastava, National Medical Commission (NMC) chairman Abhijat Chandrakant Sheth and CBI Director regarding an assurance given in reply to Rajya Sabha USQ dated 29 July, 2025 regarding "Medical College Scam", according to the notice.

States Focus

PM HONOURS SAVARKAR ON 143RD BIRTH ANNIVERSARY

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday paid tributes to Vinayak Damodar Savarkar on his 143rd birth anniversary, and said his courage and patriotism will always inspire people.

"Remembering Veer Savarkar on his Jayanti. His courage and patriotism will always inspire people. His intellect and emphasis on social reform are also noteworthy," Modi said in a post on X.

Describing Savarkar as a "great revolutionary and fierce nationalist thinker", the prime minister said that his personality, filled with valour and intellect, will continue to inspire every generation of the nation.

Politician and ideologue and a leading figure in the Hindu Mahasabha, Savarkar was born on May 28, 1883, and died on February 26, 1966, at the age of 82. (*PTI*)

AIADMK LEADER VELLAMANDI NATARAJAN JOINS TVK

Former AIADMK minister Vellamandi R Natarajan joined the Vijay-led TVK, a source said on Thursday.

The former Tourism minister called on TVK general secretary 'Bussy' N Anand and joined the party on May 27. He is the fifth AIADMK personality to join the ruling TVK this week, following four rebel AIADMK MLAs who resigned as legislators and joined the ruling party.

Natarajan had won from the Tiruchirappalli East Assembly constituency in 2016. He had backed former Chief Minister O Panneerselvam during the leadership crisis in the party and rejoined the AIADMK in February this year when Panneerselvam joined the DMK. (*PTI*)

Sikkim Police awarded President's Police Colour

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Gangtok

President Draupadi Murmu on Thursday conferred the prestigious President's Police Colour on the Sikkim Police at an event at Paljor Stadium.

Sikkim has now become the 15th state of the country and the third in the northeast to receive the award.

The President's Police Colour, also known as '*Nishaan*', is the highest ceremonial honour bestowed upon a State or central police force in India in recognition of exceptional service, bravery, and professionalism.

The officers of the state police honoured with the President's Police Colour are authorised to wear a special emblem on the uniform. Speaking on the occasion, Murmu said, "I am delighted to have conferred the 'President's Police Medal for Distinguished Service' upon the Sikkim Police.

This honour is a matter of pride for all members of the Sikkim Police."

She praised the Sikkim Police, founded in 1897, for dedication to maintaining law and order in the strategically important state.

President Droupadi Murmu confers the Presidents Police Colour on the Sikkim Police during an event at Paljor Stadium in Gangtok PTI

Observing that the police have had a colonial bearing, having been set up to control the people instead of serving them, the President said the mindset must change, and police should become citizens' allies and guides.

"By adopting the role of an ally, trust between the public and the police will increase," she said.

Murmu called upon the police to embrace technology to deal with cybercrimes.

"Now, new challenges like cybercrime, online fraud, hacking, and deepfakes are emerging. To tackle these new challenges, the police must become proficient in the latest technology, cybersecurity, and digital investigation," she added.

Siddaramaiah thanks Karnataka in emotional post after resigning as CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Bengaluru

Congress leader Siddaramaiah on Thursday shared an emotional message thanking the people of Karnataka for their love and support during his tenure as chief minister, after resigning from the post.

Siddaramaiah shared on X a photograph of himself standing on a stage with folded hands before a gathering in a gesture of gratitude. He wrote, "Thank you. Your love. Your trust. My forever strength." The message appeared on the photograph carrying his signature.

Thanking the people for standing by him during difficult times, Siddaramaiah said in the post: "I bow my head before the people of Karnataka-the lakhs of affectionate hearts who treated me as one among their own, blessed me, encouraged me, corrected me, stood by me in difficult times and held my hand throughout this long journey. Whatever I am today is because of you."

Stating that the Constitution was his religion and the people his God, Siddaramaiah said his resignation was only from the post of chief minister and not from public life or his commitment to the people.

"Till my last breath, I will continue to fight for social justice and stand against divisive communal forces that go against the spirit of our Constitution. Thank you for your love, trust and companionship through every step of this journey," he added.

Siddaramaiah resigned as Karnataka chief minister, two days after the Congress high command asked him to step down.

Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah addressing a press conference after announcing his resignation in Bengaluru on Thursday. Deputy CM DK Shivakumar and senior Congress leaders are also seen PTI

Flanked by his deputy and successor, DK Shivakumar, Siddaramaiah addressed a packed press conference shortly after submitting his resignation to the Governor's Special Secretary at Lok Bhavan here.

Special Secretary Prabhu Shankar received the resignation as Governor Thaawarchand Gehlot was out of the state.

"I have tendered my resignation from the post of chief minister," Siddaramaiah told reporters, expressing confidence that the Governor would accept it in accordance with constitutional provisions.

Chennithala calls attack on ED outside Vijayan's home CPI(M) conspiracy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala has termed the violent attack on the vehicles of the ED officials, who raided the rented house of former CM Pinarayi Vijayan, as a "conspiracy" of the CPI(M) to disrupt law and order under the new UDF Government.

Chennithala emphasised that no one would be allowed to take the law into their hands and everyone involved in the violence, no matter how big they are, will face stringent legal action.

He said that in the state capital, the CPI(M) workers deliberately attacked the ED officials' vehicles to disrupt the normal way of life.

The Home Minister on Wednesday said that despite the lack of information to the Kerala police or Home Department from ED regarding the raids, the police on its own reached all the places where the crowd had gathered during the search.

At Vijayan's residence in Kannur and at the home of P A Mohamed Riyas in Kozhikode, there was no untoward incident after the ED raid, he said.

However, at Vijayan's rented house in the state capital, the ED officials' vehicles were violently attacked and damaged as part of a "conspiracy", he claimed.

Chennithala said that the police have photographs of all those involved in the violence, and they will face stringent action. "No one will be allowed to take the law into their hands. We are not against demonstrations and protests. But everything has a limit. Attacking ED officials who had come for an investigation and damaging their vehicles is unacceptable.

"CPI(M) workers tried to take the law into their hands. It will not be condoned. Will catch all the culprits involved in it, no matter where they are hiding, and strong police action will be taken against them," he asserted.

He also claimed that attempts to disrupt law and order in the state capital had been going on for the last two days.

"One concerning the university union and the other one that happened here," the minister said.

He further said that the police were not to be blamed for the incident.

West Bengal handed over 142.8 acres to BSF for fencing India-Bangladesh border: Suvendu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

The West Bengal Government has handed over 142.79 acres of land to the BSF for setting up outposts and barbed-wire fencing infrastructure along the India-Bangladesh border, Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari said.

The handover is part of the BJP Government's decision, taken at its first cabinet meeting on May 11, to transfer 600 acres of land within 45 days for border fencing and related infrastructure projects.

"Govt of WB has initiated intensified measures to strengthen border security by facilitating construction of BSF outposts and barbed-wire fencing, further enhancing security in the border areas.

Additional land has now been handed over to BSF, taking the total tally to 142.79 acres," the CM said in a social media post late on Wednesday.

He also shared a district-wise chart detailing the land transferred to the BSF across nine districts.

According to the chart, 22.92 acres of land have been handed over in Coochbehar, 35.16 acres in Jalpaiguri, 8.81 acres in Darjeeling, 2.84 acres in Uttar Dinajpur, and 20.17 acres in Dakshin Dinajpur.

Additionally, 10.9 acres has been handed over in Malda, 38.8 acres in Murshidabad, 0.55 acre in Nadia, and 2.6 acres in North 24 Parganas.

As part of the first phase of the initiative, 43 acres of purchased land across five districts and sanction orders for 31.9 acres of vested land were handed over to the BSF on May 20.

Panchayat elections in Himachal Pradesh sees 77% turnout; women surpass men

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE Shimla

Nearly 77 per cent polling was recorded during the second phase of the Himachal Pradesh rural body elections for 1,276 panchayats on Thursday, with women voters surpassing men in turnout in nine out of 12 districts.

"Around 76.90 percent polling has been reported till 3 pm and the percentage is likely to increase as polling is still under way at some places, and details of more than 300 booths are yet to be uploaded", State Chief Election Commissioner Anil Khachi said.

The polling was peaceful and no untoward incidents have been reported so far from any part of the state, he added.

Sirmaur district reported maximum polling till 3 pm at 84.08 per cent, while Lahaul-Spiti reported the lowest turnout at 69.38 per cent. The voting percentages for female and male electors stood at 80.03 per cent and 73.85 per cent, respectively.

Villagers in Ward No 1 of Kangri under Ree Gram Panchayat in Hamirpur district boycotted the panchayat elections, citing years of stalled development work and the failure to resolve several pending issues.

Andhra CM pays tributes to NTR on 103rd birth anniversary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Thursday paid tributes to Telugu Desam Party founder NT Rama Rao on his 103rd birth anniversary.

The chief minister said that Rama Rao, popularly known as NTR, stood as a living example of the saying that with perseverance, human beings can become sages and great personalities.

"I pay tributes to the revered leader of Telugu people, the globally acclaimed legend and great personality, NT Rama Rao, on his 103rd birth anniversary," said Naidu in a post on X. He noted that NTR, born on May 28, 1923, in Nimmakuru village of Krishna district, remains an unforgettable figure etched forever in the hearts of Telugu people.

Naidu highlighted that NTR left an indelible mark on the world of cinema through his iconic portrayals of Lord Rama and Lord Krishna and later emerged as a guiding star in politics.

131 cattle seized, eight held in Sambhajinagar ahead of Bakri Eid

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

Police in Maharashtra's Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar seized 131 cattle ahead of Bakri Eid, resulting in eight persons being apprehended, a senior official said on Thursday.

The action was taken in Jinsi area on Wednesday after information was received about cattle being kept there, he added.

The animals were brought to Jinsi police station, where they were examined by veterinarians before being sent to a cow shelter with the help of the civic body, the official said.

The police had earlier held meetings with various peace committees in the city urging them to ensure prohibited animals are not sacrificed as part of Bakri Eid rituals, he said.

Nitin Nabin tones up BJP's preparations for 2027 elections

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Starting with a three-day visit to Uttarakhand on Thursday, BJP president Nitin Nabin has hit the ground to tone up the party's preparations for the assembly polls to be held in seven states next year.

During his stay in Uttarakhand, Nabin will hold a series of meetings with the BJP leaders and workers, and seek their feedback on the party's poll preparations in the state.

The BJP chief, who will call on Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami during his visit, will also hold a meeting with state ministers to discuss poll preparations and get their feedback, sources said.

Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami with BJP National President Nitin Nabin during a meeting PTI

"The BJP national president's visit to Uttarakhand is the beginning. He will visit all other states, one after another, where elections are due next year.

"In each of these states, he will stay for about three days and hold meetings with party workers and leaders, including MLAs, and get their feedback. This series will continue now," a source in the party said.

"The BJP chief has already set in motion the party's poll preparations. He will now undertake visits to all the poll-bound states to tone up the party's preparations and fine-tune its poll strategy," the source added.

It is learnt that in the states where the BJP is in power, Nabin will also meet ministers, MLAs and senior party leaders apart from party office-bearers to discuss the party's poll strategy and get their feedback.

Assembly polls in Goa, Gujarat, Manipur, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh are due to be held in 2027. Except Punjab, the BJP is in power in the remaining states. The sources said Nabin has started the BJP's poll preparations early so that the party remains "completely prepared" when the time for elections comes.

The BJP chief on Thursday appointed Sardar Kewal Singh Dhillon as the party's Punjab unit president. The appointment of Dhillon, a Sikh, as the BJP's Punjab unit chief indicates the party's intent to strongly fight the state assembly polls due next year.

According to the sources, some state BJP leaders had been pushing for a Sikh face to lead the Punjab unit of the party.

4 lion cubs die in Gujarat's Gir forest region, 17 isolated amid viral infection scare

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Ahmedabad

Four lion cubs have died in different areas of the Gir forest region in Gujarat due to suspected infection, while 17 big cats have been isolated, officials said.

Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel held a high-level meeting over the development on Wednesday.

Four lion cubs have died in different areas of the Gir forest region, and 17 (adult) lions are being isolated and taken care of, an official release stated, citing the details shared by Principal Secretary, Forest and Environment, Vinod Rao, with the chief minister at the meeting held in Gandhinagar.

Rao informed that all the lions within a radius of 10 km of Gir Gadhada and Babaria areas are being monitored intensively, and no other symptoms of disease have been detected in them.

"All the lions in the Mahsuli area of Amreli and Bhavnagar districts are also being monitored intensively by the Forest Department, and daily reports are being received.

"As part of the safety measures against such seasonal diseases seen at the beginning of summer, the deticking and other health measures are being taken for more than 350 lions in the Gir area," the release stated.

Specialist doctors from Junagadh Veterinary College have also joined this operation, said Principal Chief Conservator of Forests Jaipal Singh.

Forest Minister Arjun Modhwadia on Tuesday said two lion cubs in the Gir forest region have died due to suspected Babesia virus infection, while three other big cats succumbed to natural causes and infighting in separate incidents.

Modhwadia, however, ruled out the possibility of any major epidemic or disease outbreak in Gir forest, the last abode of the Asiatic lions.

Babesia virus spreads through ticks and can cause weakness, coughing and nasal discharge in affected animals.

Earlier, 11 lions had died in Gujarat within a month in 2018 due to a combination of canine distemper virus and protozoal infection.

The 2025 census recorded 891 Asiatic lions in Gujarat.

Freezing vacant Govt posts cruel joke on unemployed youth: J&K Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Jammu

The Jammu and Kashmir Pradesh Congress Committee on Thursday criticised the government's decision to freeze the creation of all vacant posts as part of its austerity measures, calling it a "cruel joke" on the educated unemployed youth of Jammu and Kashmir.

Addressing a public gathering at Channi Himmat in Jammu, working president of JKPCC, Raman Bhalla, said that the decision would further aggravate the unemployment crisis in the Union Territory and shatter the hopes of thousands of qualified youth aspiring for government jobs.

"The move to freeze the creation of all vacant posts in government is a cruel joke on the educated unemployed youth of Jammu and Kashmir who are already grappling with limited employment opportunities," he said.

On Saturday, the Jammu and Kashmir government issued a circular directing all departments to execute austerity measures, labelling them as "economy and austerity measures for the rationalisation of expenditure." The order also specified that no new posts would be created.

Bhalla urged the government to immediately review and withdraw this decision, emphasising that austerity measures should not come at the cost of job creation.

"The burden of austerity should not be placed on the shoulders of unemployed youth. If the government is serious about reducing expenditure, it should begin by curtailing unnecessary spending by the ruling elite and senior bureaucrats rather than blocking employment opportunities for deserving candidates," Bhalla said.

Highlighting the growing challenge of unemployment, the Congress leader noted that unemployment among educated youth has become one of the most pressing socio-economic issues in Jammu and Kashmir due to the limited opportunities.

"Unlike many other states where industries and private enterprises provide large-scale employment, Jammu and Kashmir has a relatively weak industrial base. For decades, government service has remained one of the principal sources of stable employment for educated youth. Any decision to freeze recruitment or keep posts vacant will only deepen frustration among job seekers," he said.

Bhalla warned that prolonged unemployment could have serious social and economic consequences, including growing distress among the youth and a slowdown in the region's overall development.

Sealed by authorities, decades-old goat market in Varanasi wears deserted look on Bakrid

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Varanasi (UP)

A park which usually bustles with activities this time of the year when it turns into a goat market for Eid-ul-Azha, the decades-old Benia Bagh Bakra Market in the heart of Varanasi wore a deserted look this Bakrid after the civic body sealed it following complaints of poor sanitation and overcrowding, triggering resentment among the goat traders.

The Benia Bagh falls within a 2-km radius of the Kashi Vishwanath temple. Under the Smart City project, the park now has a children's playing area, an open gym and walking tracks.

Unlike previous years when goat sellers from several Purvanchal districts, including Ghazipur, Mau, Jaunpur and Gorakhpur, flocked to Benia Bagh, the empty park looked a pale shadow of the past on Thursday, with no jostling of animals or the men who put them up for sale.

Municipal Commissioner Himanshu Nagpal said the permission granted to the goat market, which generally opens around 10 days before Bakrid, was cancelled following an inspection after complaints of overcrowding and poor sanitation were received by the Nagar Nigam.

Goat traders, however, argued that their business had been hit badly as the authorities first granted them permission for selling goats at the park ahead of Bakrid, only to revoke it later.

According to municipal officials, the goat traders were directed to vacate the premises within three days last Friday. However, since they did not comply with the order, the market was vacated and sealed on Monday with police assistance. "The site is currently being used as a park," a municipal official said.

According to Smart City PRO Shakambhari Nandan, the goat market has been sealed due to garbage dumping noticed at the site.

The action by the civic body has drawn sharp criticism from goat traders, who said the market has been known across Uttar Pradesh for nearly four decades.

According to the traders, it opens around 10 days before Eid-ul-Azha and attracts sellers from several Purvanchal districts, including Ghazipur, Mau, Jaunpur and Gorakhpur.

The traders said shutting the market just ahead of the festival was unfair, and asked where they should go to sell their goats at such a short notice.

Afroz Alam, a local, said his family purchased goats from the Benia Bagh every year as traders from distant places gathered there and sold good-quality animals at reasonable rates.

"We have been purchasing goats from the market for decades. I was shocked to find it closed a day before Eid. I had to eventually buy the animal from a local trader at a much higher rate," Alam said.

17 HIGHWAYS IDENTIFIED FOR MONETISATION IN FY27

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

State-owned NHAI on Thursday said it has identified 17 National Highways assets with a total combined length of 1,692.5 km for monetisation under the toll-operate-transfer (TOT) and infrastructure investment trust (InvIT) modes during the financial year 2026–27.

NHAI, in a statement, said the identified National Highways assets comprise stretches across nine states, including Haryana, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, and Maharashtra.

These Highway assets collectively represent economic and logistics corridors with established traffic potential and robust connectivity significance, it added.

NHAI said the monetization exercise will be undertaken through transparent and structured mechanisms under the TOT and InvIT frameworks.

TOT and InvIT have emerged as successful models for attracting long-term institutional investment into further expanding the National Highway infrastructure by adopting innovative financing mechanisms for sustainable infrastructure development while ensuring efficient asset management and operational excellence.

BJP mocks Congress over Siddaramaiah; says new CM won't benefit Karnataka

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE Bengaluru

Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar in a conversation with Congress leader Siddaramaiah during a press conference after the latter resigned from the post of state Chief Minister in Bengaluru PTI

The BJP in Karnataka on Thursday hit out at the Congress party over the resignation of Siddaramaiah as the chief minister, alleging that whoever becomes the new CM would not benefit either Kannadigas or the state in any way.

The party accused the Congress government of stalling Karnataka's development and said that its three years in office were marked by "misuse of funds, corruption, burdening the state with debt, and deceiving the youth".

Taking to social media platform 'X', the BJP said the drama over the power struggle within the Karnataka Congress had come to a temporary end.

"The three years of achievements of @INCKarnataka amount to misuse of funds meant for Dalits, looting money from the Valmiki Corporation, deceiving youth, pushing farmers towards suicide, increasing prices for common people, and burdening Karnataka with debt," the BJP alleged.

The party further claimed that after "completely stalling Karnataka's development" and spending three years indulging only in "collection, corruption, and commission politics", the Congress had now merely put a "brief pause" in the form of a resignation. "Whoever becomes the new chief minister, it will not benefit Kannadigas or Karnataka in any way.

Their tendency to run the government by oppressing and exploiting the poor, workers, farmers, youth, women, Dalits, and backward communities will continue unchanged," the BJP claimed.

Alleging that the Congress leadership's only agenda was to "completely bankrupt Karnataka and turn the state into an ATM for the Congress high command", the BJP said the people of the state would see peaceful days only when the "anti-people government" is removed.

FSSAI issues notice to IRCTC over viral video of utensils bring washed in toilets

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Food regulator FSSAI on Thursday issued a notice to state-owned IRCTC, taking suo motu cognizance of a video posted on a social media platform that shows utensils being washed inside the toilet area of a train compartment, sources said.

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has termed this act, if true, objectionable, as it could lead to food contamination, they added.

A source said the FSSAI has served a notice to Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation Ltd (IRCTC) citing this social media video, in which utensils are allegedly being washed inside the train toilet premises.

As per the video taken by a passenger, the train number is 12223 - LTT ERS Duronto. Utensils were being washed by catering staff or contractual persons engaged by IRCTC, as per the video.

FSSAI has sought a reply from the IRCTC on this matter at the earliest.

Washing utensils in toilet areas poses serious risks of contamination and is highly objectionable from the food safety perspective, a source said.

Under Schedule 4 of the Food Safety and Standards (Licensing and Registration of Food Businesses) Regulations, 2011, food business operators have to maintain hygienic processing, handling, washing and cleaning practices so as to prevent contamination of food and food contact surfaces.

Earlier this month, the FSSAI had sought an explanation from quick-commerce player Blinkit regarding consumer complaints about the sale of poor-quality eggs on its platform, sources said.

India, China hold constructive talks on LAC; agree border peace key to normalising ties

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

India and China held "constructive" and "forward-looking" talks on the situation along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in eastern Ladakh, noting that maintaining border peace and tranquillity enabled progress in the normalisation of overall relations.

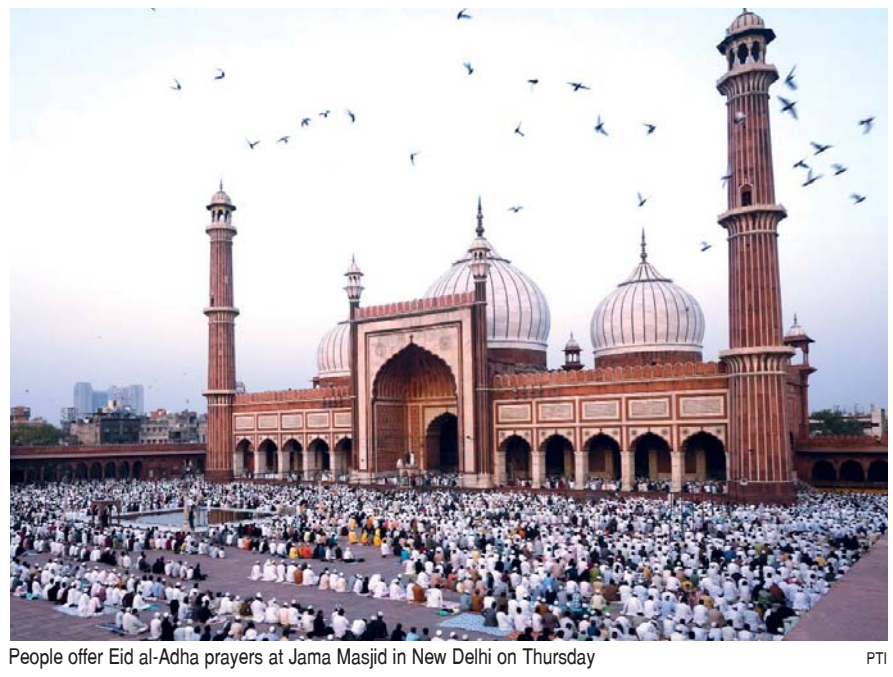
The two sides discussed various aspects of the border situation during a meeting of the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination (WMCC) in Beijing on Wednesday.

"The discussions were constructive and forward looking," the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said, a day after the talks.

India and China rolled out a series of measures in the last over one year to rebuild their relationship after it came under severe strain following the deadly Galwan Valley clashes in 2020 and the subsequent military face-off that lasted for over four years,

"The two sides reviewed the situation in the India-China border areas. They expressed satisfaction with the progress made in maintaining peace and tranquillity in the border areas, which has enabled progress towards gradual normalization of bilateral relations," the MEA said.

The two sides also agreed to work together to make "substantive preparation" for the next meeting of the Special Representatives (SR) which is to be held in China.



People offer Eid al-Adha prayers at Jama Masjid in New Delhi on Thursday PTI

TMC leader Santanu Sen resigns as national spokesperson, slams party over RG Kar row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

Former Rajya Sabha MP and TMC leader Santanu Sen on Thursday resigned as the party's national spokesperson and slammed the outfit over the controversy surrounding the R G Kar rape and murder case and described the poll defeat as a public rejection of "unethical practices".

The resignation comes at a time the TMC is battling open dissent, public recriminations and an erosion of organisational cohesion following its rout in the assembly elections.

Sen, a doctor-turned-politician and councillor of the Kolkata Municipal Corporation, submitted his resignation to TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee, saying he could no longer continue defending issues that had alienated ordinary people.

"Accepting the people's verdict, I have decided to resign from the post of national spokesperson," Sen wrote in his letter. He, however, has not quit the party.

In the letter, Sen said that despite being a "loyal soldier" of the TMC since its inception, he was no longer morally comfortable in publicly defending controversies linked to the party.

"In several difficult situations, even when my conscience did not agree, I fought publicly for the party in television debates and media platforms and had to face criticism from common people," he wrote. "But now, when people have rejected us over the RG Kar incident, job scam and various unethical acts and corruption, my conscience no longer permits me to support these as a spokesperson," he said.

The RG Kar Medical College and Hospital controversy has remained one of the most politically damaging episodes for the TMC in recent years.

The rape and murder of an on-duty doctor at the state-run hospital last year triggered massive protests across Bengal and sparked sustained outrage among sections of civil society, doctors and students.

Allegations of institutional corruption and attempts to suppress dissent further intensified the backlash.

Sen, himself a former student and doctor associated with RG Kar, had emerged as one of the few TMC leaders to publicly raise questions over alleged irregularities at the institution following the incident.

His remarks had embarrassed the party leadership at the time. He was suspended for "anti-party activities" and removed from the post of spokesperson before being reinstated months later.

Soon after the change of guard in Bengal, Sen congratulated the new BJP government and Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on social media, which caused considerable discomfort within TMC circles.

TMC MP Kakoli accuses party colleague Kalyan Banerjee of abuse, misogyny amid fresh party rift

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

Internal faultlines within the TMC widened further on Thursday as senior MP Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar complained to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla against party colleague Kalyan Banerjee, accusing him of repeated verbal abuse inside Parliament and misogynistic behaviour towards women Parliamentarians.

The public escalation of hostilities between two senior TMC Lok Sabha MPs came barely 24 hours after Ghosh Dastidar quit all organisational posts in the party, citing growing disillusionment with its functioning and indirectly targeting sections of the leadership.

In her letter to the Speaker, the four-term Barasat MP sought permission to formally lodge a complaint against Banerjee and demanded punitive action.

"I seek your permission to lodge a formal complaint to you for redressal against Lok Sabha Member of AITC Kalyan Banerjee, who has repeatedly verbally abused me inside the Lok Sabha. This misogyny has been against many lady members and needs to be punished," Ghosh Dastidar wrote.

Though she did not specify any particular incident in the letter, the complaint has added another volatile layer to the increasingly public factional tensions within the ruling party after its electoral reversal earlier this month.

Banerjee, one of the TMC's most combative parliamentarians and a trusted troubleshooter of the leadership, hit back sharply and questioned both the timing and intent behind the allegations.

"If any incident had actually occurred inside the House, it should have been brought to the Speaker's notice immediately in keeping with parliamentary procedure. Raising such allegations much later naturally raises questions about the intent and timing behind them," Banerjee, the Sreerampur MP, told reporters.

He also questioned how the complaint letter, dated May 28, was submitted on a parliamentary holiday.

"Such claims are completely baseless. This appears more like a calculated political move than a genuine grievance," the four-term MP said. The confrontation between the two MPs carries political significance within the TMC because it comes days after a key reshuffle in the party's parliamentary hierarchy.

On May 14, TMC chairperson Mamata Banerjee reappointed Kalyan Banerjee as the party's chief whip in the Lok Sabha, replacing Ghosh Dastidar during a meeting of party MPs — a move widely interpreted in political circles as a reaffirmation of the Sreerampur MP's standing within the leadership despite repeated controversies around him.

Editor's TAKE

India to rule the skies with stealth bomber

India is aspiring to make a stealth bomber — its most audacious defence project to date — a move that signals a technological coming-of-age

If all goes as per the plan, by 2032 India would join the select club of three countries - the USA, China and Russia - that have fifth-generation stealth multirole fighters. The Ministry of Defence has issued a Request for Proposal (RFP) to three shortlisted private-sector consortia for the development and production of five prototypes of India's fifth-generation stealth fighter, the Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA), under a ₹15,000-crore project. For a nation long dependent on foreign suppliers for frontline combat aircraft, this is a watershed moment. But the country will have to wait for at least six years to have this stealth bomber made in India.

The AMCA is a fifth-generation, medium-weight, multi-role, twin-engine stealth fighter being designed and developed indigenously. Such platforms typically include stealth, low-probability-of-intercept radar, advanced avionics, and highly integrated computer systems capable of networking across the battlespace. The prototypes are expected to fly by 2032, with the IAF eventually receiving a homegrown fifth-generation fighter. Three private-sector-led consortia are in the race: Larsen & Toubro-Bharat Electronics Limited, Tata Advanced Systems Limited, and Bharat Forge-BEML. Notably, HAL, a public sector company has been excluded from the prototype race. Tata Advanced Systems, with its established aerospace manufacturing credentials, is widely considered the frontrunner.

The AMCA programme is not for the faint-hearted. The engineering demands of fifth-generation aviation are among the most complex in modern technology. Stealth coatings, internal weapons bays, advanced AESA radar, and supercruise engines represent the cutting edge – and India is attempting all of it simultaneously. The engine question is particularly fraught: the first two squadrons are expected to fly with GE-F414 engines, while an indigenous engine is being developed on a parallel track. History warns us to be skeptical: India's gas turbine development has faced decades of delays. But one must strive to develop cutting-edge technology as no one would share such a technology anyway.

Then there is the institutional challenge. India's defence procurement has a troubled track record with timelines. The AMCA itself has been in various stages of conception and delay since the 2000s, with first-flight targets that have repeatedly shifted. Bluntly assessed, the project is audacious and ambitious, but achievable – on a longer timeline than officially stated. The involvement of India's most capable private defence firms injects a new urgency and efficiency that the purely public-sector model lacked. Still, a 2032 first flight and service entry around 2035 would require everything to go right.

The AMCA does not exist in a vacuum. China's J-20 is already operational, and Pakistan has reportedly shown interest in China's J-35. It may trigger a new phase of arms race in the sub-continent. Yet dependence on imported fighter jets is strategically untenable. The AMCA is not just a fighter jet, but India's declaration that it intends to rule the skies.

Can Vijay follow NTR's political script?

As Vijay enters politics, comparisons with MG Ramachandran are natural, but his rise more closely mirrors NT Rama Rao, who entered politics at the peak of his cinematic fame and quickly built a strong support base

KALYANI SHANIKAR

In the vibrant South Indian political landscape, movies have often been intertwined with politics. Few personalities exemplify this connection better than two film superstars, Vijay and NT Rama Rao (NTR). They both share a common link: they became chief ministers shortly after launching their parties. As a leading Tamil superstar, comparisons with MG Ramachandran (MGR) are common for Vijay, but a more fitting parallel might be Nandamuri Taraka Rama Rao (NTR) of Andhra Pradesh. Vijay, like NTR, entered politics at the peak of his fame and quickly found success. As he is still new to politics, it is important to be patient and give him time to demonstrate his leadership potential.

Both matinee idols leveraged their on-screen fame to become Chief Ministers in Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh, transforming their fan clubs into political support. NTR said he wanted to serve the people after completing all his duties. Vijay said that he would leave the film industry to help people. He said, "For the fans who gave up everything for me, I'm stepping away from cinema altogether."

After he started the party, NTR toured the state in an old Chevrolet car that looked like a chariot, named Chaityana Ratham (chariot of awakening). He travelled around the state, even though elections were still a year away, showing himself as an alternative to the Congress, the ruling party in Andhra Pradesh. NTR became Chief Minister of Andhra Pradesh just nine months after founding the Telugu Desam Party, demonstrating how quickly film stars can influence politics.

In Tamil Nadu, important political figures include CN Annadurai and M. Karunanidhi from the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and film stars MG Ramachandran (MGR) and J. Jayalalithaa from the AIADMK. MGR, a former film star, left the DMK due to internal conflicts and founded his own party, the AIADMK. His transition from cinema to politics was emblematic of how film stars became central to Tamil regional identity and political power, with MGR serving as Chief Minister from 1977 to 1987. Their careers exemplify the deep intertwining of cinema and regional political leadership in Tamil Nadu, illustrating the cultural significance of film stars in shaping local politics.

MGR's tenure was marked by grassroots welfare initiatives, such as the "Two Rupees a kg rice" program and mid-day meals for schoolchildren, which fostered a sense of trust and respect for his commitment to the common people.

> NOW THAT VIJAY IS IN POWER, WITHOUT ANY ADMINISTRATIVE EXPERIENCE, WE MUST GIVE HIM HIS HONEYMOON PERIOD OF SIX MONTHS AND SEE HOW HE PERFORMS

Each leader represents the hopes and needs of their time. NTR faced the social and economic challenges of the past, while Vijay faces the rapid changes of today. Their stories show how cinema continues to shape public life and influence politics. life.

NT Rama Rao (NTR) was a prominent leader in Telugu and Tamil cinema, best known for playing mythological characters. In 1982, he started the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) to promote pride and welfare for Telugu people. His simple message focused on food, shelter, and clothing, leading to important programs like the ₹2 per kilogram rice scheme. His career exemplifies how film stars can leverage regional identity to influence politics and mobilise support among local communities.

NTR was elected three times with large majorities, but his governments never completed their full terms. He was a charismatic leader who understood the struggles of poor people. He made a lasting impact on politics through his initiatives and connections with grassroots movements. He was also a strong public speaker. He starred in over 300 films, primarily in Telugu cinema, and was known as "Viswa Vikhyatha Nata Sarvabhouma." He acted in over 300 films in his career from 1949 to 1982.

NTR focused on regional identity and welfare during his political career. In contrast, Vijay tackles economic issues and concerns of young people in his approach. NTR died in a state of sadness, while Vijay is still building his political legacy in a difficult environment.

NTR was seen as a kind leader who worked closely with local communities to provide direct benefits. In contrast, Vijay positions himself as a forward-thinking reformer, addressing today's youth's needs with a modern approach and adapting quickly to change.

Vijay ended the long-standing Dravidian dominance in South Indian politics. He gained significant political support just two years after founding his party, offering hope for new leadership in the region. Meanwhile, NTR ended Congress rule in Andhra Pradesh.

Vijay's initial style as Chief Minister was distinctly corporate, prioritising transparency and centralised financial reporting to tackle debt, illustrating his focus on managing a modern economy.

Vijay's approach differs from NTR's. While NTR focused on fighting corruption and promoting rural welfare, Vijay targets the aspirations of today's youth. He portrays himself as relatable and often plays the underdog in his films. By connecting with young voters through strong social media campaigns, Vijay emphasises transparency and modern economic policies. By incorporating anti-corruption themes, he builds his political identity and gains loyalty from young fans.

Now that Vijay is in power, without any administrative experience, we must give him his honeymoon period of six months and see how he performs.

The writer is a popular columnist
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PIC TALK

People greet each other on the occasion of Eid al-Adha at Jama Masjid, in New Delhi. PHOTO: PTI

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Suryakiran's 30-Year flight across Indian skies

SAYAN CHATTERJEE

2ND OPINION

Formed in 1996 at Air Force Station Bidar in Karnataka, Suryakiran was established as the Indian Air Force's dedicated aerobatic display team. The unit originally flew the HJT-16 Kiran trainer aircraft, from which it derived its name. Over time, the team's striking red-and-white jets became synonymous with Indian aviation displays, drawing huge crowds wherever they performed.

For the last three decades, the red-and-white aircraft of the Suryakiran Aerobatic Team have remained one of the most recognisable sights in Indian and international skies (through participation). Known for their sharp formations, colourful smoke trails, and breathtaking precision, the team has become the public face of the Indian Air Force at air shows and national celebrations across the country.

What separates Suryakiran from ordinary flying is the level of precision involved. Pilots fly at high speeds while maintaining extremely close distances between aircraft during loops, barrel rolls, mirror passes, and synchronised formations. In many manoeuvres, aircraft fly only a few metres apart, demanding extraordinary concentration and trust between pilots. At its peak, Suryakiran operated with a formidable nine aircraft flying together, making it one of the largest aerobatic teams in Asia. Every pilot selected into the team is first a trained Indian Air Force officer. Aerobatic flying is considered among the toughest forms of aviation because it combines high-speed manoeuvring with split-second decision-making under intense physical pressure. Selection into Suryakiran has long been viewed as both prestigious and demanding within the Air Force.

Over the years, the team has performed at Republic Day celebrations, Aero India exhibitions in Bengaluru, and air displays across India, becoming a major attraction for aviation enthusiasts and the public alike. For many young Indians, watching Suryakiran was often their first close glimpse of military aviation. The team's journey, however, was not without setbacks. In 2011, Suryakiran was temporarily disbanded due to aircraft shortages and operational priorities within the Indian Air Force. The decision disappointed aviation followers across the country, many of whom believed the famous display team might never return. But four years later, in 2015, Suryakiran returned with a new identity and a new aircraft platform — the Hawk Mk132 Advanced Jet Trainer. The induction of the Hawk significantly modernised the team, offering improved performance capability, avionics, and safety standards.

The team has also faced moments of tragedy. In 2019, two pilots lost their lives in a crash during a practice sortie ahead of Aero India in Bengaluru, underlining the risks associated with formation aerobatic flying, where margins for error remain extremely small. Yet, despite losses and interruptions, Suryakiran endured. Today, the team represents more than aerial entertainment. It has become a symbol of precision, discipline, professionalism, and the softer side of military aviation diplomacy — one that connects directly with civilians, within and across borders, through skill and spectacle rather than conflict. As Suryakiran completes thirty years, the team continues to evolve while retaining the spirit that made it iconic. During its latest public performance, the formation once again painted the sky with its signature tricolour smoke trails before breaking into a perfectly synchronised manoeuvre that drew applause from thousands watching below.

It was a familiar sight — fast jets, perfect timing, and silence turning into awe. Three decades later, Suryakiran still does what it has always done best: reminding India that flying, at its highest level, is as much about trust and precision as it is about speed.

The writer is an educationist and senior columnist

DEMOCRACY CANNOT SURVIVE THROUGH PERMANENT POLITICAL BINARIES

There has been a growing trend of the 'Us vs Them' dichotomy in Indian politics, reflecting a steady decline in the ethos of democratic engagement. The idea of the vital grey area, where common ground can be discovered through dialogue and compromise, is gradually disappearing. Politics today is increasingly shaped by rigid binaries, where disagreement is often mistaken for hostility and ideological differences leave little room for meaningful engagement.

However, this was not always the character of Indian politics. In the years following Independence, the political landscape was fragmented yet intellectually vibrant. Although the Congress remained the dominant force, several political streams emerged with alternative visions for the country. These ideological divergences were not discouraged; rather, they were seen as essential for the healthy functioning of democracy in a newly independent nation. Before the first general elections in 1951, Syama Prasad Mookerjee stepped out of Jawaharlal Nehru's cabinet to establish the Bharatiya Jana Sangh, the precursor to the Bharatiya Janata Party. Similarly, BR Ambedkar formed the Scheduled Castes Federation, while leaders like Ram Manohar Lohia and Jayaprakash Narayan strengthened the Socialist movement. Despite differences, politics then allowed space for dissent, debate and constructive engagement. Today, there is an urgent need to move beyond the 'black and white' approach that deepens polarisation. National issues must not be viewed solely in binary terms if democracy is to remain inclusive and resilient.

R NARAYANAN | MUMBAI

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In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The green legacy of Devaki Amma

The recent conferment of the Padma Shri on Kollakkayil Devaki Amma, the 92-year-old from Alappuzha, is a welcome recognition of her quiet and sustained environmental work over several decades. Her successful afforestation efforts helped revive once barren coastal land and created a remarkable example of community-led conservation. At a time when Kerala faces coastal erosion, changing rainfall patterns, and declining green cover, such efforts carry even greater significance. Devaki Amma's five-acre forest, Tapovanam, now supports over three thousand indigenous medicinal plants and local species.

Her work offers valuable lessons for local panchayats, environmental groups, and forest departments seeking to encourage similar grassroots initiatives. Schools should arrange educational visits to such sites so students can understand the difference between natural biodiversity and monoculture plantations. Small but meaningful measures such as distributing indigenous saplings, teaching basic conservation techniques, and recognising more grassroots environmentalists can significantly strengthen local ecological awareness. Environmental change often begins with ordinary individuals working quietly for years. Recognising such unsung heroes inspires future generations towards conservation.

A MYILSAMI I COIMBATORE

Remembering Raja Randhir Singh

The passing of Raja Randhir Singh marks the end of an extraordinary chapter in Indian sports history. A five-time Olympian shooter and recipient of the Arjuna Award in 1979, he was not only one of India's finest sportspersons but also a visionary administrator who devoted his life to the development of sports in India and across Asia.

He created history at the 1978 Asian Games in Bangkok by winning the men's trap shooting gold medal, bringing pride to the nation at a time when India was striving to establish itself in international shooting.

His contribution, however, extended far beyond medals and personal achievements. Through his decades-long association with the Indian Olympic Association, the Olympic Council of Asia and the International Olympic Committee, he played a major role in strengthening India's sporting presence globally. Known for his humility, discipline and deep respect for athletes, he inspired generations of Indian sportspersons and administrators alike. His passing is a profound loss to Indian sports, but his legacy will continue to guide and inspire the Olympic movement in India

SANJAY CHOPRA | PUNJAB

Every vote must count

The Supreme Court's validation of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Bihar rests on a simple democratic principle: governance must be guided by the realities of eligible voters, not abstract assumptions. By recognising the legitimacy of the SIR, the Court affirmed that democracy is not merely about ballots, but also about understanding the composition of the electorate to ensure fair representation and targeted welfare. The Court rejected the challenge to the exercise and held that the SIR helped secure the mandate of free and fair elections.

Accurate electoral data enables governments to design policies that better reflect social realities, helping bridge gaps in education, healthcare and employment. For the Opposition, the verdict should serve as a reminder to move from obstruction towards constructive engagement. Instead of dismissing the exercise as partisan, they should scrutinise its findings, propose safeguards against misuse, and demand transparency in implementation.

Ultimately, the verdict challenges all political parties to elevate public debate from rhetoric to responsibility. The Court rightly stressed that electoral purity matters as much as polling itself, and that democracy thrives when every voter is counted, not discounted.

O PRASADA RAO | HYDERABAD

Fire Safety: A growing crisis amid climate change and urban expansion

Disaster risks in Indian cities are advancing much faster than disaster management strategies currently in place. There is a dire need for the modernisation of firefighting facilities through adoption of advanced rescue equipment, smart fire detectors, AI monitoring systems, and command-and-control centres

SATENDRA SINGH

India's cities are growing at an unprecedented pace. New highways, industrial corridors, commercial complexes and towering residential buildings have become symbols of a rapidly modernising nation. Yet beneath this narrative of progress lies a danger that receives attention only when tragedy strikes. Whether in hospitals, schools, coaching centres, factories, shopping malls or high-rise apartments, fire accidents have become disturbingly frequent across the country. The growing number of such incidents suggests that India is facing not merely a series of isolated accidents but a larger crisis shaped by climate change, rapid urbanisation, inadequate planning and poor enforcement of safety regulations.

Recent fire incidents across Delhi-NCR, Kolkata, Hyderabad, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu and several other states have highlighted the scale of the problem. These disasters have caused loss of life, property destruction, environmental damage, and high economic costs. More importantly, they reveal that fire disasters are no longer isolated incidents. They are the result of multiple interconnected factors, including climate change, rising temperatures, unplanned urbanisation, ageing infrastructure, weak regulatory enforcement, and human negligence.

India has witnessed unusually high temperatures, prolonged heat waves, erratic rainfall patterns and extended dry spells in recent years. Scientists have linked many of these trends to global warming and recurring El Niño events, which contribute to hotter and drier conditions. Higher temperatures dry out vegetation, reduce moisture levels and create conditions in which fires can spread rapidly. At the same time, increased dependence on air conditioners, coolers and other electrical appliances during extreme heat places enormous pressure on power infrastructure. Overloaded systems, overheating transformers and short circuits frequently become the trigger for urban fires.

The Urban Heat Island Effect has further intensified these risks in metropolitan areas. Dense clusters of concrete buildings, asphalt roads, vehicular emissions and shrinking green spaces trap heat and significantly raise temperatures in cities. As urban centres become hotter, the likelihood of heat-related fire incidents increases. This demonstrates how environmental stress and urban development are increasingly intersecting in ways that place cities at greater risk.

The effects of climate change are equally visible in India's forests. States such as Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Odisha, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, and several north eastern states regularly experience forest fires during dry seasons. Rising temperatures, declining soil moisture and changing rainfall patterns have made many ecosystems more vulnerable. Human activities such as unattended campfires, agricultural burning, discarded cigarette ends and deliberate forest fires further worsen the situation. The consequences extend far beyond the loss of vegetation. Forest fires destroy biodiversity, damage wildlife habitats, release large quantities of carbon emissions, worsen air pollution and threaten the livelihoods of forest-dependent communities.

At the same time, India's rapidly expanding cities are creating new and complex fire safety challenges. Metropolitan centres are witnessing unprecedented growth in high-rise residential and commercial buildings. While vertical development also raises serious questions about emergency preparedness. Many firefighting systems are not adequately equipped to deal with fires in ultra-high-rise structures.

The challenges do not end here. Narrow roads, traffic congestion, illegal parking, encroachments, low water pressure and blocked emergency routes frequently delay firefighting operations. In many residential and commercial complexes, fire alarms, sprinklers, smoke extraction systems and emergency exits are poorly maintained or non-functional.

Unplanned urbanisation compounds these risks. Illegal constructions, overcrowded neighbourhoods, inadequate spacing between buildings and the operation of hazardous industries within residential areas create conditions in which even a small fire can escalate rapidly. In older parts of many cities, narrow lanes make it difficult for fire engines to reach affected locations. Such constraints often turn manageable incidents into major disasters, highlighting the need for safety-centred urban planning. A significant proportion of fire disasters in India are preventable. Investigations into major incidents repeatedly reveal familiar causes: faulty wiring, overloaded electrical systems, blocked exits, unauthorised construction, poor maintenance and improper storage of flammable materials. Although India has building regulations and fire safety norms, implementation often remains weak. Fire safety audits are frequently treated as procedural formalities rather than rigorous inspections. Administrative negligence, inadequate monitoring and lack of accountability allow violations to persist until disaster strikes.

Human negligence remains another major contributor. Emergency exits are commonly locked or used for storage, firefighting equipment is neglected and electrical systems are poorly maintained. Public awareness regarding basic fire safety measures remains limited. In an increasingly urbanised society, such complacency can have devastating consequences. The risks become even more severe in institutions that cater to vulnerable populations. Fires in hospitals can be particularly deadly because patients in intensive care units, oxygen-supported wards and critical care facilities cannot be evacuated quickly.

Similarly, schools, coaching centres and hostels often function from buildings that were never designed for educational use. Overcrowding, narrow staircases, poor ventilation, locked exits and inadequate emergency planning can transform a minor incident into a catastrophe within minutes. The safety of children, patients and other vulnerable groups cannot be compromised due to commercial interests or administrative oversight. Industrial and chemical fires present another growing concern. The expansion of chemical plants, petroleum facilities, warehouses, plastic recycling units, paint industries, gas storage centres and fireworks manufacturing units has increased the scale of potential hazards. Many such facilities handle highly combustible materials daily. Several accidents in recent years have exposed serious shortcomings in industrial safety standards.

An often overlooked aspect of fire disasters is the danger posed by smoke inhalation. In many cases, smoke causes more fatalities than flames. Modern buildings contain plastics, synthetic materials, chemicals and electrical components that release highly toxic fumes when burned. Smoke spreads rapidly through stairwells, corridors and ventilation systems, reducing visibility and oxygen levels within minutes.

Public awareness about smoke-related hazards remains inadequate. Simple measures such as staying close to the ground, avoiding lifts, covering the nose and mouth and following evacuation procedures can save lives, yet such information is not widely understood.

Despite growing risks, many fire departments continue to face shortages of trained personnel, modern equipment and specialised rescue technology. Several cities still lack aerial firefighting platforms capable of reaching the upper floors of skyscrapers. The modernisation of fire services has therefore become essential. Investments in smart fire detectors, AI-powered monitoring systems, drones, GIS-based mapping, emergency communication networks and integrated command and control centres can significantly improve response capabilities. Equally important is specialised training for firefighters in handling high-rise emergencies, hazardous materials and industrial accidents.

Addressing fire safety requires a broader governance approach. Responsibility cannot rest solely with fire departments. Municipal authorities, urban planners, builders, industries, electricity providers, educational institutions, resident welfare associations and citizens all have a role to play. Wider roads, stricter zoning regulations, improved building standards, underground cabling, removal of encroachments and rigorous safety audits must become integral to urban development. Fire resilience should also be incorporated into Smart City initiatives and future infrastructure planning.

Community preparedness is equally important. Fire safety education should become part of schools, workplaces and public awareness programmes. Mock drills must be conducted seriously rather than as procedural exercises. Citizens must adopt safer practices, including proper maintenance of electrical systems, keeping escape routes clear and ensuring that firefighting equipment remains functional. The media, too, has an important role in promoting awareness and fostering a culture of preparedness.

India stands at a critical juncture. The country can continue reacting to disasters after they occur or embrace a proactive approach centered on prevention, preparedness and resilience. Most fire disasters are preventable, but prevention requires political commitment, administrative accountability, technological innovation and public participation.

As India advances towards greater urbanisation, industrialisation and economic growth, safety must become a central pillar of development. Fire safety is no longer merely a technical concern; it is an essential component of sustainable development, public welfare and national security. The growing frequency and scale of fire-related disasters serve as a warning that cannot be ignored. The cost of inaction will continue to be measured in lives lost, communities disrupted and opportunities diminished. The time to act is now.

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Rubio in India: Did he succeed in repairing the India-US partnership?

AMBASSADOR ASHOK SAJJANHAR

The US Secretary of State Marco Rubio visited India for four days from May 23-26, 2026. It was his first visit to India after assuming office in January 2025.

Relations between India and the US have grown progressively over the last quarter of a century. The two countries started on a positive note in Trump's second term with an early and substantive stand-alone visit by PM Narendra Modi to the White House on 13th February, 2025.

In a surprising move, however, the US slapped 25 per cent tariffs on imports from India on April 3rd, 2025. This was followed on 10th May, 2025, by President Trump's announcement about the ceasefire between India and Pakistan in the Op Sindoor conflict, even before India had made the announcement. India never accepted Trump's claim of having mediated the ceasefire. Matters deteriorated further with the imposition of an additional 25 per cent penalty tariff on Indian goods due to the purchase of Russian oil. Other importers, including China, which imported more Russian oil and gas than India, were left untouched.

The last year also witnessed several derogatory remarks emanating from the right-wing Trump support base and senior officials of the US administration. Trump's frequent compliments to PM Modi in recent months, amidst such remarks against India and Indians, have been viewed as patronising in India.

It was against this background that Rubio undertook his visit. He called on PM Modi, held bilateral discussions with EAM Jaishankar and National Security Adviser Ajit Doval, and participated in the Quad foreign ministers' meeting. In addition to New Delhi, he travelled to Kolkata, Agra and Jaipur. Recent months have also witnessed the US cosying up to Pakistan and China, the two avowed adversaries of India.

Bilateral discussions

Rubio had announced before his departure for India that he would encourage India to buy more energy from the US and possibly also from Venezuela. On the economic front, Rubio and Jaishankar spoke about the value of concluding the interim agreement regarding reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade. Energy formed a significant aspect of the discussions, as ensuring the accessibility and affordability of energy for India's 1.4 billion people remains India's prime objective. The ministers also discussed nuclear energy cooperation in the backdrop of the recent visit by an American delegation.

On defence and security, a comprehensive underwater domain awareness roadmap was signed. Cooperation in critical minerals and Pax Silica received special mention. A bilateral agreement to promote partnership and ensure trusted, reliable supply chains in this crucial field was inked.

Jaishankar raised the problems faced by legitimate Indian travellers in the issuance of visas by the US and expressed India's expectation that legal mobility from India would not be hampered. The necessity of continued strong cooperation and zero tolerance towards terrorism was highlighted.

The Quad deliberations

The Quad foreign ministers' meeting took place on May 26, 2026. This was the third such meeting since Trump assumed office in January 2025. There has been considerable disquiet in Indian political and academic circles as the Quad Summit, to be hosted by India in 2025, was not held, and there is no indication of where and when it might take place. Observers see this as evidence of the US losing interest in the Quad. In Trump's first term, the Quad was revived in 2017 after a decade of hibernation. Trump had then identified China as a systemic threat with the capacity and intent to dislodge the US from its pre-eminent global position. In his second term, after facing pushback from China through export controls on critical minerals, Trump termed China not a strategic threat but a commercial competitor.

The Quad foreign ministers' meeting was therefore a welcome opportunity to revitalise the forum. It is widely recognised that China is perceived as a security threat in the Indo-Pacific. All Quad members seek active US engagement to ensure peace, security, and a free, open and rules-based Indo-Pacific. The Quad decided to expand cooperation under the Indo-Pacific Partnership for Maritime Domain Awareness (IPMDA). It launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Surveillance Collaboration (IPMSC) to strengthen coordination in maritime surveillance.

The ministers strongly condemned terrorism in all its forms, including cross-border terrorism, and condemned the terrorist attack in Pahalgam in April 2025.

Conclusion

Being smart, articulate and a long-time supporter of India, Rubio tried to undertake as much damage control as possible. His visit, which combined the bilateral agenda alongside the Quad foreign ministers' meeting, attempted to repair one of the worst phases in bilateral ties caused largely by Washington's unilateral moves, while also trying to revive the Quad framework, which had remained moribund over the past year. Timely implementation of the decisions taken during Rubio's visit will determine the success of his trip.

The writer is an Executive Council Member at the Manohar Parrikar Institute for Defence Studies and Analyses, Distinguished Fellow at the Ananta Aspen Centre, and former Ambassador of India to Kazakhstan, Sweden and Latvia

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Falling infant mortality, rising gender bias: Why India's baby girls still don't survive

SWAPNA MAJUMDAR

First, the good news - infant mortality rate (IMR) in India has gone down from 30 to 24 deaths per 1,000 live births between 2019 and 2024. According to the recently released Sample Registration System (SRS) 2024, this decline, by an average of one point annually, has been the fastest so far. However, the not-so-good news is that many states like Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Assam, Odisha and Rajasthan are still lagging behind and have a higher IMR than the national average of 24.

But the more worrying news is that gender disparities continue to persist. More girls die before they reach the age of one than boys, and this is seen even in states like Odisha, which has brought down its IMR by a significant 21 points.

In fact, most of them do not survive beyond four weeks. The SRS report reveals that the number of newborn deaths during the first 28 days of life per 1,000 live births, or neonatal mortality rate (NMR), now accounts for nearly 73 per cent of all infant deaths. So, in states with high IMR gender gaps, it is unsurprising that baby girls have less chance of surviving beyond 28 days after birth than boys.

The first 24 to 48 hours are crucial for the survival of the mother and child, say doctors. In Bihar, which has the highest gender gap (IMR was 25 for female infants compared to 21 for males), many women, especially in rural areas, tend to leave the hospital within six to eight hours of giving birth, increasing the vulnerability of both the newborn and the mother. This could be one of the reasons why one in every 37 infants in rural areas still dies before completing one year of life, compared to one in 59 in urban regions.

If the child is lucky enough to survive, her gender is, more often than not, the reason for the lack of proper breastfeeding needed to nourish and keep her healthy and alive. It has been seen that gender discrimination is highest for the second or third daughter, who faces nutritional neglect leading to dietary deficiencies.

The survival of baby girls is not solely dependent on household wealth. Girls in states like West Bengal often have a better chance of celebrating their first birthday than those in richer states like Punjab or Haryana. This is because West Bengal has maintained a high sex ratio at birth (the number of females per 1,000 males), reflecting gender equity at birth. It was 973 girls per 1,000 boys according to the latest National Family Health Survey-5. Punjab and Haryana continue to be

plagued by a strong preference for sons, leading to female foeticide carried out surreptitiously through illegal sex-selective abortions. In Haryana, the first four months of 2026 saw a sharp fall in the sex ratio at birth (SRB) to 898 girls per 1,000 boys, down from 909 recorded in the first four months of 2025 and 923 recorded for the entire year.

Another reason for daughters not being wanted is the fear of dowry. Unfortunately, dowry remains an accepted social custom, as many parents feel it will make their daughter's new life easier. Many mortgage everything they have or take loans beyond their means to meet the demands made by the groom and his family.

But this has not always saved their daughters from harassment, abuse and even death. In 2024, an average of 16 women died every day due to dowry-related violence, according to the latest National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) data released on May 6, 2026. The country recorded 5,737 dowry deaths, or an overall national dowry death rate of 0.8 cases per lakh women population. High-population states like Uttar Pradesh (2,038) and Bihar (1,078) led in total cases and also recorded the highest dowry death rates, at 1.8 and 1.7 per lakh women population, respectively.

So, when the chief minister of a state officially offers financial incentives for the birth of the third and fourth child to combat the drop in population and total fertility rate, it is equally transactional. He fears the state will lose out on its share in political representation and central finances because its population is falling relative to most parts of the country. Also, Andhra Pradesh lifted the ban on people with more than two children contesting local body elections not because of the problems faced by women through abandonment, or the trauma of giving up their third or fourth child, but for political gains. Both these steps undercut women's basic reproductive right of choosing when and whether to give birth. Unless women collectively push back, their bodily autonomy and their right to be born, survive and thrive, will continue to be disregarded and overlooked.

The writer is journalist writing on development and gender

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SC stays order to seal structures near Delhi Golf Club

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Granting "extraordinary indulgence", the Supreme Court has stayed till July 22 its order directing the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) and Delhi Police to seal structures within the 100-metre prohibited zone of a protected monument near the entrance gate of the Delhi Golf Club.

A bench of Justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and N Kotiswar Singh passed the order after senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Delhi Golf Club, sought time to respond and come up with suggestions.

"Though the court does not find any ground for any rethinking, however, by way of extraordinary indulgence, the implementation of the aforesaid directions to the chairperson, NDMC, and Commissioner of Police, Delhi, is kept in abeyance till the next date of listing on July 22, 2026," the bench said.

In a hearing held on Wednesday, the bench had initially directed that all activities within a 100-metre radius of Lal Bangla I & II, near the entrance of the Delhi Golf Club, will be stopped.

The top court passed the order after noting an "alarming" situation that most of the monuments bear no semblance of any conservation work and are in dilapidated condition. With regard to nine

other monuments in the club, the apex court said there shall be no activity permitted within 20 metres radius of those buildings. This direction was also kept in abeyance by the court.

"Coming to the role of the ASI in not taking appropriate steps as per the requirements of the Act, by ensuring that no activity happens around the monument which is protected and has to be taken care of, we issue notice to the Director, ASI, as to why appropriate orders be not passed against him for such callous and casual approach in the matter where despite a monument being under the custody of the ASI, there is absolutely no work undertaken or action taken by it," the bench said.

The top court then directed the ASI director to file a personally affirmed explanation on the next date of hearing. The issue of heritage sites arose in a case filed by Rajeev Suri, who raised the issue of encroachment of the Gumti of Shaikh Ali - a Lodhiera monument in Delhi's Defence Colony.

Earlier, the apex court was told about the dilapidated condition of 10 ancient structures situated within the precincts of the Delhi Golf Club. The directions were passed after examining a survey report submitted by court commissioners led by senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan.

Order Order

Missing *saroops* case: SGPC hands documents to SIT

The Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) on Thursday said it has handed over the copies of the documents sought from time to time by the Punjab Police's Special Investigation Team, which is probing the case of missing 328 *saroops* (sacred copies) of the Sri Guru Granth Sahib.

The SIT visited SGPC sub-office in Chandigarh on Thursday in connection with the ongoing probe.

The Punjab Police has alleged that SGPC had failed to extend effective cooperation to the investigating agency.

On Thursday, the SGPC said they are fully cooperating with the SIT in the matter.

SGPC chief Harjinder Singh Dhami said they have provided copies of the requested documents to the SIT at the committee's Chandigarh sub-office. (*PTI*)

Nasrapur girl murder trial set to begin

A special court here on Thursday framed charges against the 65-year-old accused in the alleged sexual assault and murder of a minor girl at Nasrapur in Pune district, marking the commencement of the trial that will be conducted daily.

Special Judge SR Salunkhe ordered the proceedings to be held "in-camera" (behind closed doors) starting Friday, observing that there is strong prima facie evidence and a chargesheet against the accused Bhimrao Kamble. The alleged crime had triggered massive protests. Special Public Prosecutor Ajay Misar informed the court that the accused is mentally sound and fit for trial. He also submitted a medical report to that effect alongside a list of 82 witnesses.

The court has fast-tracked the matter to ensure daily hearings in view of the gravity of the crime. (*PTI*)

WFI moves SC over Vinesh Row, cites judicial overreach

AMANPREET SINGH
New Delhi

The Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) has moved the Supreme Court, challenging the Delhi High Court order that allowed Olympian wrestler Vinesh Phogat to participate in the selection trials for the 2026 Asian Games, scheduled to be held on Saturday.

In its Special Leave Petition (SLP), the WFI termed the Delhi High Court division bench order dated May 22 as "ex facie illegal" and argued that the federation was not given adequate opportunity to file a detailed reply before directions were issued in favour of Vinesh.

The federation said the High Court had directed inclusion of Vinesh in the trials for the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya despite her allegedly being "ineligible" under the published selection criteria.

The WFI further argued that selection of athletes for international multi-sport events falls exclusively within the domain of the recognised National Sports Federation and warned against "judicial overreach" into sporting selection

matters. Giving background to the dispute, the federation stated that Vinesh had voluntarily retired from wrestling in December 2024 through communications sent to the International Testing Agency (ITA). According to the plea, under United World Wrestling (UWW) anti-doping rules read with the WADA Code, an athlete returning from retirement must undergo a mandatory six-month whereabouts and dope-testing period before becoming eligible to compete. The WFI also referred to a "recorded missed test" allegedly registered against Vinesh on May 4 in connection with an unsuccessful testing attempt on December 18, 2025, following which a show-cause notice was issued to her on May 9. The federation contended that the disciplinary process against the wrestler was still pending and should be allowed to reach its "logical conclusion".

The plea also said the selection policy, published in February 2026, had no provision for an "iconic player" or maternity-based exemption and maintained that selections had always been merit-and-performance based.

The WFI further submitted that 12 wrestlers in each category had already qualified for the trials on the basis of medals won at the Senior National Championships, Senior Federation Cup and Under-20 National Championships, and claimed those wrestlers were not heard before the High Court passed its order.

The federation additionally argued that the deadline for accreditation for the Asian Games had expired on May 14, prior to the High Court order, making implementation of the directions difficult. V

inesh had approached the Delhi High Court seeking permission to compete in the trials after she was denied an opportunity to compete in National Open Ranking event which was supposed to be her first even on come back. WFI had issued a showcause notice for violation of rules.

Vinesh moved court but did not get relief and only after she appealed that verdict, the Delhi High Court asked WFI to allow the celebrated wrestler to compete in trials in Delhi on May 30. (*PTI*)

DD news protest: Court denies bail to accused

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

A Delhi court has dismissed the anticipatory bail plea of a man in a case regarding a protest outside Doordarshan Bhawan last month, saying the custodial interrogation of the accused was needed to unearth the "entire conspiracy". On April 14, a protest was held outside the *DD News* office against anchor Ashok Shrivastav for allegedly using derogatory language against Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, following which a case was registered at Tilak Marg police station.

In an order dated May 26, Additional Sessions Judge Shefali Barnala Tandon said there are prima facie serious allegations against the applicant or accused Ranvir Singhania, noting that the investigating officer (IO) opposed the relief.

The IO argued that the accused's custodial interrogation is required for identification of other accused persons. "It is stated by IO that as per the CCTV footage collected by them, the applicant/accused is clearly seen bringing the protestors to

Doordarshan Bhawan in multiple vehicles bearing Rajasthan registration numbers, and he is also seen protesting, shouting slogans and burning effigy," Judge Tandon said.

The judge further said that according to the IO, after the accused joined the investigation under the protection of the court, CCTV footage had been shown to him and he identified himself and other 17-18 persons there, and his vehicle used for bringing the protestors to the spot was recovered and seized.

The court, however, clarified that its observations would not have any bearing on the merits of the case during trial.

Bhojshala dispute: Another plea in SC against MP HC order

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

A fresh plea has been filed before the Supreme Court challenging a Madhya Pradesh High Court order, which said that the disputed Bhojshala complex in Dhar district was a temple dedicated to Goddess Saraswati.

The high court had also said that the Centre and the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) can decide on the Bhojshala complex's administration and management.

The Hindu community considers Bhojshala a temple dedicated to Goddess Saraswati, while the Muslim

side calls the 11th-century monument the Kamal Maula Mosque. The disputed complex in Dhar district of Madhya Pradesh is protected by the ASI. One Jebran Ansari has challenged the high court's May 15 order. Earlier, the mosque's caretaker, Qazi Moinuddin challenged the order of the high court.

The Hindu side has already filed a caveat in the top court, saying no orders be passed without hearing it on any appeal against the high court order in the Bhojshala complex dispute case.

"Let no order be made in the above matter without notice to the undersigned," said the caveat, filed by Jitendra Singh 'Vishen' through advocate Barun Kumar Sinha.

Vishen was the sixth petitioner in the matter in which a high court bench in Indore gave the decision.

The high court has also quashed an April 7, 2003, order of the ASI that allowed Muslims to offer namaz inside the Bhojshala complex every Friday. The high court also said that the Muslim community may approach the Madhya Pradesh Government for allotment of separate land in the district for the construction of a mosque. In its much-awaited verdict, the high court observed that there were indications of a Sanskrit teaching centre and a temple of Goddess Saraswati existing in the Bhojshala complex.

The high court delivered the verdict on five petitions and one writ appeal related to the matter.

"The religious character of the disputed Bhojshala-Kamal Maula mosque is established as a temple of Goddess Saraswati," the high court had said.

None can deny there is corruption in judiciary, says Madras HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Chennai

Observing that none can deny there is corruption in the judiciary, the Madras high court has said that there were and are corrupt judges.

A vacation bench comprising Justices GR Swaminathan and V Lakshminarayan made the observation while dismissing a Public Interest Litigation plea on May 21 from an advocate RS Tamilvendan, which sought a direction to the authorities to ban the continued screen-

ing of the Tamil film "Karuppu", starring popular film star S Surya and Trisha.

The bench said while addressing a legal conference in Kollam (Kerala), former Chief Justice of India Bharucha implied that 20 per cent of the judges in the country were corrupt.

Six accused gets bail in Delhi Govt scheme scam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

A Delhi court has granted bail to six accused persons in an alleged scam linked to a Delhi Government scheme, saying it is an admitted proposition of law that bail is the rule and denial is an exception.

The case was registered in 2025 by the Anti-Corruption Branch (ACB) based on a complaint by the Department for the Welfare of SCs, STs and OBCs, which alleged large-scale irregularities by empanelled coaching institutes in claiming funds from the exchequer under the 'Jai Bhim Mukhyamantri Pratibha Vikas Yojana' in 2018-19.

Earlier this month, the ACB arrested nine owners, directors and associates of coaching institutes in connection with the alleged Rs 37.20-crore scam. Special Judge Ruchi Aggarwal Asrani was hearing separate bail pleas filed by Ravindra Singh Jadon, Harshit, Azad Kalet, Sanjeev Kumar, Narendra Kumar Gupta and Jeetender Kumar. According to the prosecution, Jadon was the director of M/s Ravindra Institute of Indian

Civil Services (OPC) Pvt Ltd, Harshit was running Momentum NEET IIT Academy, Kalet was running Takshila Institute, Kumar was running Prayas Institute, Gupta was director of Takshila Academy Pvt Ltd and Jeetender was running an NGO namely Pahal in Rohini, which was associated illegally with one Kiran Institute.

The prosecution alleged that the accused persons received undue benefits.

In separate orders passed on May 26, Judge Asrani said that the accused persons had been incarcerated for 26 days and "it is an admitted proposition of law that the bail is a rule and denial is an exception".

She said that as they were not personally required in the investigation, therefore, continued incarceration will not serve any purpose.

SC seeks responses of Centre, ED, RBI on plea alleging siphoning of homebuyers' funds

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Supreme Court has sought responses from the Centre, ED, RBI and others, including a few real estate firms, on a plea alleging that thousands of crores collected from homebuyers in Noida and Yamuna Expressway projects were siphoned off.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi on Wednesday took note of the submissions of lawyer Prashant Bhushan, appearing for petitioner Vandana Sabharwal, and issued notices to respondents for July 15.

Besides Union ministries of housing and urban affairs and corporate affairs, ED and the RBI, the bench also sought responses of the Uttar Pradesh RERA (Real Estate Regulation and Development Authority), Noida Authority, Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA), Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL), Jaiprakash Infratech Ltd (JIL), Standard Chartered Bank, and developers including CRC Homes, CRC Greens, Gaursons, Gulshan Homz,

Mahagun and Investors Clinic.

Sabharwal, in her plea, said that the case reflected a larger systemic pattern in the real estate sector where developers allegedly divert homebuyers' funds, transfer land and development rights to related entities, and eventually push projects into insolvency, leaving buyers stranded. Bhushan referred to findings of the ED, which is investigating the matter under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). He told the bench that the ED had found that out of nearly Rs 14,559 crore collected by JAL and JIL from over 25,000 homebuyers, "substantial amounts" were diverted for non-construction purposes and siphoned off to related group entities, including Jaypee group companies.

"This issue keeps recurring project after project," Bhushan said. "Funds are collected from homebuyers, diverted elsewhere, and the companies eventually go into bankruptcy. Homeowners are left in a serious situation because the diverted funds are either never identified, or not identified and brought back in time," he said.

Right to trauma care of citizens integral part of right to life: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Observing that right to trauma care of citizens is an integral part of right to life, the Supreme Court has asked all states and Union territories to operationalise within three months one helpline number '112' for emergency responses and establish functional good samaritan grievance redressal system.

A bench of Justices JK Maheshwari and AS Chandurkar also directed the states to furnish periodic

compliance reports by organising monthly meetings and uploading the minutes on the concerned portals.

The bench passed the order on Tuesday on a plea filed by Savelife Foundation which raised the need for trauma care to be recognised as a matter of right in the Indian public law system.

The top court said when a person suffers an accident or any such similar incident which requires urgent trauma care, they usually feel shock and disorientation, a sense of helplessness where they have to hope that those around them would somehow help them get the care that they need.

"In such a situation, every minute spent without medical intervention or urgent care significantly narrows the scope for survival. Swiftness, is quite literally, like medicine," it said.

Referring to different stages of care after such an incident, the bench said a robust mechanism for trauma care must take a "bottom-up approach" which accounts for various stakeholders. It said usually, no matter how strong the urge to be a good samaritan is, the bystander hesitates, suffers a reactive paralysis, sometimes due to fear of legal proceedings, of getting summoned to police station as a witness and sometimes due to the psychological weight of the situation itself.

"To address these barriers, what is required is a systemic intervention, creation of a uniform framework for trauma care, building public awareness, standardization of first aid skills and proper good samaritan laws; since right to trauma care of citizens is an integral part of right to life enshrined under Article 21 of the Constitution of India," the bench said.

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India, Canada to avoid sensitive sectors in trade talks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

India and Canada have decided to focus on low-hanging fruit, work on areas of convergence and avoid seeking concessions in sensitive sectors in the negotiations for the proposed free trade agreement, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal has said.

The two countries are negotiating a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA). The third round of negotiations is underway in Ottawa. The minister was in Canada for a three-day official visit.

"I remember when I was talking to Maninder Sidhu (Canada's trade minister) about speeding up CEPA negotiations, one of the first elementary decisions we both took was that 'we won't make perfect the enemy of the good'.

"Let's capture the low-hanging fruit. Let's look at areas of convergence. Let's leave the sensitive things out of the agreement. If something is sensitive for Canada, no sense in trying to egg on and trying to get that into the CEPA. Likewise, if something is sensitive for India or the Indian public or Indian businesses, no sense in breaking our heads trying to navigate that path," he said while addressing the Ontario Centre of Innovation on May 27.

Under such pacts, India does not grant market access in areas such as agri-commodities and dairy.

Both sides are looking to conclude the negotiations for the proposed pact by year-end. The two countries have also set a target to increase bilateral trade from the current $17 billion to $50 billion by 2030.

In such pacts, two trading partners significantly reduce and eliminate import duties on the maximum number of goods traded between them. Besides, they also ease norms to promote trade in services and boost investments.

Goyal also said that during his visit, he met government representatives, businesses, investment companies, pension funds, and insurance companies.

Seeking investment from Canadian firms, he said India is known for protecting intellectual property.

India, he said, has the third-largest startup ecosystem, with about 2.3 lakh entities registered as startups. "The digital public infrastructure is another area where India has demonstrated tremendous capabilities to the world, as well as offered itself and these technologies for wider public good across the world," Goyal said, adding that vast potential for bilateral cooperation is there in sectors such as AI, cleantech, agritech, and deep tech.

During his meeting with Jo Taylor, President and CEO of Ontario Teachers' Pension Plan, he discussed investment opportunities in India across infrastructure, renewables, financial services, healthcare, technology, and the digital economy.

First Reliance solar modules roll out from Gujarat

Reliance Industries delivered the first 200 megawatt-peak (MWp) batch of premium, high-efficiency solar modules from its green energy manufacturing complex in Jamnagar in Gujarat, marking the operational rollout of its New Energy business during FY 2025-26.

The Dhirubhai Ambani Green Energy Giga Complex, spread across 5,000 acres in Jamnagar, Gujarat, is being developed as an integrated clean energy manufacturing ecosystem covering solar modules, batteries, green hydrogen and bio-energy infrastructure.

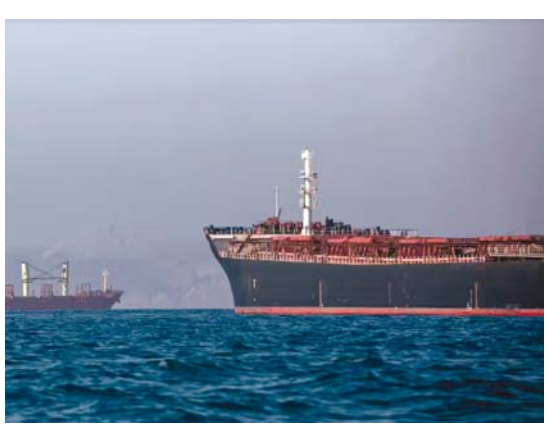
In its latest annual report, Reliance said the first batch of 720-watt-peak BIS-certified high-efficiency heterojunction technology (HJT) solar panels demonstrated about 10 per cent higher energy yield and 25 per cent lower degradation compared with prevailing industry benchmarks.

The company is progressively commissioning cell and module manufacturing lines and remains on track to scale solar manufacturing capacity to 10 gigawatt-peak (GWp) annually, with plans to expand to 20 GWp.

Manufacturing integration for polysilicon, glass, ingots and wafers is being rolled out in phases.

Reliance also said its battery energy storage system (BESS) giga-factory has entered advanced commissioning, with an initial operational target of 40 gigawatt-hours (GWh) of annual capacity and a longer-term roadmap of 100 GWh. (*PTI*)

New trade routes can ease Hormuz dependence: EY



India needs to diversify its trade routes and accelerate development of alternative connectivity corridors, including the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) and the Indo-Pacific route via the Malacca Strait, to reduce its reliance on the Strait of Hormuz, an EY report said. The EY Economy Watch report for May said that in view of the mounting pressures emanating from the West Asia crisis and the changing world trade and economic order, India might look at recasting its growth strategy to ensure that no long-term damage is done to its medium to long-term path. Earlier this month, Prime Minister Narendra Modi called for austerity measures, including a reduction in gold imports, a cutback in foreign travel, and a reduction in domestic fuel consumption.

The EY report said that going forward, India needs to prepare for unanticipated economic shocks and vulnerabilities. The Government may look at building strategic reserves for crude oil, LPG, fertilisers, processed and unprocessed rare earth materials and basic medicines and critical medical equipment; building dual-use infrastructure to minimise the impacts of unanticipated nuclear and biological threats; and re-strategising the achievement of sustainable levels of current account and fiscal imbalances. (*PTI*)

LIC looks to improve return from real estates

KUMAR DIPANKAR ■ New Delhi

LIC is looking to improve returns from real estate properties, and the insurer would also explore the option of a separate subsidiary to achieve greater efficiency in managing its vast assets, which are conservatively estimated at over ₹60,000 crore.

"We have substantial real estate, both inherited and purchased over the period of 70 years that we have been operating. It is used both for our own use and as an investment which earns returns for us.

"We look at each piece of real estate as an investment. As part of the asset, we expect each property to contribute towards the returns for the policyholders as well as shareholders," LIC CEO and MD R Doraiswamy told PTI in an interview.

In the recent past, he said LIC has initiated a comprehensive review of its real estate portfolio to assess the returns and yields it generates, and to identify opportunities for further optimisation and improvement.

This detailed analysis is aimed at enhancing returns for policyholders while also strengthening the organisation's overall profitability, he said.

Asked if there is any target for FY27, Doraiswamy said, no such targets as such...we need to improve from whatever it is currently. That is what we are looking at.

"Properties that are self-occupied also play an important role in enhancing the organisation's image. Therefore, improving the ambience and overall environment of our branches and owned buildings has become a key focus area," he said.

At the same time, he said, LIC is also evaluating leased properties to ensure they generate appropriate revenue returns.

"All options are open before us...all options will be examined, and we will take it forward in the days to come," he said when asked if LIC would consider setting up a separate subsidiary for managing its real estate portfolio more efficiently. (*PTI*)

Centre urges States to adopt coal gasification incentives

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Government on Thursday said Odisha and Maharashtra have introduced their State-level incentive schemes to boost coal gasification projects, and the Centre is persuading other States like Chhattisgarh, Uttar Pradesh, Jharkhand, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, and Assam to also follow suit.

The development assumes significance against the backdrop of geopolitical headwinds and West Asia crisis-triggered fuel market volatility.

Speaking during the roadshow on the scheme for promotion of surface coal/lignite gasification projects, Coal Secretary Vikram Dev Dutt said, "We have engaged effectively with States. Some of them have been more than proactive in realising that coal gasification is the future, and at the State level they need to design a shelf of incentives which would actually attract and encourage industry to actually set up large-scale coal gasification projects."

Odisha and Maharashtra Governments have moved very proactively and have schemes in place, Dutt said.

The secretary further explained the implications of these incentive schemes and said that while capital expenditure support for plant and machinery will be provided under the new Central Government scheme, state-level incentive packages will go a long way in reducing the operating expenditure of these projects.

"The engagement with state governments is very proactive from our side. We believe that Chhattisgarh is already on the drawing board and at an advanced stage of an incentive scheme for Chhattisgarh. In Madhya Pradesh, we have taken up, and the minister has been speaking to both these States and Andhra Pradesh as well."

Coal and Mines Minister G Kishan Reddy said the Centre is in regular discussions with States like Chhattisgarh, Uttar Pradesh, Jharkhand, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Assam, to bring in State-level schemes for promoting coal gasification.

India, Korea agree to address widening trade deficit

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

India and South Korea have agreed to address the widening trade deficit between the two countries within the overall framework of the bilateral trade pact, the Commerce Ministry said on Thursday.

The two nations also decided to constitute subgroups to discuss cooperation in the areas of digital trade, supply chain and strategic industrial collaboration. The issue figured during the 12th round meeting on the up-gradation of the existing Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), which was implemented in January 2010.

"Both sides acknowledged India's bilateral trade deficit, which has risen significantly since the IK CEPA came into force in 2010, and agreed to address the issue within the overall IK (India-Korea) CEPA framework," the ministry said.

India's exports to Korea increased 3.31 per cent to $6 billion in 2025-26 from $5.81 billion in 2024-25. The export growth was negative during 2022-25.

Imports grew 1.38 per cent to $21.35 billion in 2025-26 from $21 billion in 2024-25.

The trade deficit widened to $15.35 billion in 2025-26, from $15.2 billion in 2024-25. The deficit stood at $14.71 billion in 2023-24, up from $14.57 billion in 2022-23 and $9.4 billion in 2021-22.

The ministry said that both sides reviewed the progress achieved so far in the negotiations.

During the current round, discussions were held on trade in goods, trade in services, rules of origin and origin procedures, investment, and sanitary and phytosanitary (SPS) standards.

The negotiations were co-chaired by Kapil Chaudhary, Joint Secretary, Department of Commerce, and Park Geun-oh, Director General for Trade Agreement Policy, Ministry of Trade, Industry and Energy, Republic of Korea.

Govt readies contingency plans for Kharif season: Chouhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Centre is fully prepared to mitigate any adverse impact of the El Nino weather phenomenon on this year's Kharif crop, Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said on Thursday, as he called for integrated farming and greater self-reliance in pulses and oilseeds.

"Rather than worrying, preparation is required. Contingency plans will be made for affected districts and crop changes will be considered wherever necessary," Chouhan told reporters on the sidelines of the two-day National Kharif Conference.

The Ministry is in the process of identifying districts for alternative crops and ensuring seed availability in the event of an El Nino impact, he said.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) had, in its first-stage forecast on April 13, projected a below-normal southwest monsoon for 2026, with rainfall likely to be around 92 per cent of the long-period average.

The World Meteorological Organisation (WMO) has indicated a probable return of El Nino conditions as early as May-July, while the US-based National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), in its May 11 ENSO update, said El Nino conditions are likely to emerge during May-June and persist through year-end.

El Nino, characterised by unusual warming of surface waters in the eastern tropical Pacific Ocean, is typically associated with drier and hotter conditions in India.

Kharif (summer) sowing has just begun in some parts of India, but it is still in the very early stages. Farmers have started preparing fields for early sowing (especially of short-duration crops such as pulses, coarse cereals, and some cotton) in regions that have received pre-monsoon rains.

Normal Kharif sowing starts in June and peaks in June-July with the arrival and progress of the southwest monsoon.

Notwithstanding weather challenges, India is on track to achieve a record food-grain production of 376.56 million tonnes in the 2025-26 crop year (July-June), an increase of 18.8 million tonnes over the previous year, Chouhan said.

ICAR Director General ML Jat noted that rice output targets set for 2047 had already been met, underscoring the case for crop diversification.

"We don't need 50 million hectares under rice. We need 35 million hectares by 2047. If we have to offload 15 million hectares, redirecting that to oilseeds and pulses could make us self-reliant in those crops," he said.

Jat also flagged that over 100 districts are using fertilisers beyond scientifically recommended levels, calling for a multi-pronged strategy that includes nutrient-efficient crop breeding, greater use of organic and biological inputs, and improved soil health management.

Seed quality and data ecosystem were flagged as priority areas. Delivering quality seeds to farmers alone could raise productivity by 15-20 per cent, Jat said, urging all stakeholders — including state farms, agricultural universities, and ICAR institutions — to prioritise seed production.

He also called for building a robust agricultural data ecosystem to support AI-driven interventions such as the Bharat Vistar platform.

In FY26, 97% of violative ads were on digital platforms, majority of them on Meta: ASCI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

The new-age digital media is home to over 97 per cent of violative ads in FY26, and online giant Meta alone contributed nearly four-fifths of such problematic campaigns, ASCI said on Thursday.

There were a total of 9,611 ads, which were found to be in violation, of which 97.36 per cent were carried on digital platforms and 2.04 per cent on TV and 0.26 per cent on print media, according to the Advertising Standards Council of India (ASCI).

Among the ads found to be violative on the digital platforms, 79.84 per cent were carried on Meta, which runs popular platforms like Facebook and Instagram, while Google, which runs YouTube, had just 3.59 per cent of the violative ads, the self-regulatory body said.

Websites had a share of over 13 per cent in digital ads found to be in violation of Asci's codes, as per its annual report.

The 2025-26 financial year witnessed a 21 per cent jump in the number of ads reviewed by Asci to 11,581, with campaigns from offshore betting and realty sectors being the most violative, the sector's self regulatory body said on Thursday.

Despite regulatory interventions, offshore betting was the most violative sector with a bulk 6,933 cases, and was followed by realty at 643 and personal care at 576 cases, it said.

The SRO said 93 per cent of the ads reviewed came from its own monitoring and added that 98 per cent had to be modified.

A bulk 75 per cent of the overall ads promoted harmful products and 27 per cent lacked honest representation to mislead consumers, it said.

"We are seeing a growing tendency toward exaggerated claims, manufactured scientific credibility, influencer-led amplification and the normalisation of non-compliance as a post-publication correction exercise," the body's chairman Sudhanshu Vats said.

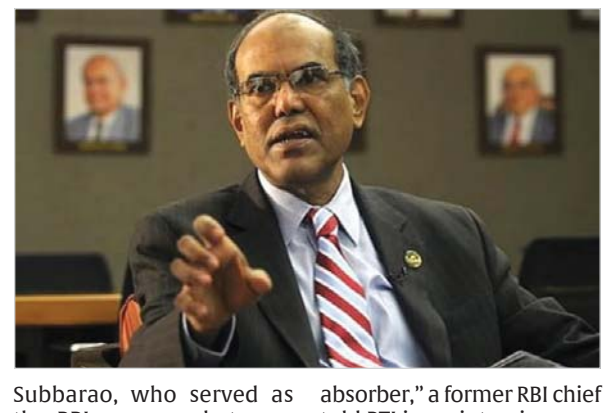
RBI must let rupee depreciate: Subbarao

MANISH M SUVARNA ■ Mumbai

Former RBI Governor Duvvuri Subbarao has said the central bank must allow some more depreciation in the rupee to help absorb external pressures, and choose liquidity measures, rather than going for rate hikes, if inflation risks intensify.

In comments that come days ahead of the second meeting of the rate-setting panel for FY27, Subbarao said the monetary policy should be used as a "last resort" to defend the exchange rate.

"RBI may, of course, tighten monetary policy if it believes that to be justified by inflation concerns,"



Subbarao, who served as the RBI governor between 2008 and 2013, said.

"The rupee should be allowed to adjust rather than be rigidly defended because the current pressures reflect a deterioration in India's external balance. A weaker rupee acts as a natural shock absorber," a former RBI chief told PTI in an interview.

The local currency has been depreciating due to geopolitical uncertainty and the West Asia crisis, and touched a lifetime low of 97.15 against the US dollar earlier this month.

According to data compiled from market sources, the rupee has depreciated 5 per cent since the start of the West Asia crisis, around 6.1 per cent since the beginning of the year, and over 10 per cent in one year.

Subbarao said stabilising the exchange rate during times of pressure is fundamentally a challenge of managing expectations.

"Exchange-rate crises are ultimately crises of confidence. If investors, importers and households begin to believe the rupee will weaken further, they behave in ways that actually make it weaken further. Exporters delay bringing money back home, importers rush to buy dollars, households move into gold, and investors hedge aggressively," he said. (*PTI*)

FROM THE WORLD

SRI LANKA

'Debt risks remain high'

The International Monetary Fund (IMF) on Thursday said Sri Lanka's debt sustainability risks remain high, although its debt trajectory continues to improve amid ongoing economic reforms under the programme supported by the global lender. The remarks came after the IMF completed the combined fifth and sixth reviews of the island nation's economic reform programme supported by the 48-month Extended Fund Facility (EFF) arrangement, leading to the release of about $695 million. With the latest disbursement, total IMF purchases under the arrangement have risen to around $2.4 billion, the Fund said. "Debt sustainability risks remain high and we have described it as such in our assessment... Debt in general still remains quite high," IMF Sri Lanka mission chief Ivan Papageorgiou told reporters here.

NEPAL

India to build 14 schools

India has pledged Nepali Rupees 560.2 million for the construction of 14 schools in eight earthquake-affected districts of Nepal, reaffirming its commitment to the Himalayan nation's post-disaster reconstruction and socio-economic development. The Central Level Project Implementation Unit-Education under Nepal's Ministry of Education and Sports has signed agreements for the construction of 14 schools across eight districts of Nepal under a Government of India grant of Nepali Rupees 560.2 million, the Indian Embassy in Kathmandu said in a press statement on Wednesday. The schools will be built in Gorkha, Nuwakot, Dhading, Dolakha, Kathmandu, Kavrepalanchowk, Ramechhap and Sindhupalchok districts – regions which bore the maximum brunt of earthquakes in country. over the last several years.

The country witnessed its worst earthquake in 2015, which killed nearly 9,000 people.

Fire at girls school in Kenya, 16 killed

EVELYNE MUSAMBI ■ Gilgil (Kenya)

A fire ripped through a dormitory in a girls' boarding school in central Kenya on Thursday, killing at least 16 students, a government official said, in the latest such incident to afflict the East African nation.

Education Minister Julius Ogamba said Thursday that 79 others were injured at the Utumishi Girls School, which has more than 800 students in the Gilgil area of central Kenya. The cause has not yet been established. Ogamba said authorities would investigate whether the school's fire safety manual had been adhered to. Police said they were leading the rescue and emergency response efforts at the school, which is located about 120 kilometres from the capital, Nairobi. The Government-owned secondary school is managed and sponsored by the Kenya Police Service. Many of the students are daughters of police officers. The victims have not yet been identified.

One person at the scene, Wambui Nderitu, arrived to check on her cousin, who is a student at the school. She said she heard that the matron opened one of two dormitory doors "without alerting the children to exit."

"The second door remained closed, and even though my cousin escaped with a leg injury, we've been told many children are injured and some died," Nderitu said.

The Kenya Red Cross said several students were evacuated and are receiving treatment in various hospitals. The group said it deployed "tracing and psychosocial support teams to support affected students and families." Kenya's deadliest school fire in recent history occurred in 2001 when 67 students died in a dormitory fire in Machakos County. In 2024, 21 students burned to death in a school fire in central Kenya. President William Ruto declared three days of mourning. In 2017, 10 students died in a school fire in Nairobi. A student was charged with murder. (*AP*)

Netanyahu aide to be charged for leaking secret information

NATALIE MELZER ■ Nahariya (Israel)

Israel's attorney general on Thursday said a close adviser to Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu will face criminal prosecution for leaking secret information to a German newspaper with the intent of harming the country's security.

The announcement marked another scandal for the embattled Netanyahu as the country gears up for elections this fall. Netanyahu himself is on trial for corruption in three separate cases and faces tensions within his coalition that threaten to dissolve parliament.

The attorney general's office said it plans to indict Jonatan Urich in the leak of a classified document in 2024 to a German tabloid that critics said was aimed to help absolve Netanyahu of blame for failed negotiations with Hamas during the war in Gaza. It said Urich would also be charged with possession of confidential information and destruction of evidence.

Netanyahu's office refused to comment on the planned indictment. But Urich's lawyers told Israel's Army Radio channel that the decision was "wrong and disconnected from the evidence."

Urich reacted with a sarcastic one-line post on social media, saying "It's quite something that the AG didn't ask for a death sentence."

Netanyahu and members of his inner circle have claimed they are the victims of a politically motivated witch hunt by overzealous prosecutors and the media.

The attorney general's office did not say when the indictment would be officially handed down. It is a standard practice to announce the intent to indict ahead of time. Another former aide to Netanyahu, Eli Feldstein, has already been indicted on charges related to the same affair. Both Urich and Feldstein were arrested last year in a separate case known in Israel as "Qatargate," on suspicion that they accepted money from Qatar to promote a positive image of the Gulf Arab state in Israel after the October 7, 2023 Hamas attack.

They are suspected of accepting money from a foreign Government while working for the prime minister's office. Netanyahu's office has played down the leaks and Qatargate affair and has frequently accused the judiciary of bias. (*AP*)

India, Singapore hold talks on defence cooperation

GURDIP SINGH ■ Singapore

India and Singapore on Thursday held wide-ranging discussions on key areas of defence cooperation, security collaboration and avenues to further strengthen the strategic relationship between the two countries.

Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh co-chaired with Singapore's Permanent Secretary (Defence) Joseph Leong the 16th Defence Policy Dialogue which reaffirmed the robust bilateral defence partnership between the two nations. "Wide-ranging discussions were held on key areas of defence cooperation, security collaboration and avenues to further strengthen the strategic relationship between the two countries," said a post on X by the spokesperson of the Ministry of Defence.

Singh visited the Digital Operations Technology Centre (DOTC) of the Digital and Intelligence Service of the Singapore Armed Forces, the ministry said.

The visit provided valuable insights into Singapore's advanced digital and technical capabilities, while exploring avenues for collaboration with the Indian Armed Forces in niche and emerging domains of warfare, the post on X added.

During the meeting, the high-ranking officers reaffirmed the "strong and long-standing" defence relationship between Singapore and India. They also discussed ways to strengthen bilateral defence cooperation between the SAF and Indian Armed Forces (IAF), as well as exchanged views on global and regional security developments. The visit provided valuable insights into Singapore's advanced digital and technical capabilities, while exploring avenues for collaboration with the Indian Armed Forces in niche and emerging domains of warfare, the post said.

On Saturday, Singh will address the annual three-day Shangri La Dialogue, said the London-based organisers International Institute of Strategic Studies (IISS). (*PTI*)

Aid supplies reach Congo as WHO head travels to Kinshasa

JUSTIN KABUMBA/ OPE ADETAYO ■ Bunai (Congo)

Aid supplies were rushed in to the centre of Congo's outbreak of a rare type of Ebola virus as beleaguered medical workers have struggled with a lack of equipment, a distrustful population and armed groups in a volatile region.

A white cargo plane on Thursday morning delivered masks, gloves, boots, and medications — all of which are in short supply — donated by the European Union to Bunia, a northeastern town at the heart of the outbreak. UN-branded forklifts lifted several cases into trucks.

In Bunia, Associated Press reporters saw empty emergency treatment centres, and doctors in the nearby town of Bambu using expired medical masks while tending to suspected Ebola patients.

At least three attacks have been recorded against health centers in Ituri province as residents protested stringent medical protocols that clashed with local burial rites, heightening the danger health workers face.

The aid delivery from the EU is expected to come in batches over the next eight days, Jerome Kouachi, head of emergency operations at UNICEF in Congo, told the AP.

The director-general of the World Health Organisation, Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, said on Thursday that he was on his way to Congo to see first-hand efforts to contain the Bundibugyo virus, which has no approved treatment or vaccine. The WHO has declared the outbreak a public health emergency of international concern, in the hope of ramping up aid.

The Congolese Government has confirmed more than 1,000 suspected cases, with at least 220 deaths, since it declared an outbreak on May 15. But the virus had been spreading undetected for weeks, and the WHO suspects it is much larger than what has been reported. The virus has also reached neighbouring Uganda, which has confirmed seven cases and one death. On Wednesday, the Congolese Government said the first survivor to recover from the virus had left a health centre. "We are trying to catch up," Congo Foreign Minister Therese Kayikwamba Wagner said earlier this week. "It is a race against the clock."

The response on the ground has been hampered by multiple challenges, including customs' red tape, insufficient storage facilities, bad roads and weak telecommunications, humanitarian agencies said in a report on Thursday. Tedros on Wednesday called for a ceasefire in a region where armed groups have staged violent attacks for decades. "We cannot build community trust or isolate the sick while bombs are falling," he said.

Tucked in the northeastern part of Congo close to the Ugandan border, Ituri province has been reeling from attacks by the Allied Democratic Force, a rebel group allied with the Islamic State group, and a coalition of ethnic militias. In early May, the ADF killed at least 40 people and burned several homes in Ituri.

The illness has also been reported in two Congolese provinces south of Ituri — North Kivu and South Kivu, where the Rwanda-backed M23 rebel group controls many key cities, including Goma and Bukavu.

The rebels have reported two cases. The region's main airport in Goma, which doubles as a staging ground for humanitarian efforts into the region, has been closed since January 2025, when M23 seized the city. The conflict has precipitated one of the world's largest humanitarian crises, with at least 7 million people displaced in eastern Congo. (*AP*)

ORIENTAL NAGPUR BETUL HIGHWAY LIMITED

Regd. Off. : Unit No 307A, 3rd floor, Worldmark 2 Asset Area No 8, Hospitality Dist. Delhi Aerocity New Delhi - 110037
E-mail: onbhlinvestors.relations@orientalinfratrust.com; CIN: U45400DL2010PLC203649

FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED MARCH 31, 2026

(₹ in Millions)

Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)	Quarter Ended 31.03.2025 (Audited)	Year Ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)
1	Total income from operations (net)	1,123.27	1,015.19	4,035.24
2	Net Profit/(Loss) for the period (before Tax and Exceptional items)	411.00	484.45	1,737.86
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional items)	411.00	484.45	1,737.86
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional items)	-1,654.43	441.63	-731.47
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	-1,654.33	441.62	-731.39
6	Paid up Equity Share Capital	181.35	181.35	181.35
7	Reserves (excluding (excluding Debenture Redemption Reserve)	8,366.80	9,102.83	8,366.80
8	Securities Premium	3,443.66	3,443.66	3,443.66
9	Net Worth	9,522.69	10,540.81	9,522.69
10	Paid up Debt Capital/Outstanding Debt	13,823.19	16,625.12	13,823.19
11	Outstanding Redeemable Preference Shares	-	-	-
12	Debt Equity Ratio	1.45:1	1.58:1	1.45:1
13	Earnings Per Share (of Rs 10/- each)			
	1. Basic:	-91.23	24.35	-40.33
	2. Diluted:	-91.23	24.35	-40.33
14	Capital Redemption Reserve	-	-	-
15	Debenture Redemption Reserve	974.54	1,256.64	974.54
16	Debt Service Coverage Ratio	.88:1	1.46:1	0.92:1
17	Interest Service Coverage Ratio	2.04:1	2.13:1	2.07:1

Notes:

a) The above is an extract of the detailed format of audited financial results filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulations 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the audited financial results are available on the websites of the National Stock Exchange (NSE) and the listed entity (http://www.nagpurbetulhighway.in).

b) For the other line items referred to in Regulation 52(4) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, pertinent disclosures have been made to the Stock Exchange and are available on the websites of the National Stock Exchange (NSE) and the listed entity (http://www.nagpurbetulhighway.in).

c) These audited financial results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors of the Company at their meeting held on May 28, 2026.

d) The audited financial results of the Company have been prepared in accordance with Indian Accounting standard prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act, 2013.

For and on behalf of Board of Directors of
Oriental Nagpur Betul Highway Limited
Sd/-
Rajesh Yadav
Director
DIN: 08397240

Place: New Delhi
Date: May 28, 2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of **SHRI SHIVAM VERMA** to inform to the public at large that **SHRI SHIVAM VERMA** is purchasing the **PROPERTY NO. 71, AREA MEASURING 50 SQ. YDS. OUT OF KHASRA NO. 328, SITUATED IN THE AREA OF VILLAGE BINDAPUR, DELHI STATE, ABADI KNOWN AS VISHWAS PARK, IN BLOCK-B, UTTAM NAGAR, NEW DELHI-110059.** from **SMT. RENU SHARMA** who became owner through **GPA, ATS AND WILL dated 22/09/2004, duly attested with the Notary Public Delhi** which was executed by **SHRI NAVEEN SHARMA same to be financed & mortgaged by Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd.,** So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within **15 days** from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. **Lucem Legal LLP**
N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre,New Delhi-110049
Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

Public Notice

This is to inform general public that Mrs. Bala Devi has acquired Plot of Land area measuring 240 sq. yds., i.e., 200.66 sq. mtrs., out of Khasra No. 229, situated at Village Luksar Pargana Dankaur Tehsil & Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P-203201, vide by way of Sale Deed dated 04.04.2024 registered as Document No. 10076.
Document related to the above said property has been misplaced i.e. Sale Deed (Doc. No. 3938) dated 24.03.2007 and Sale Deed (Doc. No. 754) dated 15.01.2009 in respect of the said property.
If anyone who find the above said documents shall handover the same to the Manager of Truhome Finance Limited (earlier known as Shriram Housing Finance Ltd).
Now, Mrs. Bala Devi and Mr. Prem Chand are availing a loan on above said property from Truhome Finance Limited (earlier known as Shriram Housing Finance Ltd.) in case anyone has any objection, the same may be raised within 7 days of this publication to Mr. Ajit Sharma (Advocate), Partner of AccuLaw Source LLP, Unit No. S-2-U, 2nd Floor, built on Plot no. 4 and 5, Ansal Utility Commercial Center, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110063 or contact : +91 9560309909 (M).

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that Mr. Dinesh Joshi (hereinafter referred to as the said Mortgagor/ Borrower), is purchasing Flat No. B-102, admeasuring 2,350 Sq. Ft. Block B, HIG Type, 2nd Floor, SPS Residency, built on GH Plot No. 18-B, Vaibhav Khand, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad (hereinafter referred to as the said property) from Mrs. Jatinder Kaur Bakshi (through attorney Mr. Amrinder Singh Bakshi vide GPA dated 29.04.2026 bearing Doc. No. 271) & Mr. Amrinder Singh Bakshi who became the owners of the said property vide Sale Deed dated 31.03.2007 regd. as Doc. No. 7901, read with SMC dated 30.10.2021 & Gift Deed dated 29.04.2026, regd. as Doc. No. 5442. The Borrower will create mortgage in respect of the said property in favour of our clients Axis Bank Ltd., BF-1A BF-2, 1st Floor, Aditya City Centre, Plot No. 3, Vaibhav Khand 3, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad. Any person, body, individual, institution having any claim and/or objection in respect of the said property by way of sale, exchange, lease, lien, mortgage, charge, encumbrance, gift, trust, easement, maintenance, inheritance, testamentary deposition or otherwise or having in their custody any title documents pertaining to the said property shall communicate the same to the undersigned at our address within 07 days from the publication of this notice with documentary evidence in support thereof, failing which all the claim, of such person shall be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned. Any objections raised after the completion of the 07 days shall not be binding upon the said property or my client. **Adv. Simran Bajaj**
100, 1st Floor, Okhla Phase-III, New Delhi-110020
Phone: +91 1149774545/99

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client Mr. Gaya Prasad Pal S/o Sh. Parmeshwar Deen and Mrs. Shakuntala Devi W/o Sh. Gaya Prasad R/o D-52, Sector-3, Phase-3, Pappan Kalan, Dwarka, South West Delhi, Delhi-110073, have disowned/debarred their son Mr. Ajay who is R/o D-52, Sector-3, Phase-3, Pappan Kalan, Dwarka South West Delhi, Delhi-110075 from their movable, immovable properties due to disrespectful, out of control behavior. He served his relationship with him for all intents and purposes with immediate effect. Anybody deals with him will do so at his/her/their own risk and responsibility.

Sd/-
(VISHAL SRIVASTAVA
Advocate

US jobless claims rise to 2,15,000

PAUL WISEMAN ■ Washington

More Americans sought unemployment benefits last week, but layoffs remain low despite economic uncertainty caused by the Iran war.

The Labour Department reported Thursday that jobless claims were up to 2,15,000, up from 2,10,000 the week before. The four-week moving average of claims, which smooths out week-to-week volatility, rose by nearly 6,300 to 2,09,000.

The number of Americans signing up for unemployment benefits — a proxy for layoffs — has stabilised in a low range of mostly 2,00,000 to 2,50,000 a week since the US economy emerged from a brief but nasty pandemic recession in 2020.

The persistently low number of claims suggests that most US companies have not resorted to layoffs. But even if they're not cutting jobs, employers haven't been adding many either. Last year, companies, nonprofits and government agencies added fewer than 10,000 jobs a month, the weakest hiring outside recession years since 2002. Job creation has picked up a bit so far this year, to an average of 76,000 a month from January through April. By contrast, they added 122,000 a month in 2024 and averaged nearly 4,00,000 a month from 2021 through 2023 as the economy roared back from COVID-19 lockdowns.

But the United States now needs fewer jobs to keep the unemployment rate from rising. President Donald Trump's immigration crackdown and ongoing Baby Boomer retirements mean that the monthly "break-even rate? The number of monthly hires may be as low as zero. And the unemployment rate — 4.3 per cent in April — has, in fact, remained low by historic standards. (*AP*)

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE DIRECTORATE OF MEDICAL EDUCATION, ASSAM
SIXMILE, KHANAPARA, GUWAHATI-22

No. DME.E- **783768/2**

REQUEST FOR BIDS
INTERNATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING

Directorate of Medical Education, Khanapara Sixmile on behalf of O/O Project Director, Assam Health Infrastructure Development and Management Society (AHIDMS) invites "Request for Bid" from reputed suppliers for supply of the following advance medical equipments funded by Japan International Corporation Agency (JICA) for High End Ultrasound Machine for Gauhati Medical College & Hospital, Guwahati

1. Procurement of High End Ultrasound

The details may be seen in the Request for Bid document uploaded in the Assam E- procurement portal **(https://assamtenders.gov.in)** & **https://ahidms.assam.gov.in**
The applicant must be registered with the E-Tendering system (ETS) of the Govt, of Assam. (Website: https://assamtenders.gov.in). The Project Director, AHIDMS reserves the right to accept or reject all bids without showing any reasons whatsoever.

Sd /-
Directorate of Medical Education, Assam
DIPR/C/PIO/65/29-May-26

Former Yemen president Abdrabbuh Mansour Hadi dies at 80

AHMED AL-HAJ ■ Aden(Yemen)

Abdrabbuh Mansour Hadi, the internationally recognised president of Yemen who led a fractured Government mostly from exile for eight years as the country descended into civil war and famine before stepping down in 2022, died on Thursday at the age of 80.

State-run Yemeni TV said he died at his residence in Riyadh, the capital of Saudi Arabia, but gave no other details. Rashad al-Alimi, the head of the Presidential Leadership Council - the leadership body of Yemen's internationally recognised government - said Hadi believed in the Yemeni people's "right to a just state, freedom and human dignity."

"He led the battle to defend the republican system," al-Alimi said on X. The Government announced three days of mourning, during which flags will be flown at half-staff.

Hadi became president in 2012 after the resignation of longtime ruler Ali Abdullah Saleh during the Arab Spring uprisings. Backed by the United States and Gulf states, Hadi emerged as a compromise candidate in a one-man election meant to guide Yemen through a political transition. But his presidency soon got bogged down in unrest. (*AP*)

Jaishankar discusses ties with Cyprus President

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nicosia

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Thursday met Cyprus President Nikos Christodoulides and held wide-ranging talks on bilateral ties and the West Asia conflict. "Delighted to call on President @Christodulides of the Republic of Cyprus today. Conveyed warm greetings of President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister @narendramodi," Jaishankar said in a social media post.

"The recent State Visit saw significant outcomes, taking our partnership to its next phase. Assured the President of (a) strong follow-up. Discussed the evolving situation in West Asia/Middle East, as also India's interests in the Mediterranean," the minister said.

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar meets Republic of Cyprus President Nikos Christodoulides during the informal Gymnich meeting of the EU Foreign Affairs Ministers in Cyprus PTI

Christodoulides came to India for a three-day visit roughly a week ago. During the visit, he met Prime Minister Narendra Modi, following which the two sides signed six agreements for deeper cooperation in areas of innovation, technology, education and culture, besides agreeing to soon conclude a comprehensive partnership on migration and mobility.

Jaishankar landed in Cyprus on Wednesday to participate in an informal meeting of EU foreign ministers — popularly called the Gymnich — amid the West Asia conflict and other geopolitical issues concerning Europe and the wider region. These meetings are held periodically to discuss major geo-economic challenges, security and strategic matters.

The Gymnich meeting was held on Thursday. In the sidelines of the Gymnich meeting, Jaishankar held quick meetings with his counterparts from the Netherlands, Poland, France, Spain, Slovakia and Estonia, and Poland's Deputy Prime Minister Rados?aw Sikorski. Hours after the Gymnich meeting, Jaishankar met President Christodoulides.

EAM meets EU foreign ministers

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nicosia

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Thursday attended an informal meeting of EU foreign ministers in Cyprus and discussed "practical collaborations" and "shared interests" in the emerging multipolar order.

Jaishankar arrived in Cyprus on Wednesday to participate in the meeting being held in Limassol amid the West Asia conflict and other geopolitical issues concerning Europe and the wider region.

"Our partnership with the EU and the region continues to deepen across a wide range of domains. Discussed opportunities, practical collaborations and our shared interests in the emerging multipolar order," Jaishankar said in a social media post.

Jaishankar also called on the President of Cyprus, Nikos Christodoulides and conveyed greetings from President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

"The recent State Visit saw significant outcomes, taking our partnership to its next phase. Assured the President of a strong follow-up," Jaishankar posted on X.

India and Cyprus unveiled a five-year roadmap for defence cooperation last week during the visit of President Christodoulides to India.

Jaishankar also discussed the situation in West Asia/Middle East, as well as India's interests in the Mediterranean, with President Christodoulides.

He also held a meeting with Jose Manuel Albares, who is the foreign minister of the EU and minister of cooperation in the Spanish government, on the sidelines of the Gymnich. "Discussed further steps for our trade, technology, defence and P2P ties. Appreciate his views on ongoing global and regional developments," he said in a social media post.

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar being received as he arrives to attend the informal Gymnich meeting of the EU Foreign Affairs Ministers PTI

NSA Ajit Doval during the first International Security Forum and the 14th Meeting of High Representatives for Security Matters in Moscow, Russia PTI

No double standards in fight against terrorism: NSA Doval in Russia

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Moscow

National Security Adviser Ajit Doval called for decisive action against terrorism and said there cannot be "double standards" in the fight against it, while addressing an international security forum in Russia on Thursday, according to the Indian Embassy in Moscow.

Doval participated in the first International Security Forum and the 14th Meeting of High Representatives for Security Matters in Moscow.

"The meeting was hosted by Mr. Sergei Shoigu, Secretary of the Security Council of the Russian Federation," the embassy said in a post on X, which further said the forum deliberated on the "Challenges and Threats to International Security in the context of the Emergence of the Multipolar World".

"(The) NSA stated that there cannot be double standards in the fight against terrorism. Responsible nations have to evaluate their choices and decide whether they support sponsors of terrorism or counter them with decisive action," the embassy said.

Doval also "highlighted the urgent need for reforms in the structures and institutions set up after the end of the Second World War in 1945 to make them effective in dealing with contemporary international security threats". "The reforms must give greater representation to and factor in the views of the Global South," it said.

Australian PM hails India's economic growth

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Canberra

Anthony Albanese

Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese on Thursday said he looked forward to hosting PM Narendra Modi again soon, while describing India's growing economic importance as an "extraordinary opportunity" for the Indo-Pacific region. Addressing the parliament in Canberra, Albanese said India, which already has the largest population in the world, was set to become the third-largest economy over this decade.

"That is an extraordinary opportunity for us in our region. We are a Pacific nation, but we are also an Indian Ocean nation as well," he said.

He said the Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement, which was signed in 2022, had enhanced the trading relationship between the two countries, and that they were further drawn together through culture, education and cricket.

Albanese recalled that he had first visited India as a backpacker in 1991 and had since made two visits as prime minister. He said the best way to understand India was to travel by bus or train.

"It is a wonderful experience to see first-hand the warmth that is there. Now, likewise, I'll have the privilege of hosting Prime Minister Modi here soon, a privilege I look forward to repeating for the second time," said Albanese.

Israel strikes Beirut southern suburb ahead of crucial Washington talks

KAREEM CHEHAYEB ■ Beirut

Israel's air force carried out an airstrike on a southern suburb of the capital, Beirut, Thursday afternoon, the Israeli military said, further straining a fragile ceasefire a day ahead of crucial negotiations in Washington.

The strike hit an apartment building but it was not immediately clear who might have been targeted. Videos from the suburb of Choueifat, close to Beirut's international airport, showed white smoke billowing from a residential neighbourhood.

Tensions have been escalating in southern Lebanon, where Israeli troops have crossed the Litani River over the past days and issued a warning for residents to leave much of the area.

Israel in recent days has widened its attacks on Lebanon, some of the deadliest days since a Washington-brokered ceasefire agreement went into effect on April 17.

This was the first attack close to the Lebanese capital since May 6, where an Israeli strike killed a military official with Hezbollah's elite Radwan Forces in another southern Beirut suburb.

Overnight, the Israeli military pounded the coastal city of Tyre, Lebanon's fourth-largest city, killing at least 14 people across the south of the country in its ongoing military escalation against the Hezbollah group ahead of the Washington talks.

Among those killed in the flurry of strikes were five women and children and a Lebanese soldier. Dozens of others were wounded, according to the Lebanese Health Ministry and the State-run National News Agency.

An Israeli soldier meanwhile was killed in a Hezbollah drone attack in northern Israel, the Israeli military said.

Attacks increase ahead of Washington talks

The intensification comes after Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu announced an expansion in the Israeli military's attacks in Lebanon, apparently sparked by Hezbollah's use of fiber-optic exploding drones that have struck Israeli troops in Lebanon and reached some of Israel's northern border towns.

The Israeli military said it has launched hundreds of attacks targeting what they said were Hezbollah military assets. (*AP*)

Drones hit 3 shadow fleet tankers off Turkiye Coast

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Istanbul

Three oil tankers were attacked by drones Thursday off Turkey's Black Sea coast, a shipping agency said.

The ships all appear on Western sanctions lists as part of a "shadow fleet" exporting Russian oil and petroleum products and evading Western sanctions on Moscow because of its war in Ukraine. One was previously targeted in March. Tribeca Shipping said the Palau-flagged ship James II was sailing 80 kilometres (50 miles) north of Turkeli district in Sinop when it was attacked. It was not carrying any cargo.

The Altura and Velora, both flagged to Sierra Leone, were targeted while carrying out ship-to-ship operations in a nearby area, according to a statement from the agency cited by Turkish media. The crews of all three ships were unharmed. Turkish coast guard vessels were dispatched to assist.

Treasury officials moot $250 note featuring Trump: Report

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

The US may have a $250 currency note featuring a portrait of President Donald Trump if administration officials succeed in getting a Congressional nod for the move, according to a media report on Thursday.

The development comes little over two months after it was announced that Trump will feature on a gold coin to commemorate the nation's 250th anniversary.

On Thursday, the Washington Post reported that US Treasurer Brandon Beach and his senior adviser Mike Brown urged the staff at the Treasury Department's Bureau of Engraving and Printing (BEP) to prepare prototypes of the $250 note.

According to the US federal law, only deceased persons can be featured on currency notes. The US Congress will have to pass a new law to allow Trump's portrait to feature on a currency note.

As part of the effort, Beach provided bureau staff with mock-up designs for the note in August and September. One design showed Trump's face in the centre of the $250 note between the signatures of the president and Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, The Post reported, quoting Treasury Department employees.

The artist who designed the mock-up told The Post that he had spoken with Trump about it.

Indian Navy's Sail Training Ship (STS) INS Sudarshini arrived at Antigua after completing a trans-Atlantic passage as part of the ongoing Lokayan 26 expedition PTI

Two Indian to be honoured on International Peacekeepers Day

YOSHITA SINGH ■ United Nations

Two Indian peacekeepers will be honoured posthumously by the United Nations for their ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty on the International Day of UN Peacekeepers.

Lance Havildar Harbhajan Singh, who served with the United Nations Organisation Stabilisation Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO), and Naib Subedar Sujit Kumar Pradhan, who was deployed with the UN Mission in South Sudan (UNMISS), will be posthumously honoured by UN Secretary General Antonio Guterres with the prestigious Dag Hammarskjold Medal for their sacrifice in the line of duty.

Additionally, Guterres will present the 2025 Military Gender Advocate of the Year award to Major Abhilasha Barak of India, who serves on the UN Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL), honouring her outreach efforts with women and girls during her deployment in the West Asian nation.

The world commemorates the International Day of United Nations Peacekeepers annually on May 29, paying homage to the fallen Blue Helmets who made the ultimate sacrifice while serving in UN peacekeeping missions across the world.

The UN Headquarters in New York will observe the Day on June 5, when the Secretary-General will lay a wreath to honour the men and women who served in UN peacekeeping and lost their lives in the cause of peace, the UN said in a statement.

Guterres will then preside over a solemn ceremony at which the Dag Hammarskjold Medal will be awarded posthumously to 68 military, police and civilian peacekeepers, who paid the ultimate price in the line of duty, including 59 who died last year.

India is the second largest contributor of uniformed personnel to UN Peacekeeping.

It currently contributes more than 4,200 military and police personnel — including 155 women — to UN peace operations in Abyei, the Central African Republic, Cyprus, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Lebanon, the Middle East, Somalia, South Sudan and Western Sahara.

Nearly 180 Indian peacekeepers have made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty, the highest number by far from any troop-contributing country.

Barak will be the third recipient of the prestigious award from India, after Major Suman Gawani and Major Radhika Sen were honoured for their commendable work while serving in UN Peacekeeping missions.

Barak is serving with the Indian Battalion as the Commander of the Female Engagement Team (FET) in UNIFIL. She is also the first woman combat helicopter pilot of the Indian Army. Gawani, who had served with the UN Mission in South Sudan, was honoured with the 2019 United Nations Military Gender Advocate of the Year Award. Sen, who served with MONUSCO, received the 2023 award.

The UN General Assembly had established the International Day of UN Peacekeepers in 2002 and selected May 29 for the annual commemoration since it was the day in 1948 when the Security Council established the first UN peacekeeping operation, the United Nations Truce Supervision Organisation in the Middle East. (*PTI*)

Republicans' recent stumbles in Congress highlight difficult road

KEVIN FREKING ■ Washington

A roughly $70 billion bill to fund immigration enforcement through the remainder of President Donald Trump's term was supposed to be an easy lift for Republicans.

But progress stalled over concerns about the inclusion of White House ballroom security funding in the package and the creation of a $1.8 billion fund to finance claims of government mistreatment. The stumble has not only delayed action on a top GOP priority but also is raising questions about other parts of the party's legislative agenda, including whether Republicans can enact another catchall, party-line bill referred to in Washington parlance as "Reconciliation 3.0."

Republicans have spent recent weeks laying the groundwork for such a bill, which they hope will serve as a final sales pitch to voters going into the mid-terms.

Speaker Mike Johnson and Majority Leader Steve Scalise, both of Louisiana, have been meeting with committee and caucus chairs to screen for proposals that have strong buy-in from the rank and file. They are aiming to follow up on last summer's big tax and spending cuts bill with a measure that would increase Pentagon spending by hundreds of billions of dollars and would include cuts elsewhere to help pay for it, which they are couching as tackling government waste and fraud.

It's a high-stakes gambit in an election year. Success will reinforce the GOP's message of being able to deliver on legislative priorities. Failure will underscore some of the Republican fractures under Trump that could leave voters seeking an alternative.

Here's a look at the coming debate as Republicans hope to pass a bill before leaving for their August recess.

House Republicans sound confident

Johnson navigated the House GOP's slim majority in passing Trump's tax and spending cuts bill last summer. The vote was 218-214. At the time, Republicans could afford to lose three votes from within their ranks. They lost just two.

They'll have a thin margin of error again, but Johnson said he's even more confident of success this time around.

"It will be just as beautiful, but not as big, so it'll have less provisions and less things to get everybody to yes on," he said.

Rep Jodey Arrington, chairman of the House Budget Committee, said Republicans are just as motivated as they were last year on the tax cuts bill.

"This one, I think you'll have potentially money to support our troops in conflict," said Arrington, of Texas. "I can't imagine a Republican not wanting to support our troops and military community in a time of conflict."

The Trump administration has called on Republicans to provide USD 350 billion to defence through a reconciliation bill.

But Rep. Brendan Boyle, the lead Democrat on the House Budget Committee, said Republicans will have a more difficult path than they did with Trump's big tax and spending cuts bill. (*AP*)

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | MAY 29, 2026

PROSPECT

BCCI Secretary Devajit Lon Saikia accompanied by Jt Secretary Assam Cricket Association Rajendra Singh and CEO Pritam Mahanta called on Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma, Chief Minister of Assam, and expressed deep gratitude for his unwavering support in facilitating the development of state-of-the-art cricket infrastructure through the Assam Cricket Association to meet the growing requirements of two premier coaching centres Guwahati Cricket Coaching Centre and City Cricket Coaching Centre.

Assam Minister Rameswar Teli being felicitated by members of Assam Tea Tribe Women Association and Assam Tea Tribe Students Association

AI taskforce proposes practical exposure for BTech students

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

An industry-led AI curriculum taskforce has recommended shifting the present lecture-based teaching system for technical education to learning from real industry use cases and enhancing practical exposure of students to equip them with a better understanding of AI development, an official statement said on Thursday.

The task force has recommended a shift from the current 25-30 per cent practical exposure to 40-75 per cent, depending on the nature of the degree and the chosen specialisation by engineering students.

"Shift from lecture-based teaching to learning anchored in real industry use cases from the first semester," the task force suggested.

The recommendations of the task force were discussed during a high-level meeting held by electronics and IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw.

Participants in the meeting included Nasscom President and Cognizant Foundation director Rajesh Nambiar, Wipro Chief Operating Officer Sanjeev Jain, and representatives from Wipro and TCS.

The task force conducted a baseline study of the existing Bachelor of Technology (B Tech) computer science and allied curricula in Indian educational institutions.

The exercise was undertaken in partnership with industry experts and the National Association of Software and Service Companies (NASSCOM), the statement said.

"While the study acknowledged that AI coverage in the Indian curriculum has expanded, it identified significant gaps. These were in pedagogy, infrastructure, and practical exposure in fields such as Generative AI, Machine Learning Operations (MLOps) and foundational model development," the statement said.

The taskforce has suggested that the industry exposure should be distributed across the programme through capstone projects, end-to-end AI solution engineering, and use of low-code and no-code tools.

It has recommended multiple entry-exit options for students, offering a flexible pathway that provides a certificate after year 1, a diploma after year 2, and an advanced diploma after year 3.

The taskforce has suggested that the curriculum reform must be matched by faculty readiness, the consultation placed faculty capacity building at the centre of the proposed roadmap. It has recommended structured train-the-trainer programmes, curated course content, standardised assessment frameworks, and modernised labs in sync with current industry tools and platforms.

"Focused intervention was also recommended for engaging seasoned industry professionals as adjunct faculty. This draws on the proven model of premier business schools to bring deep practitioner expertise into the classroom," the statement said.

The meeting concluded with consensus on four immediate next steps — estimation of requirements for compute, infrastructure, faculty and learner volumes at a national scale, engagement with the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE) for formal adoption of the revamped curriculum, faculty development roadmap including industry-led training and parallel track for non-STEM disciplines.

Everyone is a priority with Vi: Vodafone Idea's veiled dig at Airtel Priority Postpaid

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Telecom firm Vodafone Idea (VI) took a veiled dig at Airtel's Priority Postpaid service across social media platforms calling subscribers to switch to its network as it gives priority to everyone. Airtel had launched "Priority Postpaid" plans on May 19, which promise consistent speed even in crowded markets for postpaid customers. The plan has triggered a debate on whether such plans violate the rule of net neutrality framework.

Airtel promises that 5G "Priority Postpaid" will provide a "fastlane" to subscribers with use of network slicing technology even during peak traffic time by dynamically separating a portion of the network for them from other categories of telecom services.

Vodafone Idea in social media posts said, "*Na Kisi ko kum Na zyada* (neither anyone gets less nor more). Sabko equal network ka vaada (promise of equal network for everyone). Strong Network Sabka Haq (everyone's right). Change to Vi."

While Airtel has pan-India 5G network, Vi has 5G network in over 110 cities.

"Everyone is a priority with Vi. That's why we're continuously strengthening our network — we have added 2,20,000+ new towers, expanded Vi 5G in 110+ cities, and AI-based self-optimising network technology that intelligently adapts to help deliver stronger connectivity — even in crowded areas," Vi said. Vi aims to spend ₹45,000 crore in capex to improve its network and remain competitive in the market.

The company is in talks with banks to raise ₹25,000 crore debt, which it plans to use for network expansion.

Kumar Mangalam Birla

Sunil Bharti Mittal

Central Bank of India well-positioned to surpass ₹5,000 cr profit in FY27: MD

Kalyan Kumar

Central Bank of India is well-positioned to reach the milestone of ₹5,000 crore annual profit during the current fiscal year after clearing the deferred tax asset, according to the bank's MD and CEO, Kalyan Kumar.

In the March quarter of FY26, the state-owned bank took a one-time hit of ₹632 crore due to the recognition of deferred tax assets at a rate of 25 per cent, as against 35 per cent. "From the current year, we are migrating to the new tax regime and it will give us additional benefit of ₹600-700 crore in our annual profit that is going to help us in bringing improvement in the bottom line," Kumar said in an interview.

Asked if the bank can cross the ₹5,000 crore milestone in FY27, he said, "The bank booked a profit of ₹4,369 crore in FY26 and ₹5,000 crore should not be any challenge for Central Bank of India (going by the current run rate)." (*PTI*)

Tata Power-DDL energises over 10,000 rooftop solar installations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (Tata Power-DDL) has energised a record 10,466 rooftop solar installations as of April 2026. This milestone reflects the unprecedented growth in rooftop solar adoption under the company's flagship initiative, project 'Suryansh'.

The company's cumulative rooftop solar capacity has now reached 160.3 MWp, reinforcing its leadership in Delhi's clean energy transition and supporting the Government's vision of clean & green energy.

Operating under the aegis of the PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana, the utility has successfully energised a record 4,375 installations till date - the highest among the Delhi DISCOMs. Of the 10,466 total connections, 8,451 are residential, turning thousands of homes into self-sustaining power plants.

From 1,803 installations and 35 MWp of installed capacity in FY2022 to achieving 10,466 installations and 160 MWp of installed capacity as of April 2026, the performance data reflects a remarkable acceleration in the adoption of rooftop solar.

FY 2025-26 emerged as the breakthrough year for rooftop solar adoption, with 5,378 new installations adding 55.75 MWp to the distributed grid — the highest annual addition in Delhi's history. Installations under PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana witnessed exponential growth, rising to 3,100 in FY 2025-26. The momentum has continued into FY 2026-27, with 394 new installations already energised in the opening month of April 2026.

In a landmark milestone for global Hindu civic and political engagement, Americans4Hindus (A4H) proudly launched its sister organisation, Britons4Hindus (B4H) in London on May 28, 2026

From left to right: Pramit Maakoday, Global President-Americans4Hindus (A4H); Kalpesh Shah, Vice President Britons4Hindus (B4H); Dr Yash Gupta, President Britons4Hindus (B4H); and Dr Romesh Japra, Founder Chairman Americans4Hindus (A4H).

DAILY SUDOKU

				3			4	
	8				2			
5	2	1	4	9				3
	4	6	3				1	
		8				6		
	9				7	4	3	
2				6	5	3	9	8
			9				6	
	6			1				

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.

SOLUTION (28.5.26)

7	8	6	1	2	5	9	3	4
3	1	2	9	8	4	7	6	5
5	9	4	7	3	6	2	1	8
1	2	7	6	5	8	3	4	9
8	4	3	2	1	9	6	5	7
9	6	5	3	4	7	8	2	1
6	5	8	4	9	3	1	7	2
4	7	1	8	6	2	5	9	3
2	3	9	5	7	1	4	8	6

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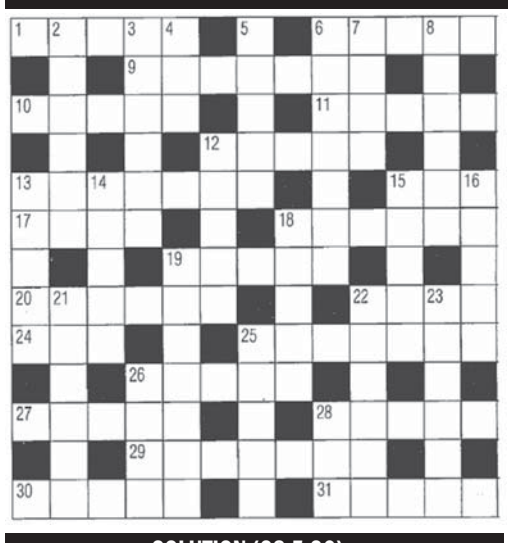
DOUBLE CROSSWORD
FRIDAY | MAY 29, 2026



ACROSS
1 Disdain a treatment for corns (5)
6 They're above awarding a runner points (5)
9 Eight in a row? (7)
10 There's always one on the other side (5)
11 Far from being a century, it's simply beyond practical availability (3,2)
12 To eat, a portion of trifle would be really nice (5)
13 Lathe operators. (There are some fine ones at the Tate) (7)
15 At fifty-one pence, a mere impertinence (3)
17 Pale as a blonde? (4)
18 A tyro without fault (6)
19 Is he out to terminate the supply? (5)
20 Consider adding water to a half of beer (6)
22 As worn during harvesting? (4)
24 She won't let you get away with it (3)
25 Goes back to cause a priest disturbed rest? (7)
26 One of many in some gallery? (5)
27 Copy a letter to "26 Down" (5)
28 Does such a girl need something to put over her? (5)
29 Imaginary invader in a train wreck (7)
30 Showing unoriginality in making black-hearted profit (5)
31 Unpleasant new head coming to stay, perhaps (5)

DOWN
2 A popular count (6)
3 Gypsy or Italian coming to a sticky end (6)
4 Refusal to discharge Victor from the navy (3)
5 Wearers of short trousers (5)
6 Rose, upset about Nat being in politics (7)
7 Granny, perhaps, starts in silence (4)
8 To Eric, maybe, it's steamy (6)
12 Such a word as one never spoke? (5)
13 Thanks to politicians, does a depressing job as a packer (5)
14 The wild heron's river (5)
15 Did it survive the slaughter? (5)
16 Our little darlings, about to start school, can be a problem (5)
18 In one version, a firm refusal (5)
19 As a flier, Alice crashed in outer Pakistan (7)
21 Trip away in the middle of the night (6)
22 Most of Hanover cannot possibly be in Germany! (6)
23 Turning taken by a tram when followed by a car? (6)
25 Damage to the stern? (5)
26 According to her, I'm wrong again (4)
28 Container of pecan nuts (3)

SOLUTION (28.5.26)

ACROSS
3, T-ouch
8, An-gr-y
10, He-ma-n
11, Tea
12, Vital
13,Simpson
15, L-Op.-es
18, Put
19, Retake
21, Benefit
22, Le-ar
23,Jive
24, Pom-pous
26, G-lower
29, Lag
31, Se-n-or
32, Petunia
34,Rid-ES
35, Lap
36, Lass-O
37, C-aper
38, Eddie

DOWN
1, An-tic
2, Wr-apper
4, O-din
5, Cha-Le-t
6, He-lot
7,Dalek
9, Gem (Meg)
12, Vote for
14, Sun
16, Par-is
17, Se-V-en
19,Ri-pp.-les
20, P-lugs
21, Baton
23, Jug-ular
24, Peri-O-d
25, Oat
27, L-e.g.-al
28, Worse
30, Pi-p-er
32, Per-I
33, Nap

Haryana has adequate fertiliser stocks for Kharif season, says KRIBHCO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Chandigarh

Despite global headwinds and supply chain disruptions arising from the ongoing West Asia crisis, Haryana has adequate fertiliser stocks to meet the needs of farmers ahead of the Kharif 2026 season and paddy sowing, a top Krishak Bharati Cooperative Limited (KRIBHCO) official said on Wednesday. KRIBHCO is a national-level multistate cooperative society under the Ministry of Cooperation, Government of India.

Demand for fertilisers peaks in the middle of May, with farmers sowing seeds over the following two months. The official firmly assured the farming community that Haryana's fertiliser inventory remains robust, secure, and fully equipped to handle the upcoming Kharif season.

Participating in a media workshop organised by the Forum for Indian Journalists on Education, Environment, Health & Agriculture (FIJEEHA) in collaboration with Alliance for Change, Transformation & Innovation (ACTION), Desh Raj Singh Vishnoi, State Marketing Manager, KRIBHCO Haryana, said the total fertiliser requirement for Haryana during the Kharif 2026 season has been estimated at around 16.20 lakh metric tonnes. Of this, the highest demand remains for urea at nearly 11 lakh metric tonnes.

The estimated requirement also includes 2.80 lakh metric tonnes of DAP, 0.95 lakh metric tonnes of SSP, 0.70 lakh metric tonnes of MOP, 0.60 lakh metric tonnes of complex fertilisers, and 0.15 lakh metric tonnes of city compost.

As per the available report, the sale of about 16.1 lakh metric tonnes of fertiliser was reported in Haryana during the Kharif 2025 season, while the sale of about 15.57 lakh metric tonnes of fertiliser was reported during the Kharif 2024 season.

"Despite global challenges and disruptions in supply chains, all stakeholders are working in coordination to ensure the timely availability of fertilisers to farmers across Haryana during the crucial Kharif season," Vishnoi said.

He further said that balanced nutrient management and uninterrupted fertiliser availability are critical for maintaining agricultural productivity in the state, particularly due to high nutrient-intensive crops such as paddy, which continue to drive strong demand for nitrogen-based fertilisers like urea.

Vishnoi further said that the Haryana government, cooperative institutions, and fertiliser companies are jointly making continuous efforts to ensure timely fertiliser supplies, promote balanced fertiliser use, and safeguard soil health.

Dish TV launches VZY entertainment ecosystem

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Dish TV India has launched 'VZY', an integrated entertainment ecosystem aimed at simplifying content consumption across streaming platforms, live TV, and smart devices. The platform brings together 29+ streaming apps, live TV channels, creator-led content, and AVOD programming into one unified experience accessible on mobile devices and Smart TVs.

The VZY ecosystem operates through two key offerings - the VZY Streaming Platform and the VZY Smart TV Ecosystem. The streaming platform focuses on seamless content discovery, reducing app-switching and search fatigue through smarter navigation and recommendations. Meanwhile, VZY Smart TVs offer a premium QLED 4K viewing experience powered by Google TV, along with Dolby Vision and Dolby Atmos support.

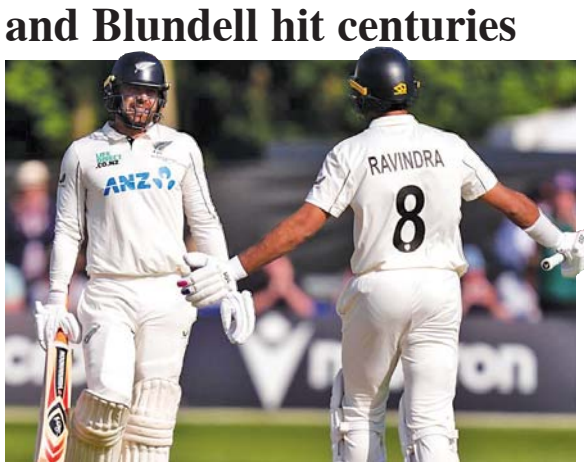
Speaking on the launch, Manoj Dobhal, CEO and Executive Director, Dish TV, said, "India's entertainment consumer doesn't want another app they want an experience that just works. VZY is built on that insight."

Sukhpreet Singh, Chief Revenue Officer, Dish TV, added, "The VZY Entertainment Ecosystem combines streaming platforms, live TV channels, and premium smart viewing under one integrated platform."

The launch is supported by a new IPL-season campaign promoting seamless entertainment discovery across devices.

BRIEFLY

NZ-Ireland Test: Ravindra and Blundell hit centuries



Rachin Ravindra and Tom Blundell hit centuries as New Zealand recovered from losing two early wickets to reach 361-5 at stumps on the opening day of its first-ever cricket Test match against Ireland on Wednesday.

Ravindra finally fell to Harry Tector's spin after scoring 121 runs. Blundell scored 142 not out.

The hosts earlier won the toss and chose to bowl in the one-off, four-day match at the Civil Service Cricket Club in Belfast.

Irish pacer Mark Adair marked the occasion by bowling New Zealand captain Tom Latham (0) off the second ball of the first over and also claimed Devon Conway (4).

Ravindra and Blundell came together at 86-4. They shared a 217-run partnership with New Zealand at 303-5 after Ravindra's dismissal. (*PTI*)

CWG 2030: Sports Ministry to engage IT Consultants in NSFs

The Sports Ministry on Thursday said it would be deploying IT Consultants in National Sports Federations (NSFs) to strengthen their digital systems for better coordination during the 2030 Commonwealth Games in Ahmedabad.

The plan is part of the broader framework of the National Sports Digital Ecosystem (NSDE). However, the ministry did not specify the timeline, criteria or the number of professionals per federation that it would be looking to hire. The Sports Ministry currently recognises over 40 national federations.

"The initiative is aimed at streamlining federation-specific digital systems and enabling more effective planning for competitions, national coaching camps, athlete participation, governance processes and real-time coordination as India prepares to build a stronger sporting ecosystem ahead of the 2030 Commonwealth Games and its long-term Olympic ambitions," Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya said on the first-time endeavour through a press release. (*PTI*)

Crystal Palace beats Rayo Vallecano 1-0

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Leipzig (Germany)

Crystal Palace didn't want to be in the third-tier Conference League and Jean-Philippe Mateta nearly left the club.

On Wednesday, it was Mateta's goal that won Palace the title.

A season which began with pleas to play in a higher competition ended with Palace's first-ever European trophy as Mateta's goal lifted his team to a 1-0 win over Rayo Vallecano in the final.

The French forward, who was close to leaving in January before a transfer collapsed, scored on a rebound in the 51st minute after Rayo goalkeeper Augusto Batalla parried Adam Wharton's long-range shot.

"I feel fantastic!... First time in Europe, we did it! Now I just want to celebrate, I just want to party," Mateta told TNT Sports.

"It's incredible. We did everything. I told you about the intensity we're going to put. I'm tired right now. I gave everything."

Along with giving outgoing coach Oliver Glasner the perfect send-off, Palace's win, which came in its first season playing in Europe, keeps English teams on track for a sweep of the three main European men's club competitions. Aston Villa won the Europa League last week and Arsenal will face Paris Saint-Germain in the Champions League final on Saturday.

From appeals to celebrations: It was a triumphant end to a season which began with Palace in court appealing in vain against being demoted from the second-tier Europa League, the competition it had originally qualified for by winning the FA Cup, in a dispute over ownership rules. Palace fans spent the season chanting against UEFA and getting fined for it.

Mateta said of the traveling Palace fans at Red Bull Arena: "I'm always with them. They support me as a player a lot, and as a team. They're always behind us and we did that for them too."

Palace's win lands it a Europa League spot for next season, much to the delight of Glasner, who said Wednesday he wanted to watch the team's progress on TV next season.

Palace fans set the tone before kickoff with a giant banner like an airport departures board.

Europa League: Boarding. Glasner announced in January he'd leave at the end of the season when his contract expires.

The Austrian has been in charge since February 2024 and led Palace to its first major trophy last season in the FA Cup. It's not clear yet where he'll go next. Glasner bid his farewell in unique style, sliding on his stomach between two lines of his players in Slip 'N Slide style ahead of the presentation.

It was the third time in the Conference League's five-season history that an English team lifted the trophy after West Ham in 2023 and Chelsea a year ago. Some Rayo fans were seen in tears at the final whistle after a first major final for a team so often in the shadow of its neighbors Real Madrid and Atletico Madrid.

A shot bouncing off both posts: Mateta's goal lit up the final after a cagey first half with no shots on target from either team.

Praggnanandhaa shocks Carlsen; Gukesh's slump deepens at Norway Chess

AJAI MASAND ■ Oslo

R Praggnanandhaa signalled a return to his menacing best with a sensational victory over world Number 1 Magnus Carlsen, outplaying the Norwegian great to claim three full points, while reigning world champion D Gukesh continued his worrying slide with another disappointing result at the Norway Chess tournament.

Carlsen may not have looked invincible in this year's edition, with rivals increasingly exposing rare chinks in his game. But defeating the seven-time champion on home soil remains one of the toughest feats in world chess.

Praggnanandhaa, carrying the confidence from his recent triumph at the Superbet Chess Classic Romania in Bucharest, held his nerve on Wednesday night against the five-time classical world champion in a tense time scramble to climb to second place with 4.5 points.

In a rare sight, Carlsen is languishing at the bottom of the six-player standings with just 1.5 points. The victory also marked Praggnanandhaa's second classical win over the Norwegian legend at Norway Chess, having stunned him memorably during the 2024 edition.

However, it was Firouzja who continued to light up the tournament with his red-hot form, defeating D Gukesh in Armageddon after their classical game ended in a draw to collect 1.5 points and surge to 7.5 overall.

Firouzja, still carrying the effects of the injury he suffered at the Superbet Chess Classic Romania, left the venue in a wheelchair and wearing a moon boot after another dramatic outing. Playing in obvious discomfort, with his injured right leg awkwardly propped up on a chair and barely able to move, Firouzja showed that pain can be overcome when the target is firmly in sight.

Gukesh later admitted he had been completely absorbed in the game but could not convert his chances into a win against the Frenchman, before hurrying out of the venue and offering little insight into the alarming dip in form that has left him fourth on 3.5 points.

Meanwhile, Firouzja's remarkable winning streak continued as he escaped from a losing position before prevailing in Armageddon after a wild and chaotic time scramble.

Gukesh's struggles come at an awkward time for the reigning world champion, who is preparing for his world title clash later this year against challenger Javokhir Sindarov. (*PTI*)

'Sports cut from 2032 Brisbane Games could return in future'

OC President Kirsty Coventry

GRAHAM DUNBARAP
■ Lausanne (Switzerland)

Sports and medal events cut from the 2032 Brisbane Olympics program will have a path to return at future Summer Games, IOC President Kirsty Coventry told sports leaders.

Coventry's reassurance on Wednesday to the annual meeting of Summer Games sports bodies came after she warned in February of "uncomfortable" talks ahead to make future Olympic hosting more efficient.

The International Olympic Committee aims to finalise within months the list of sports on the Brisbane program that Coventry previously told their leaders will be fewer than the 36 being played at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. "There is a path (back), it's not just an end," the IOC president told *The Associated Press* on Wednesday on the sidelines of the assembly of the summer sports group known as ASOIF.

Brisbane also could have fewer than the 353 medal events being competed for at Los Angeles.

"I know that not everyone will be happy," Coventry acknowledged to ASOIF members Wednesday, adding "the goal is not to destroy any sport." Coventry also met Tuesday with ASOIF members and assured them "we don't have specific numbers" as targets for the sports and events program for Brisbane. The most important metric shapes to be the number of venues needed as the IOC looks to manage costs for hosts. "The cost and complexity comes when you start adding additional venues for single purpose events," Coventry told the AP.

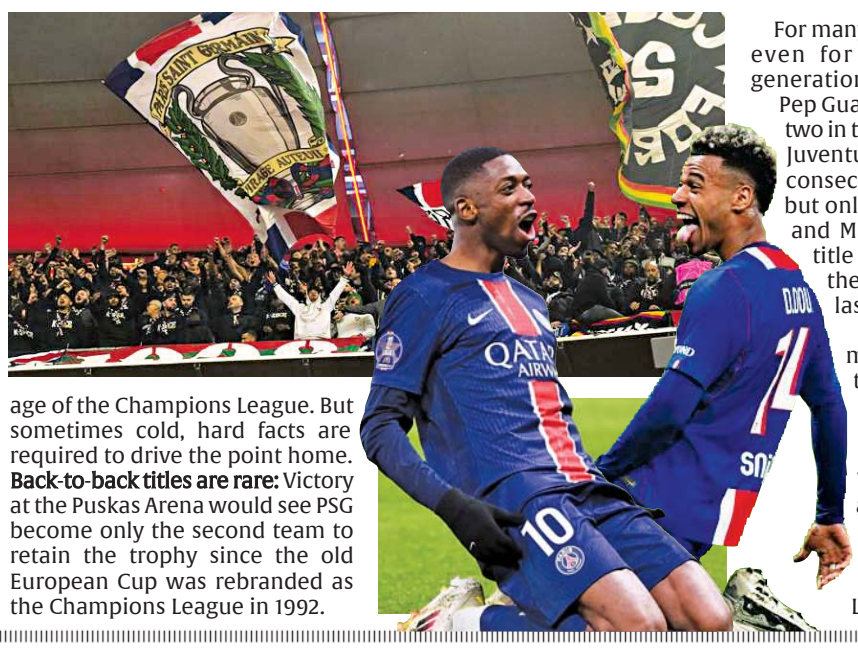
"That's where we need to look and say: How could we change that?" A major step toward streamlining the program for Brisbane and beyond is a June 24 meeting of the full IOC membership in Lausanne that should agree on a process for evaluating sports and events.

A list of sports at Brisbane could be confirmed in December, with a longer timeline into 2029 to confirm the detailed program of medal events. The 36 sports in Los Angeles is up from just 26 at the 2012 London Olympics, and ASOIF President Ingmar De Vos later acknowledged, "It has grown too much and needs to be brought back into proportion."

Sports at risk?: Modern pentathlon has long been seen as vulnerable to losing its historic Olympic status, while canoe slalom has a very specific venue demand. (*AP*)

Paris Saint-Germain on the brink of greatness in the Champions League

JAMES ROBSONAP ■ Budapest



The Champions League, the most important continental trophy in European club soccer, is the prize at stake in the final at Budapest on Saturday. For Paris Saint-Germain and Luis Enrique, it doesn't end there.

On the line against Arsenal for the defending champion and its serial-winning Spanish coach is the chance to stake its claim to be considered the greatest team of this era.

"I arrived at the club thinking, My objective is to make history,' and we have indeed made history," Luis Enrique said. "We want to keep writing the story because we believe there's still more there for us to achieve."

PSG is already in the conversation when it comes to judging the finest teams to have won the title in the age of the Champions League. But sometimes cold, hard facts are required to drive the point home.

Back-to-back titles are rare: Victory at the Puskas Arena would see PSG become only the second team to retain the trophy since the old European Cup was rebranded as the Champions League in 1992.

For many years it didn't happen even for teams regarded as generationally great.

Pep Guardiola's Barcelona won two in three years. AC Milan and Juventus each reached three consecutive finals in the 90s but only won one apiece. Ajax and Manchester United took title defenses all the way to the final only to fall at the last hurdle.

Real Madrid — winner of more European titles than any other club — finally bucked that trend, winning three in a row from 2016-18. What seemed unthinkable before and since would suddenly seem a very real target for PSG if it prevails on Saturday. Luis Enrique would join Guardiola and Zinedine Zidane as a three-time Champions League winner. Not that his motivation is based on personal accolades.

PSG's ascent: Having won the Champions League with Barcelona, Luis Enrique has produced a PSG team that has set the benchmark in Europe over the past two seasons. It combines attacking flair with an energy and tenacity that appears to be moving the sport in a new direction. A team that plays with a high risk of being exposed defensively for the ultimate reward.

At its best, PSG seems unstoppable, with last year's 5-0 rout of Inter Milan in the final the most dominant in the tournament's history. And with a squad that has an average age of under 24, the potential is there for it to dominate for years to come. (*AP*)

Mandaviya to review national games preparations in 3-day Meghalaya tour

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya will chair a review meeting for the 39th National Games in Meghalaya and also inaugurate an Integrated Multipurpose Indoor Sports Complex in Shillong during a three-day visit to the North-Eastern state starting Friday.

The Host State Contract for the National Games to be held in March next year will be signed with Meghalaya in the presence of senior dignitaries and representatives of the Indian Olympic Association. Mandaviya will also participate in a series of programmes related to youth affairs, sports infrastructure development, and review centrally-sponsored schemes in the state.

During the visit, the Minister will attend a Chintan Shivir organised by Department of Youth Affairs. Meghalaya Sports and Youth Affairs Minister Shakliar Warjri and other senior officials will also be present.

Mandaviya will inaugurate the Integrated Multipurpose Indoor Sports Complex in Shillong on Saturday along with Chief Minister Conrad K Sangma.

"The Integrated Multipurpose Indoor Sports Complex, being developed at a project cost of ₹132.9 crore, is designed as a modern multi-functional sports facility capable of hosting disciplines such as basketball, badminton and volleyball, besides other indoor sporting events," the ministry stated. The complex is also a key venue for the National Games and will include integrated infrastructure such as multipurpose halls, auditorium, banquet facilities,etc.

The review meeting of the Games preparations will include presentations and discussions involving officials from Meghalaya and representatives from other North-Eastern States.

India U-18 hockey teams eye positive start in Asia Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kakamigahara (Japan)

Guided by senior stalwarts like Sardar Singh and Rani Rampal, India's Under-18 teams for boys and girls will be aiming to make their recent high-intensity training count when they take the field in the Asia Cup starting on Friday. The boys team is being guided by former men's captain Sardar and Rajnish Mishra, the girls' team is being helmed by former women's team captain Rani Rampal.

After weeks of intensive preparation camps and valuable exposure matches against Australia in Bhopal, both teams will hope to make a strong impact at the continental tournament against some of Asia's finest young talent.

The Indian U-18 boys team, led by forward Ketan Kushwaha, heads into the tournament following a month-long national coaching camp at the Udhav Das Mehta (Bhai Ji) Central Centre at SAI, Bhopal, under the guidance of coaches Sardar Singh and Rajnish Mishra. As part of their preparations, the side played a four-match series against the visiting Australian U-18 team, registering one win and one loss, while two matches ended in draws.

India have been placed in Pool A alongside hosts Japan, Korea, Chinese Taipei and Kazakhstan in the boy's competition. The Indians will open their campaign against Kazakhstan on May 29 before taking on Japan (May 31), Korea (June 1) and Chinese Taipei (June 3).

Pool B comprises Malaysia, Pakistan, Bangladesh and China. The top two teams from each pool will qualify for the semifinals scheduled on June 5, while the final will take place on June 6.

Speaking ahead of the tournament opener, India boys' team captain Ketan Kushwaha said, "The team is feeling confident and excited ahead of the Asia Cup. The camp in Bhopal and the matches against Australia helped us improve a lot as a unit and understand the areas we need to work on. We know every match in the tournament will be competitive, but the squad is motivated to give its best and make the country proud."

The Indian U-18 girls' team, captained by Sweety Kujur, also enters the tournament after a productive national camp in Bhopal under the guidance of Rani.

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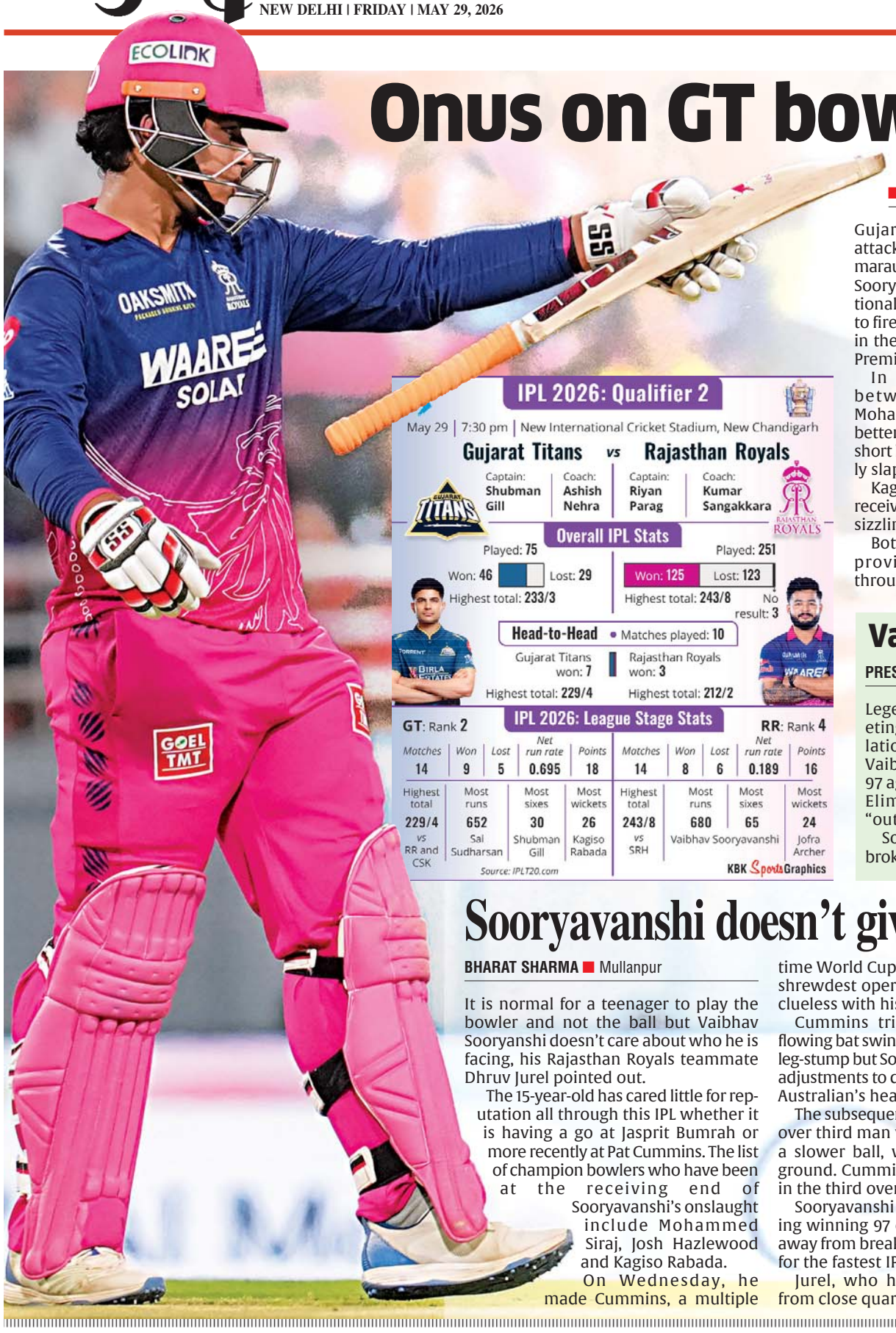


Onus on GT bowlers to stop Sooryavanshi

BHARAT SHARMA ■ Mullanpur

Gujarat Titans' potent pace attack will have to stop the marauding boy wonder Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and their traditional-minded top-order needs to fire against Rajasthan Royals in the Qualifier 2 of the Indian Premier League on Friday.

In the previous outing between the two teams, Mohammed Siraj did get the better of Sooryavanshi with the short ball after being disdainfully slapped for a six.

Kagiso Rabada too was at the receiving end of Sooryavanshi's sizzling shot-making.

Both Siraj and Rabada have provided the early breakthroughs through this tournament for GT, but the 15-year-old has raised the bar with an awe-inducing 97 off 29 balls in the Eliminator against Sunrisers Hyderabad. It is expected to be another belter of a surface here and Sooryavanshi would be looking to smash every ball out of the park, caring little for the bowler's stature like he punished Pat Cummins.

The batting sensation has been dismissed off a short ball multiple times and probably that is one area the GT bowlers would like to target judiciously.

Royals, on a roll at the moment, rely heavily on Sooryavanshi and Jofra Archer. Both the X-factor players effectively won them the Eliminator against Sunrisers here.

Yashasvi Jaiswal has been totally overshadowed by Sooryavanshi's sensational ball striking at the top of the order.

Dhuv Jurel has done well at number three but he has been benefited by the head start provided by Sooryavanshi.

By captain Riyan Parag's own admission, Royals should have reached 260 on Wednesday but had an inexplicable collapse in the death overs. They would surely want to improve on their finishing skills. Titans, on the other hand, get another shot at reaching the IPL final after getting a pasting at the hands of Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

Titans bank heavily on their top three — Shubman Gill, Sai Sudharsan and Jos Buttler. If they don't deliver, RR really don't have the batting depth to turn it around. If they end up conceding a 250-plus total like they did against RCB, it puts additional pressure on Gill and Sudharsan, who are highly consistent but can't go hammer and tongs from ball one.

The bowling has been their biggest strength but it faltered big time in the death overs in Dharamsala where RCB skipper Rajat Patidar took the game away from Gill and Co. Titans would also need a big improvement in the fielding department. (*PTI*)

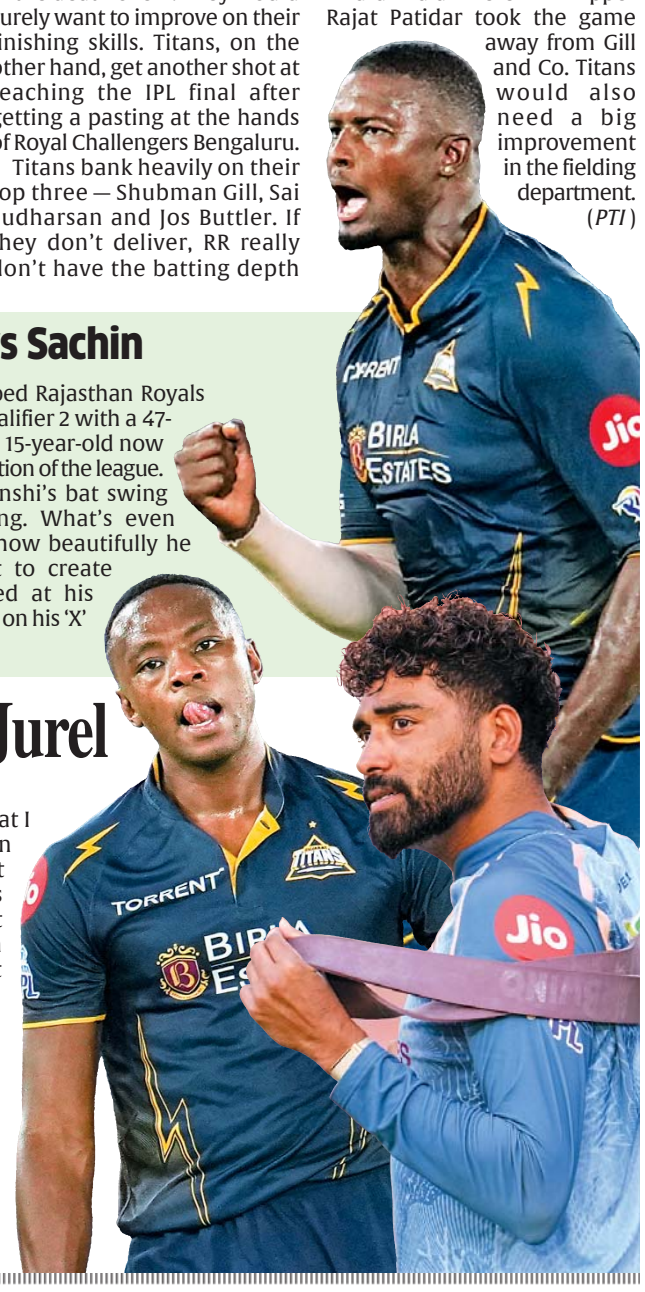
Vaibhav's bat swing outstanding, says Sachin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mullanpur

Legendary Sachin Tendulkar led the cricketing world's outpouring of awe and adulation after teenage batting sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi smashed a 29-ball 97 against Sunrisers Hyderabad in the IPL Eliminator, lauding the left-hander's "outstanding bat swing."

Sooryavanshi's blitz, during which he broke Chris Gayle's record of most sixes (59) in an IPL edition, helped Rajasthan Royals march into the IPL Qualifier 2 with a 47-run win over SRH. The 15-year-old now has 65 sixes in this iteration of the league.

"Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's bat swing has been outstanding. What's even more remarkable is how beautifully he clears his front foot to create room for balls aimed at his legs," Tendulkar wrote on his 'X' account.



Sooryavanshi doesn't give a damn about bowler: Jurel

BHARAT SHARMA ■ Mullanpur

It is normal for a teenager to play the bowler and not the ball but Vaibhav Sooryanshi doesn't care about who he is facing, his Rajasthan Royals teammate Dhruv Jurel pointed out.

The 15-year-old has cared little for reputation all through this IPL whether it is having a go at Jasprit Bumrah or more recently at Pat Cummins. The list of champion bowlers who have been at the receiving end of Sooryavanshi's onslaught include Mohammed Siraj, Josh Hazlewood and Kagiso Rabada.

On Wednesday, he made Cummins, a multiple time World Cup winner and among the shrewdest operators in the game, look clueless with his barrage of sixes.

Cummins tried to curtail his free flowing bat swing by bowling full into the leg-stump but Sooryavanshi made instant adjustments to dispatch the ball over the Australian's head.

The subsequent short ball was slashed over third man while the next delivery, a slower ball, was smoked down the ground. Cummins had run out of ideas in the third over.

Sooryavanshi ended up with a matching winning 97 off 29 balls, just one hit away from breaking Chris Gayle's record for the fastest IPL hundred.

Jurel, who has seen Sooryavanshi from close quarters, made his observations about the wonder kid.

"The best thing about Vaibhav that I have noticed is that he doesn't plan anything because he practices a lot and he always backs himself. That's what he does every time he goes out and plays. The best thing about him is that he backs himself. He doesn't even have a shadow of doubt that 'I am not able to do it'."

Jurel, himself in top form with six fifties in the competition, mentioned another aspect of his younger colleague's batting that makes him one of a kind.

What Sooryavanshi is doing is freakish: Even Sunrisers Hyderabad were to quick to applaud his special knock in the Eliminator. (*PTI*)

India lose to Jamaica in Unity Cup semis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The Indian men's national football team crashed out in the semifinal of the Unity Cup 2026 after suffering a 0-2 defeat against Jamaica at The Valley, London. On Wednesday night, Courtney Clarke's stunning early strike in the eighth minute and Kaheim Dixon's solo effort in the 78th minute ensured Jamaica's entry into the final.

India will face Zimbabwe, who went down to Nigeria in the first semifinal on Tuesday, in the third-place play-off on Saturday, while Nigeria will meet Jamaica in a repeat of last year's final.

The match marked several important individual moments. Noufal PN and Ricky Shabong made their senior national team debuts, while Edmund Lalrindika was handed his first-ever start for India.

Before the Blue Tigers, playing their first match on British soil since 2002, could settle into rhythm, Jamaica struck with ruthless efficiency.

A quick Jamaican counter sliced through India's shape in the eighth minute, forcing Gurpreet Singh Sandhu into a sharp save from a tight angle.

Not keen to replace anyone: Harsh on maiden call-up

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Nagpur

Rookie spin bowling all-rounder Harsh Dubey would like to create his own identity while representing India rather than just being dubbed as a "replacement" for any seasoned senior cricketer.

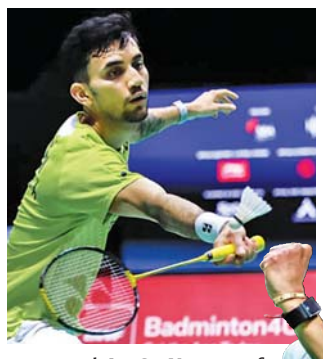
The 23-year-old Vidarbha cricketer, one of the most promising all-rounder from the stable of left-arm orthodox spinners and left-handed batters, has got a maiden call-up for both one-off Test and three-match ODI series against Afghanistan next month.

National selection committee chairman Ajit Agarkar hinted that they are looking at Dubey as a future prospect while strictly maintaining that Ravindra Jadeja has been only rested for this Afghanistan Test match.

"This opportunity has helped me grow a lot as a player. I am not looking to replace anyone. I worked hard for this opportunity and my hard work is the reason why I am here today. Instead of thinking too much about the future, my focus is entirely on giving my best on any given day," Dubey told PTI.

Sindhu, Lakshya sail into Singapore Open quarters, Prannoy out

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Singapore



Double Olympic medallist PV Sindhu and Lakshya Sen advanced to the quarterfinals with contrasting wins, while HS Prannoy bowed out after paying the price for a string of errors in the closing stages of the $1 million Singapore Open Super 750 badminton tournament here on Thursday.

Sindhu, a former world champion, took just 37 minutes to get the better of Riko Gunji of Japan 21-9 21-12 in her second round match.

But a stern test awaits Sindhu as she is pitted against top seed An Se Young of Korea in the last-eight round. Sindhu has never beaten the Olympic champion but lost eight times with the last defeat being at the China Open last year.

Lakshya Sen, a 2021 world championship bronze winner, also progressed to the quarterfinals after second seed Kunlavut Viditsarn, an opponent against whom he had a 4-8 record, retired after just two points due to a back problem.

The Almora shuttler will now take on Japan's Koki Watanabe next.

If you don't play Vaibhav in T20Is now, when will you give him chance: Gavaskar

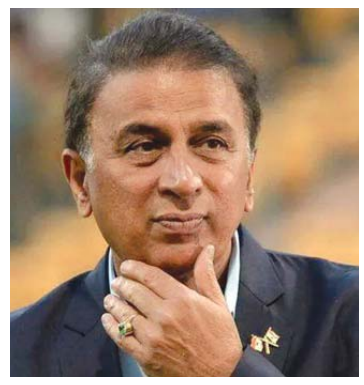
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Sunil Gavaskar believes that teen prodigy Vaibhav Sooryavanshi is "God's gift to Indian cricket" and needs to be picked for their upcoming white ball tour of England even if it comes at the cost of dropping an established top order batter from the playing eleven.

Gavaskar, who saw Sooryavanshi's astonishing 29-ball-97 against Sunrisers Hyderabad in the IPL Eliminator, is floored by the chubby-cheeked boy wonder's fearless strokeplay, especially the way he launched Pat Cummins for a straight six.

"2026 will be remembered as Vaibhav Sooryavanshi Year. He (Sooryavanshi) is ready to play T20 International cricket," Gavaskar said in a YouTube show Sports Tak.

"For England away T20 series, he will be selected. I mean he deserves to be selected after this brilliant show. If you don't give him chance after this performance, when will you give him chance?



The former India skipper is quite sure that age shouldn't be a factor as he is hitting all and sundry at the ripe age of 15.

"Don't go by his age. He is hitting those bowlers who are older than him. In fact at 15, he is hitting bowlers with 15 years of international experience. Just look at his fearless approach," Gavaskar said.

However, to accommodate Sooryavanshi in the playing XI, the team think tank would have to leave out either Abhishek Sharma or Sanju Samson.

"Yes there will be headache as to whom you should drop. But it is a happy headache to have. When your option is whom to drop, that speaks of your country's depth of talent.

"I think he (Sooryavanshi) will be kept in squad of 15 or 16 but whether he will be in 11 or not can be decided later. But the experience he will gain in that dressing room will be priceless," Gavaskar added.

For Gavaskar, a boy who hits straight sixes is anything but a slogger.

Radhir a natural shooter, good human being: Moraad Ali Khan

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Former India shooter Moraad Ali Khan paid rich tributes to veteran sports administrator Randhir Singh, terming him as a "natural shooter and a good human being".

Singh died at his New Delhi residence on Wednesday after battling age-related ailments, marking the end of an era in the country's sporting landscape on which he left a lasting impact in varied roles. He was 79 and had undergone hospitalisation for several days before breathing his last. He is survived by his wife Vinita and three daughters — Mahima, Sunaina and Rajeshwari, who is also a shooter.

Arjuna awardee and a gold medallist at the 1996 Manchester Commonwealth Games, Khan visited Randhir's Shanti farmhouse here on Wednesday to pay his last respects.

"He was a phenomenal and natural shooter, he never used to practice like everybody else used to do. Whenever he used to be on the range, he used to be focused and he used to finish the task," Khan told PTI.

"He had that killer instinct. When he needed to perform at will, he used to perform and that is a sign of a champion."

Recalling Singh and his achievements, Khan said: "He was the first gold medallist in shooting at the Asian Games, a phenomenal achievement at that time because there were not many facilities or government support, unlike what these youngsters get today. We were in the same team. We created a record also. We created an Asian record. But unfortunately, he stopped shooting after that. It was only for the Asian Games in Hiroshima that he was part of the team.

Bengal retain Laxmi Ratan Shukla as head coach

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

Cricket Association of Bengal has retained Laxmi Ratan Shukla as the head coach of the state Ranji Trophy team and roped in former Maharashtra batter Surendra Bhave as his deputy for the 2026-27 domestic season.

The CAB had invited applications for a broader set of coaching roles on April 24, including that of the head coach, fuelling talks that the association might look beyond Shukla, who has been coaching Bengal since 2022.

"To ensure the highest standards of excellence and transparency, an independent screening panel comprising distinguished former international and first-class cricketers — Arun Lal, Devang Gandhi and Kalyan Choudhury — was to screen and shortlist the candidates," the CAB said in a statement.

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